

ROBERTO DE ZERBI: THE MASTER OF TIMING

GUIDE TO UNDERSTANDING AND COACHING DE ZERBI'S IN-POSSESSION STYLE OF PLAY

40 TACTICAL PRACTICES



PHASE OF PLAY

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ROBERTO DE ZERBI: THE MASTER OF TIMING

"Roberto De Zerbi is one of the most influential managers in the last 20 years. The way his team plays is unique. Brighton are the masters of passing the ball to a man who is free, but also knowing when to pass the ball. They know how to move at the right time." - Pep Guardiola

Pep Guardiola's high praise for Roberto De Zerbi underscores the significant impact De Zerbi has had on football, particularly through his tenure at Brighton. Guardiola, himself a highly influential figure in modern football, acknowledging De Zerbi in such terms is a testament to the Italian's innovative approach to the game. The key aspects highlighted by Guardiola—team play, uniqueness, and the ability to pass the ball effectively—reflect on De Zerbi's mastery over the tactical elements of football.

Roberto De Zerbi's style of play at Brighton has captivated many football fans worldwide due to its dynamic, attacking nature, and emphasis on possession-based football that is both aesthetically pleasing and effective. Drawing from the principles that have defined some of the most successful teams in modern football, De Zerbi has implemented a system that prioritizes control of the game through sustained possession, high pressing, and fluid movement.

Both Guardiola and De Zerbi are disciples of Positional play, but their interpretations differ. Guardiola's emphasis on controlled progression and optimal positioning embodies a chess-like strategic approach. In contrast, De Zerbi's penchant for verticality and rapid third-man combinations mirrors a high-paced, thrilling game of checkers. These distinct interpretations not only highlight the versatility of the positional play philosophy but also underscore the beautiful intricacies and nuances that make football a perpetual tactical spectacle.

The "uniqueness" of De Zerbi's style that Guardiola highlights is multifaceted. It is rooted in a philosophy that values the ball not just as a tool to score goals but as the centerpiece of a larger, more intricate game of spatial manipulation and timing. This philosophy manifests in Brighton's gameplay, which is marked by an ability to pass the ball with purpose and precision, constantly seeking the free man, and exploiting spaces with meticulously timed movements. This requires players to possess not only technical proficiency but also a high level of tactical intelligence and spatial awareness, attributes that De Zerbi has successfully instilled in his team.

The emphasis on knowing "when to pass the ball" and "how to move at the right time" underlines a deeper tactical acumen. It's not merely about possession for possession's sake but about using possession as a weapon to disorganize the opponent's structure, create opportunities, and dictate the tempo of the game. This strategic use of possession and movement sets De Zerbi's Brighton apart, showcasing a level of tactical maturity and execution that resonates with Guardiola's own philosophies.

The impact of De Zerbi's tactics extends beyond the confines of Brighton's performances. It represents a broader movement within football towards tactical flexibility, creativity, and the integration of high-tempo, attacking football with strategic, possession-based play. In this light, Guardiola's praise is not just recognition of De Zerbi's success at Brighton but an acknowledgment of his contribution to the evolution of football tactics. As the game continues to evolve, the innovative approaches of managers like De Zerbi will remain central to the discourse on tactical development, inspiring future generations of coaches and players alike.

THREE PILLARS OF DE ZERBI'S PHILOSOPHY

"The most important principle is to command the game, to control it. This is done through knowledge, reading situations, and choices. Deciding well is a consequence of knowing how to read the situation well." - Roberto De Zerbi

Roberto De Zerbi's quote encapsulates a profound understanding of football, positioning the ability to command and control the game as its most crucial aspect. This principle goes beyond the physical elements of the sport, delving into the intellectual and strategic dimensions that underpin success on the pitch.

There are three fundamentals within De Zerbi's philosophy:

- Controlling possession: At the core of De Zerbi's strategy is the concept of controlling possession. This isn't possession for the sake of it but a deliberate, methodical approach to dominate the game. By rationally occupying space, De Zerbi's teams spread the opposition thin, creating gaps that can be exploited. The use of short third-man passing combinations is central to this strategy, as it allows for quick, incisive plays that can break defensive lines. Player spatial awareness is critical; athletes under De Zerbi are adept at recognizing when to pass and when to drive forward with the ball, showcasing a level of decision-making that is both instinctive and deeply ingrained through rigorous training. Technical ability underpins this philosophy, ensuring players are equipped to execute De Zerbi's vision on the pitch.
- Manipulating time: De Zerbi strives to control the opponents by controlling the timing. He wants to be the one deciding (over the opponent) when to hold (or even completely stop) and when to move with speed. It frustrates the opponents and sooner or later they start pressing, which disrupts their defensive shape and opens up spaces which didn't exist a moment ago. And that is the moment De Zerbi's team will spring into action, penetrating space with vertical combinations and quick movement. And so, by manipulating time, cycling through a different rhythms, De Zerbi's teams aiming to achieve a complete control of the game. Their rhythm on the ball forces you to play on their terms. This system has proved not only spectacular but also very effective, it provides the attacking players with a lot of space, it's almost like always playing on the counter-attack. And that's resulting in his teams creating not just a lot of chances, but also high quality chances (in 2022/23 season De Zerbi's Brighton took the most shots in the Premier League). When Brighton lose the ball, they implement an aggressive man to man high press with the aim of reducing opponent's time on the ball and actively win the ball in advanced areas (in the 2022/23 season created the most shots from the high turnovers), adding another dimension to this possession machine.
- Collective unity: It's one thing to create a theory of football but it's quite another to make it a reality. The execution of such a complex and nuanced tactical philosophy requires more than just theoretical understanding; it necessitates a profound collective unity. De Zerbi's hands-on approach in training, where he actively participates in drills, serves as a direct method of imparting his tactical knowledge and vision. His involvement is not just instructional but also inspirational, showcasing his passion, ambition, and commitment to excellence. This close-knit relationship between coach and players fosters an environment where the whole team is synchronized in purpose and action, making De Zerbi's tactical philosophy a lived reality on the pitch.

Between possession rhythm, defensive aggression and collective unity, De Zerbi has created a brand of football that is exceptionally dynamic. This blend of positional discipline, passing automation and remarkable use of time is uniquely "De Zerbian", and the fact it has been implemented successfully at the elite level is a monumental achievement.

THIRD MAN: THE MOST IMPORTANT PRINCIPLE

“Third man is impossible to defend” - Pep Guardiola

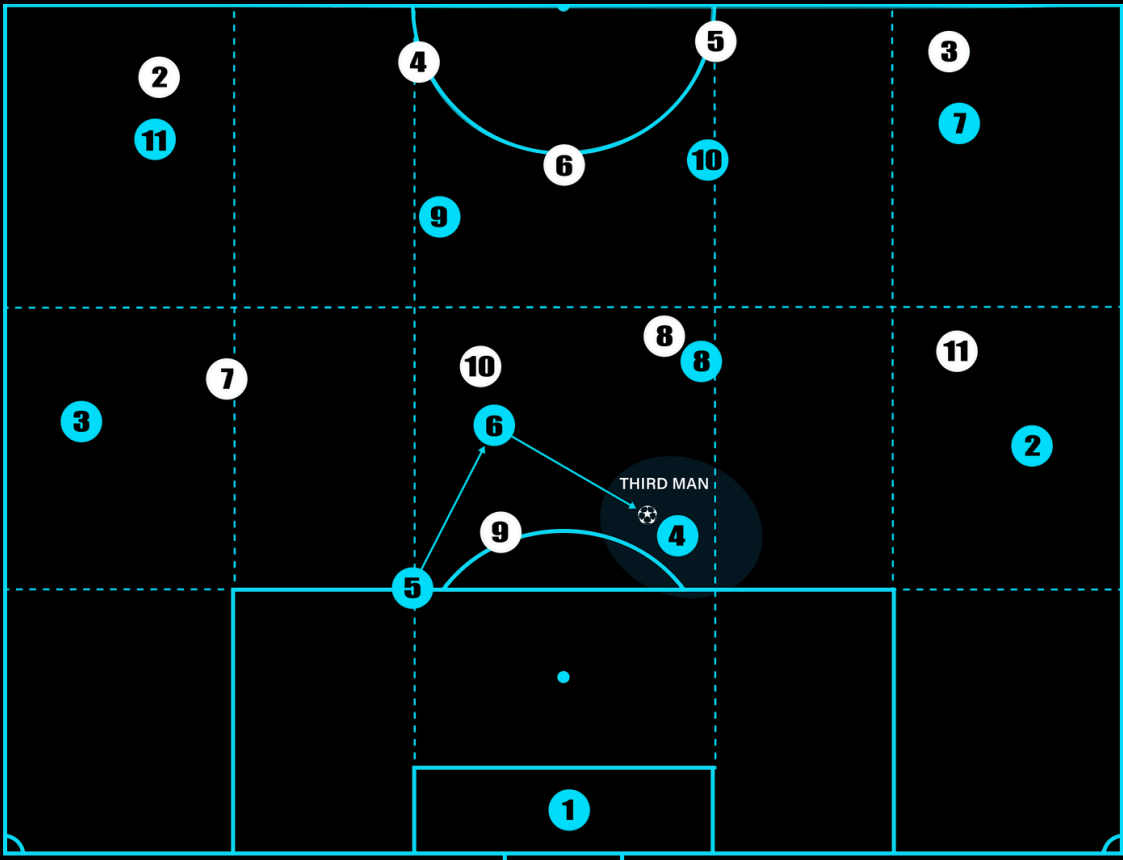
Third man is a universal tactic, grounded in creating passing triangles to facilitate ball movement and disorganize the opposition. The third man concept refers to the player who receives the ball after it has been played between two others, exploiting the space created by the movement and positioning of his teammates and the opposition. De Zerbi's emphasis on this strategy elevates it from a simple passing mechanism to a comprehensive style of play.

In De Zerbi's system, the implementation of third man concepts throughout the build-up play is not just about moving the ball forward; it's about creating a fluid, dynamic system of play that constantly offers passing options and angles. By integrating this approach across different areas of the pitch—between midfield and center-backs, among pivots, and from forwards to pivots—De Zerbi crafts a style that is predicated on anticipation, intelligence, and spatial awareness. His teams are trained to think two steps ahead, focusing on the second pass rather than the immediate one, which makes the play harder to predict and defend against.

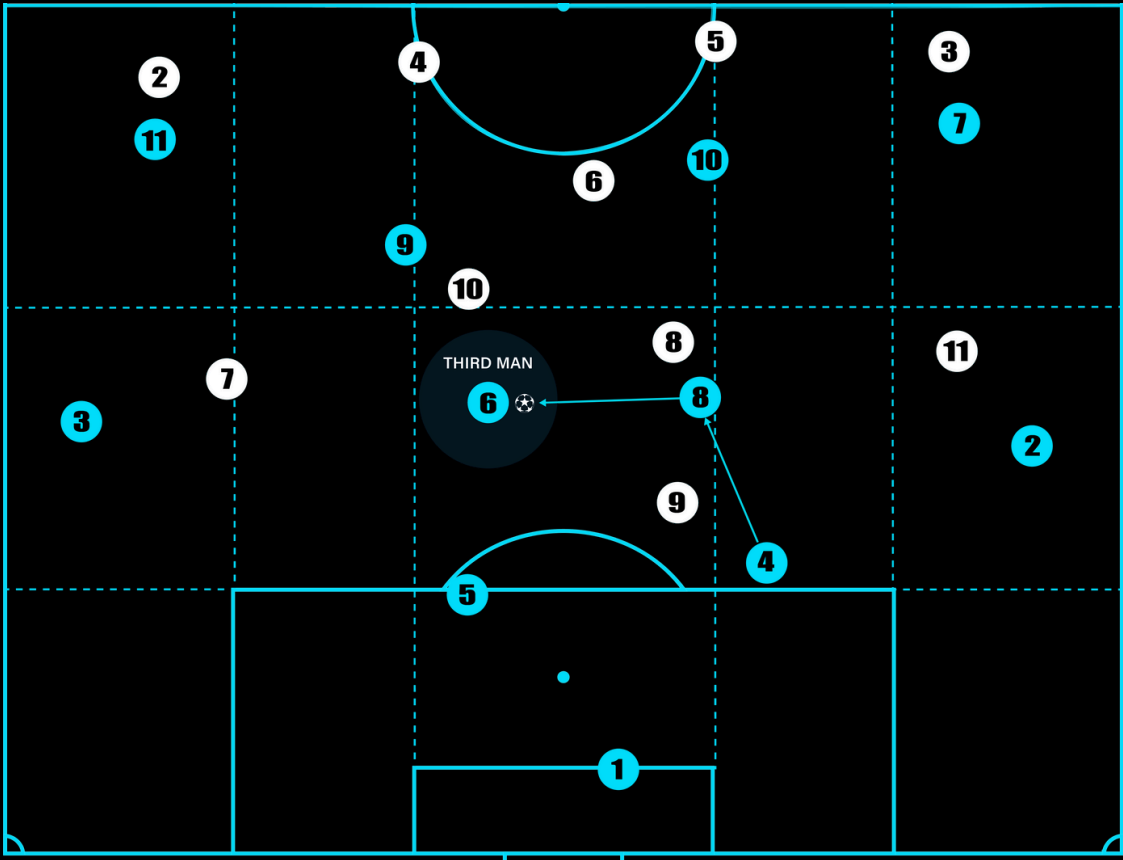
The third man often positions himself in spaces that are hard to defend, forcing the opposition to make difficult decisions—whether to step out and mark or to hold their line. This moment of indecision creates opportunities for De Zerbi's team to exploit spaces behind the opposition's defensive lines. De Zerbi's approach requires constant movement and positional rotation from his players. The third man concept encourages players to move off the ball to create triangles and provide passing options, enhancing the team's fluidity. This movement creates a dynamic and unpredictable attacking play that can disorient opponents and open up spaces on the field.

This approach requires players with high tactical acuity, technical skill, and an intuitive understanding of their teammates' movements. The success of this strategy hinges on the players' ability to read the game and execute these passes with precision and timing. When done correctly, it not only breaks through lines of pressure but also creates numerical advantages in key areas of the pitch, making it difficult for opponents to apply effective pressure or maintain defensive organization.

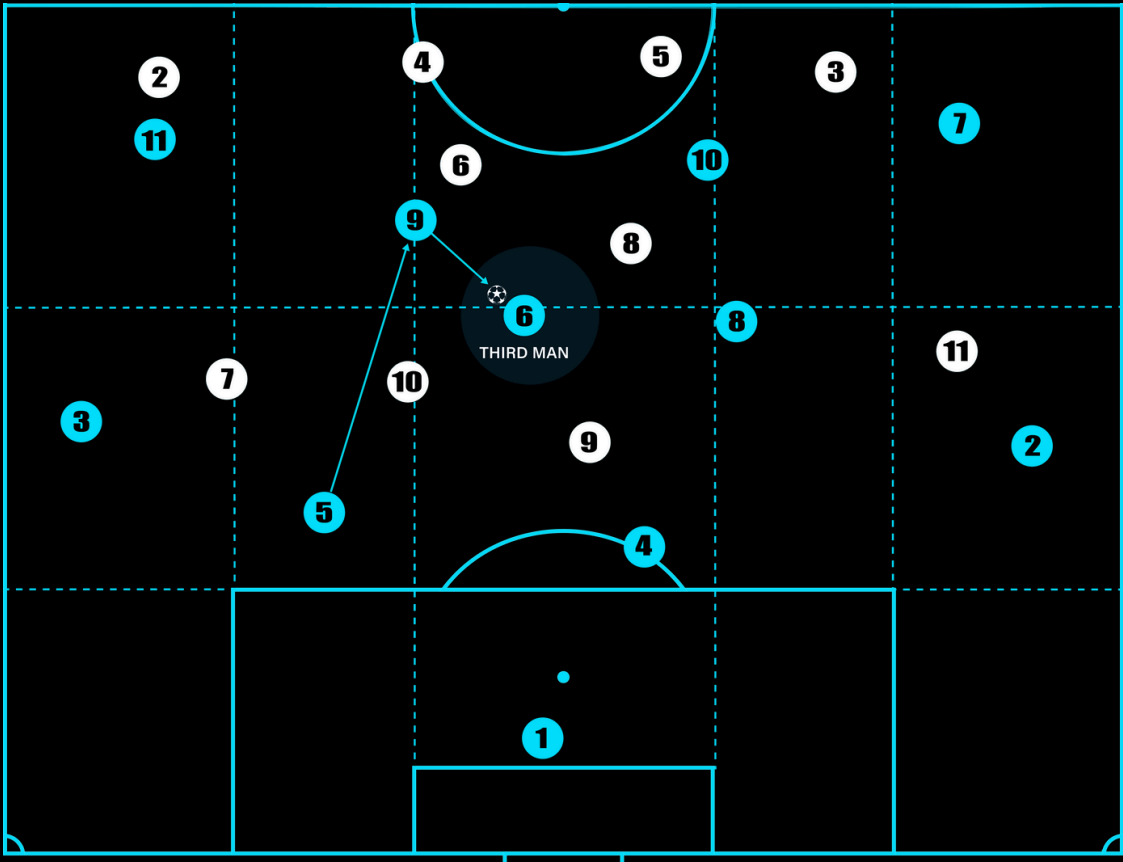
The challenge for teams facing a De Zerbi-coached side is in disrupting this intricate web of passes without sacrificing their defensive shape or allowing space to open up elsewhere on the pitch. It requires disciplined pressing, intelligent positional play, and, crucially, the ability to adapt to the fluidity and unpredictability of De Zerbi's tactical system.



Frequent third man pattern 1: CB plays into pivot, however, pivot is under-pressure to turn and plays to a second CB, who has space and is facing the play.



Frequent third man pattern 2: CB plays into pivot, however, pivot is under-pressure to turn and plays to a second pivot, who has space and is facing the play.



Frequent third man pattern 3: CB plays into forward, however, forward is under-pressure to turn and lays it off to a pivot, who has space and is facing the play.

COACHING THE THIRD MAN CONCEPT I

2 v 2 + 1 POSSESSION GAME:

Objective: improving ability to find a free man and control possession with short passing in a 3 v 2 situation.

Rules: 2 v 2 situation in order to control the possession with the help of the neutral player (green 10), who plays for the team in possession of the ball. Start with unlimited touches and progress to 2 touches max to increase the speed and force players to move more in order to maintain possesios.

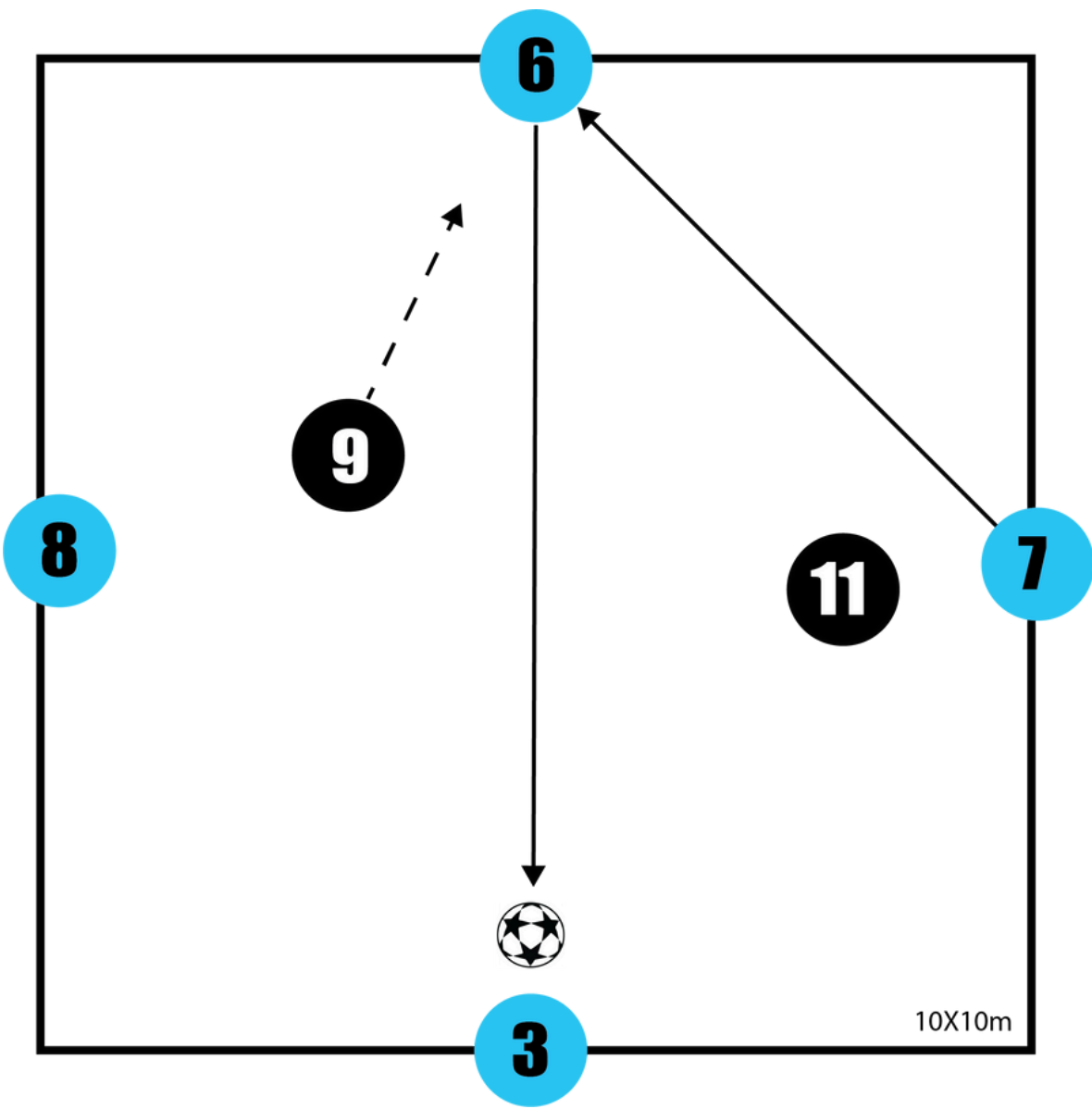
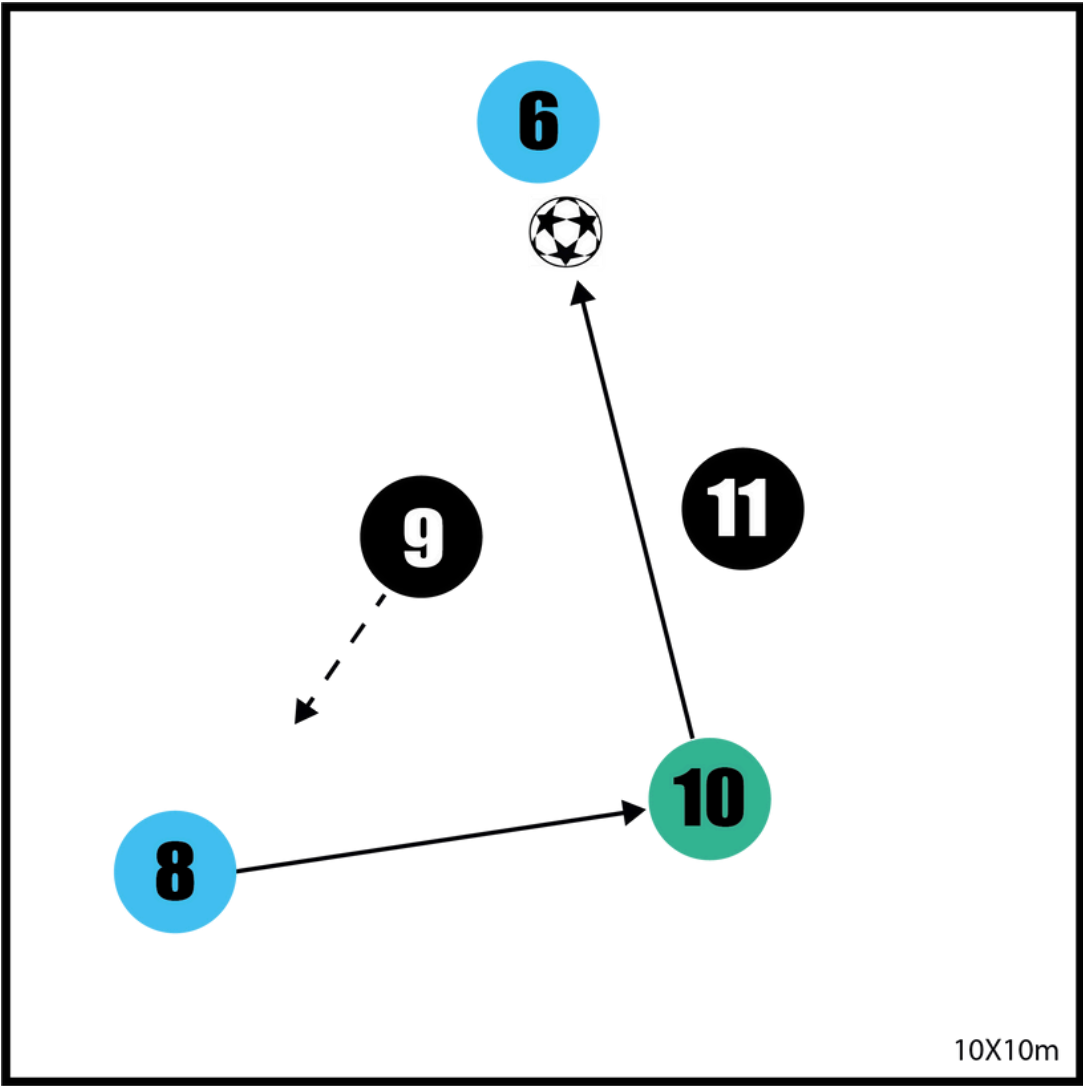
4 v 2 RONDO:

Objective: improving ability to find a free man and control possession with short passing in a 4 v 2 situation.

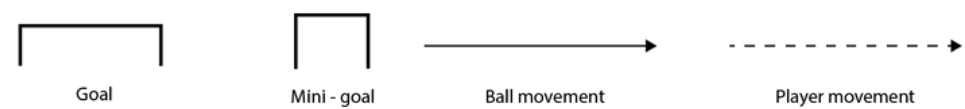
Rules: players in possession (blue) control the ball with 2 touches, while 2 defensive players trying to recover the ball with intensive pressing. Point is scored after 15 passes in a row. As the practices progresses introduce variations: blue players can only pass to a “third man”, players can only take 1 touch if the previous player used 2 touches.

COACHING POINTS:

- Movement Off the Ball: Emphasize the importance of intelligent movement off the ball to create space and passing lanes.
- Positioning: Angles of support to player in possession of the ball.
- Quick Thinking: Encourage quick thinking and fast decision-making to keep the tempo high.
- Triangles: Encourage players to form triangles to create optimal passing angles.
- First Touch: Improve the first touch to ensure the second touch can be a decisive pass to the third man.
- Body Position: Ensure players are aware of their body orientation to receive the ball on the half-turn and play it quickly to the third man.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING THE THIRD MAN CONCEPT II

8 v 8 + 5 POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: improving ability to progress through the thirds using the third man concept.

Rules: Two teams of 8 players control possession with an aim to progress the ball from one end to the other (that's how the point is scored). Neutral players (green) play with the team in possession and can only use 2 touches max. The ball can only be progressed through the middle zone using a third man combination, with a pass to green 10 and a subsequent run into the middle zone from where a pass to the other zone must be made (as shown in the diagram). After the pass is made, the player must return into his zone (blue 2 in the diagram). Start with unlimited touches and progress to 2 touches max to speed up the play.

9 v 9 + 5 POSITIONAL GAME:

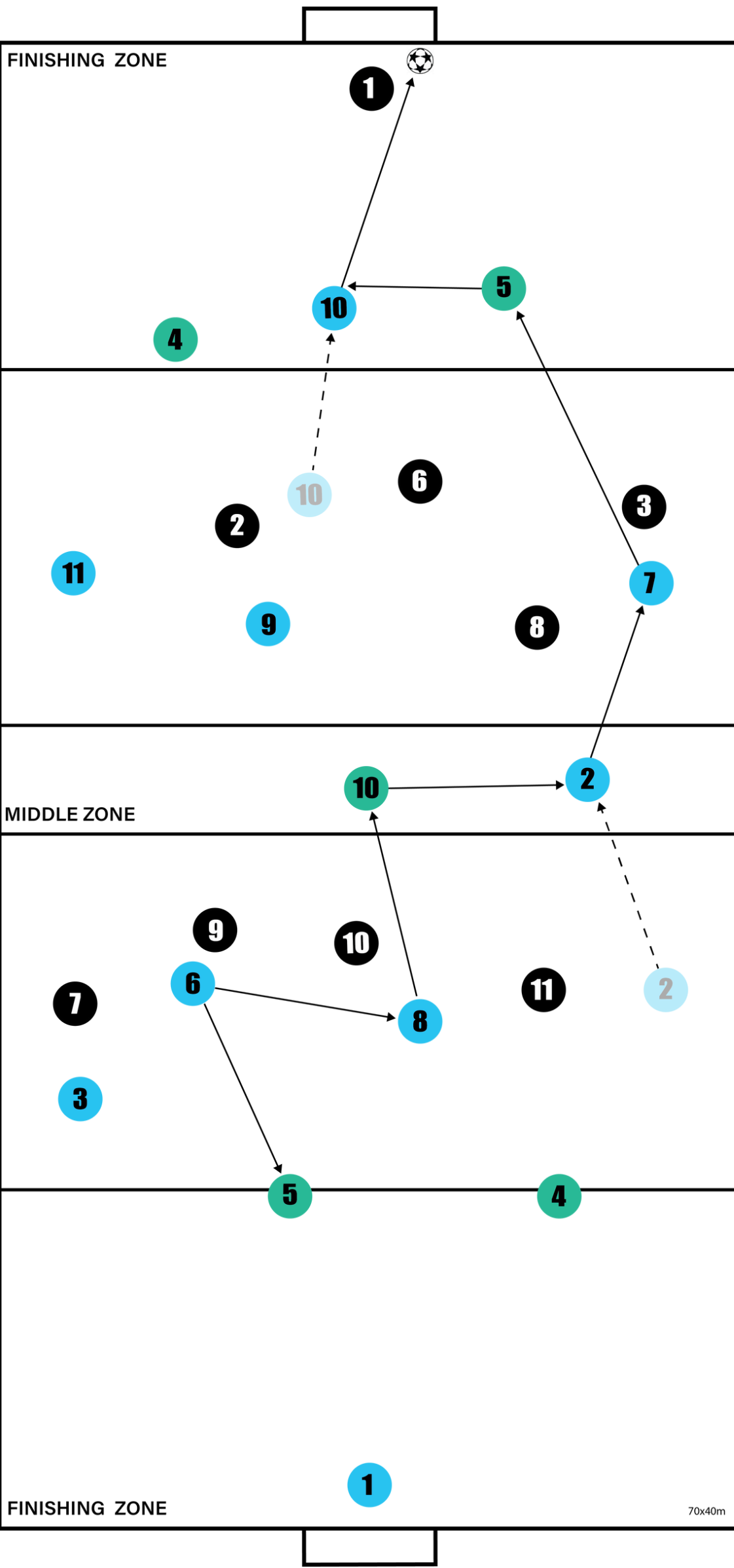
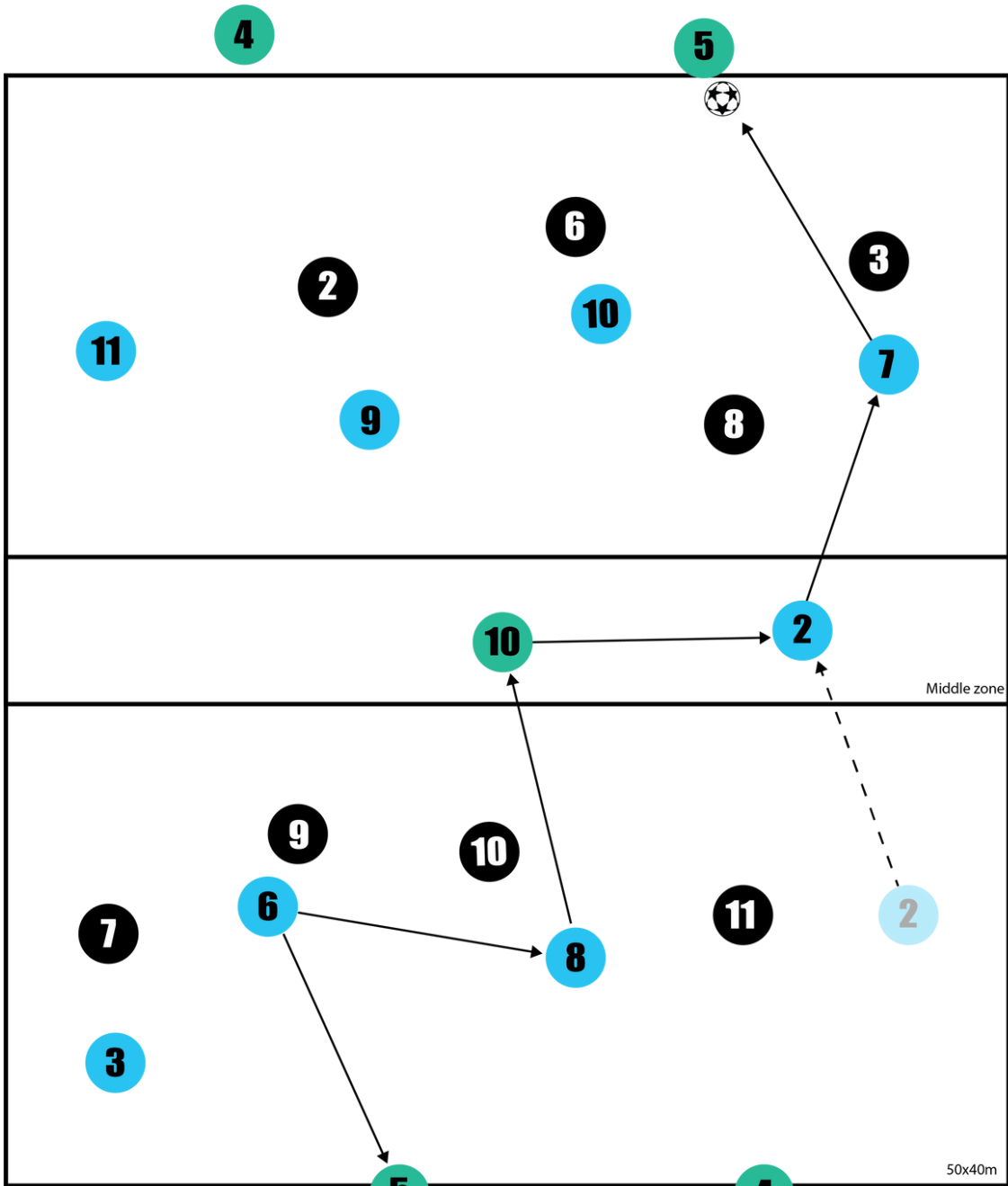
Objective: improving ability to progress through the thirds using the third man concept.

Rules: Two teams of 9 players control possession with an aim to progress the ball into the finishing zone and score. Neutral players (green) play with the team in possession and can only use 2 touches max. The ball can only be progressed through the middle zone using a third man combination, with a pass to green 10 and a subsequent run into the middle zone from where a pass to the other zone must be made (as shown in the diagram). The ball then needs to be progressed into the finishing zone, where green players can only use 1 touch to lay off the ball to the onrushing attacker. Start with unlimited touches and progress to 2 touches max to speed up the play.

COACHING POINTS:

- Movement Off the Ball: Emphasize the importance of intelligent movement off the ball to create space and passing lanes. Players must provide support to the ball carrier by offering passing options.
- Quick Thinking: Encourage quick thinking and fast decision-making to keep the tempo high.
- Triangles: Encourage players to form triangles to create optimal passing angles.
- Understanding Roles: Ensure all players understand the concept of the first man (the passer), the second man (the receiver), and the third man (the player who will receive the ball from the second man).

Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.

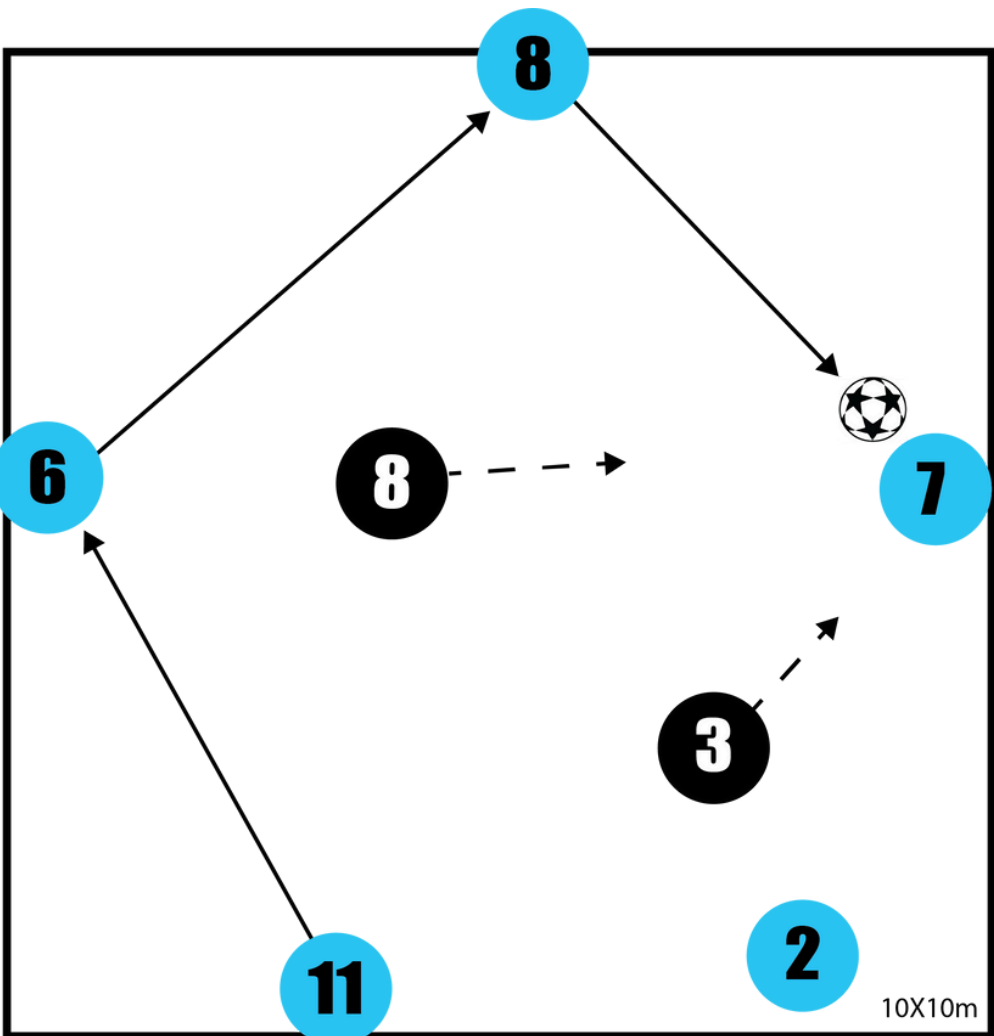


COACHING CONTROL OF POSSESSION WITH SHORT PASSING I

5 v 2 RONDO:

Objective: improving ability to control possession with 1 touch in tight spaces.

Rules: Players in possession (blue) control the ball with 1 touch max, while defending players (black), press with intensity trying to recover the ball. The point is scored after a sequence of 15 passes in a row.



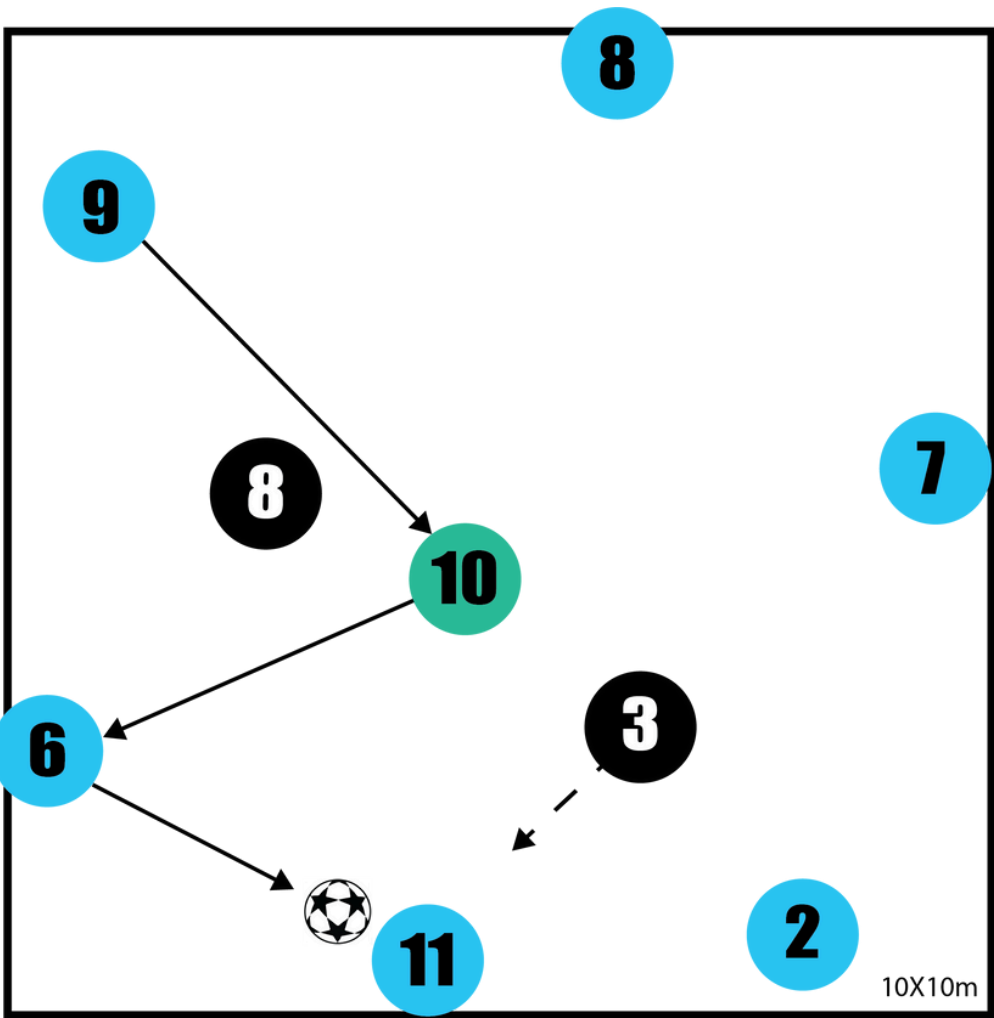
6 v 2 + 1 RONDO:

Objective: improving ability to control possession with 1 touch in tight spaces.

Rules: Team in possession (blue) control the ball with 1 touch max with the help of the floating player in the middle (green 10), while the defending team (black), press with intensity in order to recover the ball. The point is scored after a sequence of 15 passes in a row.

COACHING POINTS:

- Support Play: Players must provide support to the player with the ball by offering passing options.
- Positioning: Players should understand when to stay wide and when to come closer to support.
- Quick Thinking: Encourage quick thinking and fast decision-making to keep the tempo high. Players should be aware of their next move before receiving the ball.
- Quality of Passing: Focus on the weight and accuracy of passes. Passes should be firm but not overly hard.
- Body Positioning: Players should position their body to receive the ball on the half-turn, allowing them to play forward quickly. Encourage an open body stance to have a wider field of vision.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.

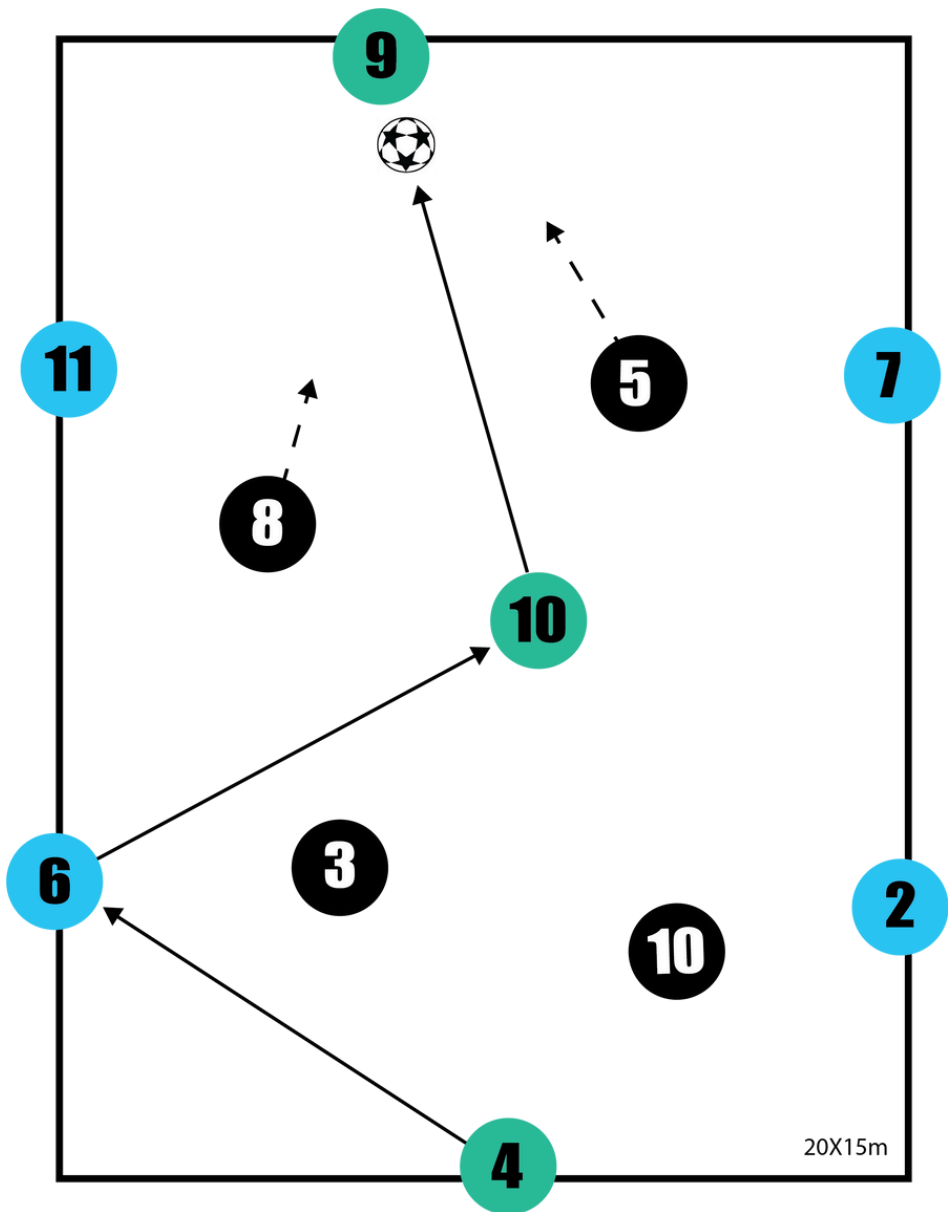


COACHING CONTROL OF POSSESSION WITH SHORT PASSING II

4 v 4 + 3 POSITIONAL RONDO:

Objective: improving ability to control possession in tight spaces.

Rules: two teams (blue and black) vying for possession, while neutral players (green) play with the team in possession of the ball. When defending team recovers the ball they need to transition to the possession positions on the edges of the play area while the team that just lost the possession, immediately initiates the counter-pressing effort in order to recover the ball. The point is scored after a sequence of 15 passes in a row. Start with unlimited touches and progress to 2 touches max to speed up the play.



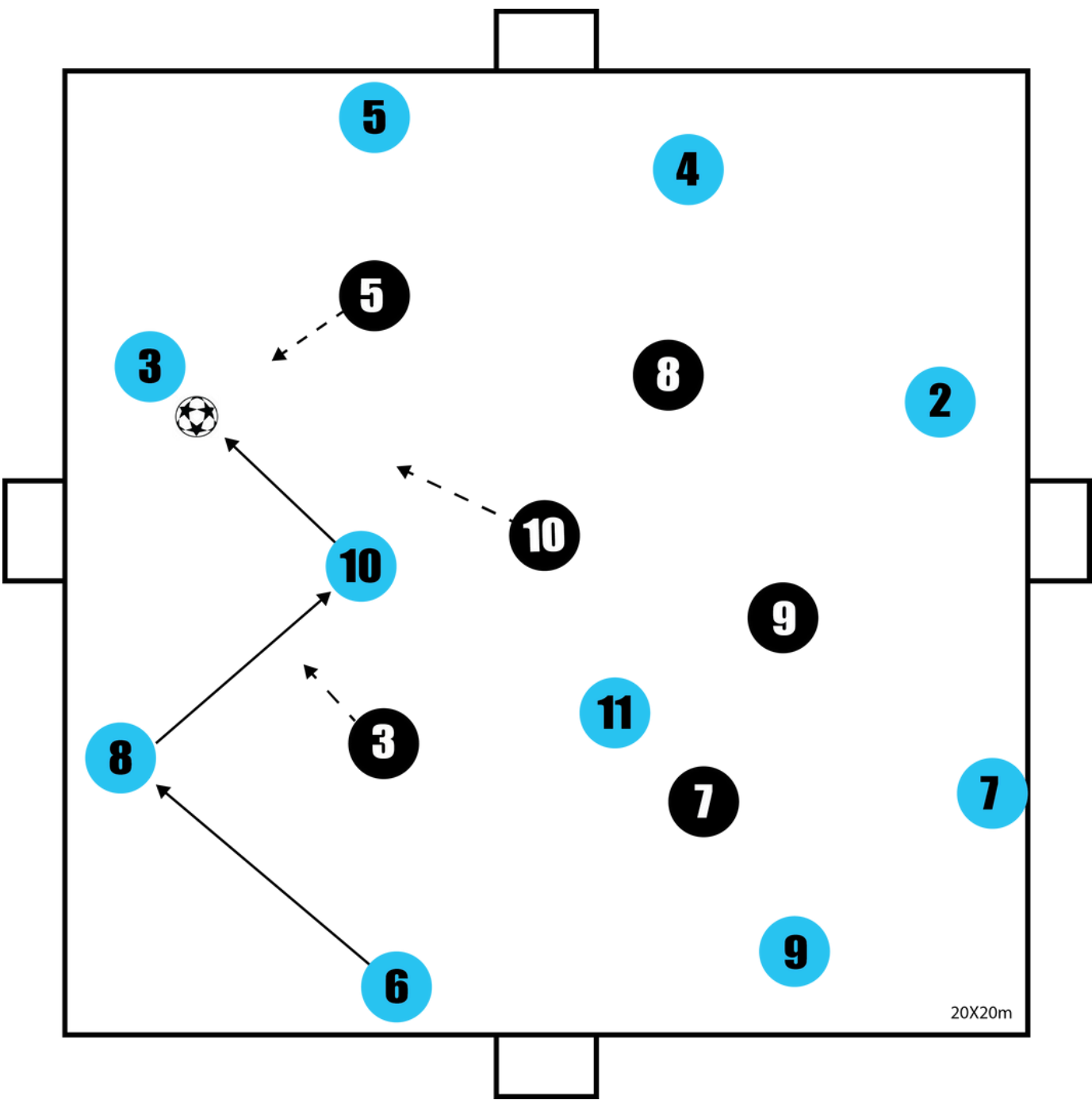
10 v 6 POSSESSION GAME:

Objective: improving ability to control possession in tight spaces.

Rules: Team in possession (blue) control the ball while the defending team (black) press with intensity in order to recover the ball and score in one of the four mini-goals. Blue team scores a point by connecting a sequence of 15 passes in a row. Once the blue team losses possession they initiate a counter-pressing effort in order to recover the ball and prevent the black team from scoring. Start with unlimited touches and progress to 2 touches max to speed up the play.

COACHING POINTS:

- Movement off the ball: Emphasize the importance of intelligent movement off the ball to create space and passing lanes. Players must provide support to the ball carrier by offering passing options.
- Quick Thinking: Encourage quick thinking and fast decision-making to keep the tempo high. Players should be aware of their next move before receiving the ball.
- Positioning: Maintain optimal spacing to avoid crowding and to make it easier to maintain possession. Players should understand when to stay wide and when to come closer to support. Ensure the creation of triangles and diamonds to facilitate easy passing options.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



AUTOMATION OF PASSING PATTERNS

Automating patterns of play is a cornerstone of Roberto De Zerbi's football philosophy, deeply embedded in his tactical approach and overall vision for how the game should be played. In De Zerbi's style, the automation of certain movements and sequences is not merely a preference but a necessity for executing his complex, possession-based strategy effectively. Here's why these automated patterns are so crucial:

- Enhancing Fluidity and Cohesion: De Zerbi's system relies on fluid movement and precise positioning to manipulate space and create opportunities. Automating patterns of play ensures that players move in a coordinated fashion, understanding where teammates will be at any given moment. This level of predictability among the players fosters a cohesive team movement, making it difficult for opponents to anticipate and disrupt their flow.
- Speeding Up Decision Making: In high-pressure situations, having pre-established patterns allows players to make quick decisions without the need for extensive deliberation. This speed in decision-making is critical in modern football, where moments of hesitation can lead to lost opportunities or turnovers. The players' familiarity with these patterns means they can execute complex sequences instinctively, maintaining the tempo of the game and exploiting brief windows of opportunity.
- Maintaining Control: Control over the game's tempo and rhythm is a hallmark of De Zerbi's approach. Automated patterns of play contribute to this by ensuring the team can dictate the pace, transitioning smoothly between defense and attack. By having set movements for various scenarios, the team can more effectively maintain possession, patiently waiting for the right moment to penetrate the opposition's defense.
- Exploiting Spaces: De Zerbi's emphasis on verticality and finding the free man in space requires intricate patterns that can disorganize the opposition's defensive structure. Automated movements create and exploit spaces through deliberate distractions and the precise timing of runs. These rehearsed plays are designed to pull defenders out of position, opening lanes for through balls and creating scoring opportunities.
- Developing Player Interchangeability: The automation of certain plays under De Zerbi's guidance is also about fostering versatility within the squad. Players become accustomed to performing different roles within the predefined patterns, which enhances the team's adaptability to various match situations. This interchangeability is a tactical asset, allowing De Zerbi to make adjustments on the fly without diminishing the team's overall cohesion or effectiveness.
- Building Confidence and Reducing Errors: Repetition leads to mastery. By automating patterns of play, players gain confidence in their roles and the system as a whole. This confidence translates into smoother executions and fewer mistakes, as players are less likely to second-guess their actions. Moreover, this approach reinforces a collective understanding of the team's strategic objectives, aligning individual efforts towards a common goal.

In summary, the importance of automating patterns of play in De Zerbi's style lies in its ability to create a team that operates with precision, intelligence, and flexibility. These patterns are the building blocks of his tactical philosophy, enabling his teams to execute complex strategies with apparent ease. Through rigorous training and a deep understanding of these automated sequences, De Zerbi's teams can consistently challenge opponents, showcasing a brand of football that is both effective and aesthetically pleasing.

RATIONAL SPACE OCCUPATION

Base Formation: 4-2-3-1. The 4-2-3-1 formation provides a balanced structure that facilitates both defensive solidity and offensive flexibility. This formation allows De Zerbi's team to establish control in the midfield, with the double pivot providing stability and options for ball circulation. The three attacking midfielders offer creativity and width, supporting the lone striker.

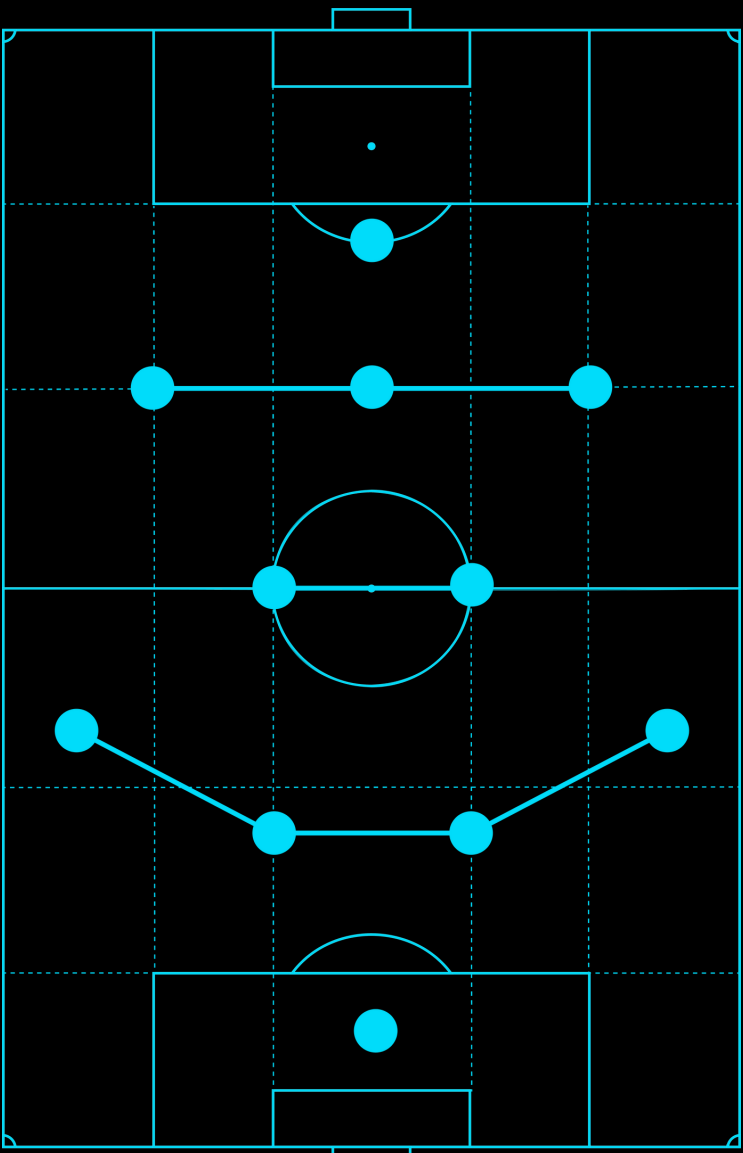
Build-Up Phase: Transition to 2-4-2-2: During the build-up phase, De Zerbi's formation often transitions into a 2-4-2-2, emphasizing width and verticality. The full-backs push higher up the pitch, effectively becoming wingers and stretching the opposition's defensive line. Meanwhile, the wingers move inside, occupying the half-spaces and creating overloads in central areas. This transformation facilitates ball progression from defense to attack, offering multiple passing lanes and options for breaking the opposition's press.

When facing an opposition's mid-block, De Zerbi's teams typically adjust their shape to create overloads in midfield and exploit spaces between the lines. The formation may resemble a 2-4-4 or 2-3-5, full-backs inverting and joining the midfield line, while one of the defensive midfielders pushes higher up. This adjustment aims to draw the opposition out, creating space behind their midfield for De Zerbi's players to exploit with quick combinations or dribbles.

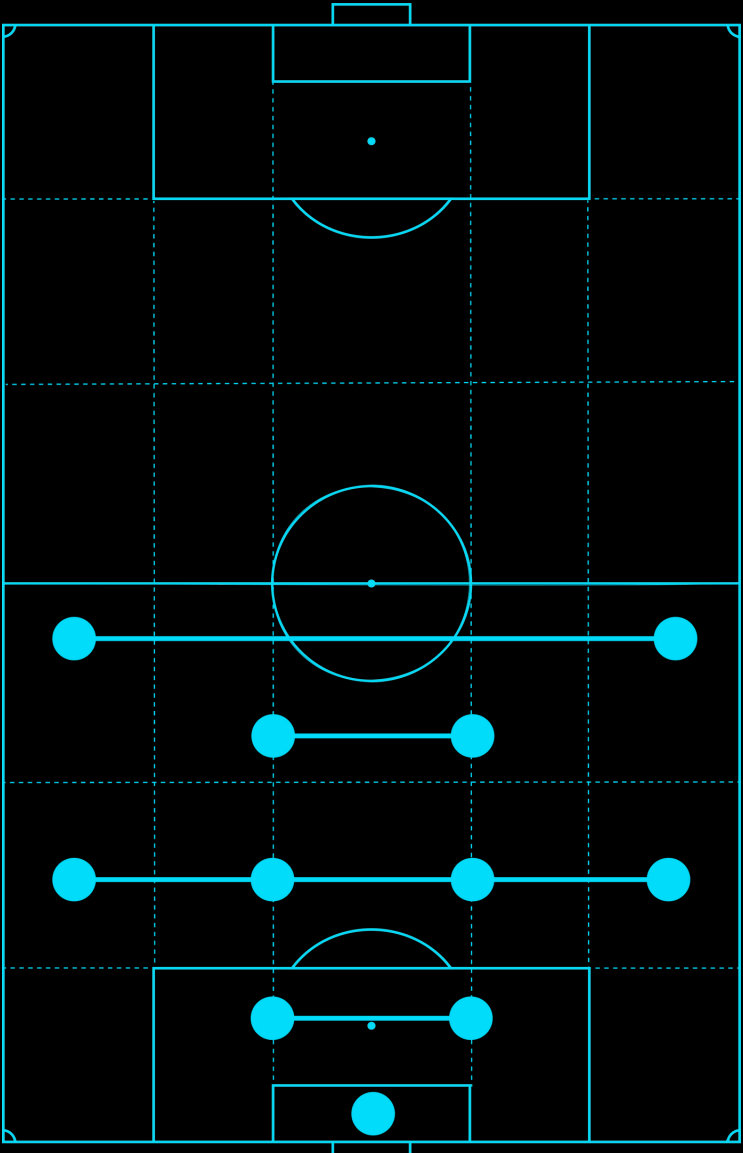
Breaking down a low-block requires patience and precision. In these scenarios, De Zerbi's formation might shift towards a 2-3-5, emphasizing width and numerical superiority in the final third. The objective is to stretch the opposition's defense to create gaps that can be exploited with quick passes or crosses into the box. The team's focus on maintaining possession and shifting the ball quickly from side to side aims to unbalance the defense and open up channels for penetrating passes.

Central to De Zerbi's tactical adaptations is the principle of rational space occupation. This concept involves players positioning themselves in ways that maximize control of the pitch, ensuring that every area is covered and that the team can create numerical advantages wherever the ball is played. It's about understanding the dynamics of space—when to compress it defensively and how to expand it offensively. Players must be versatile, intelligent, and technically proficient, capable of interpreting the game and adjusting their position and movements accordingly.

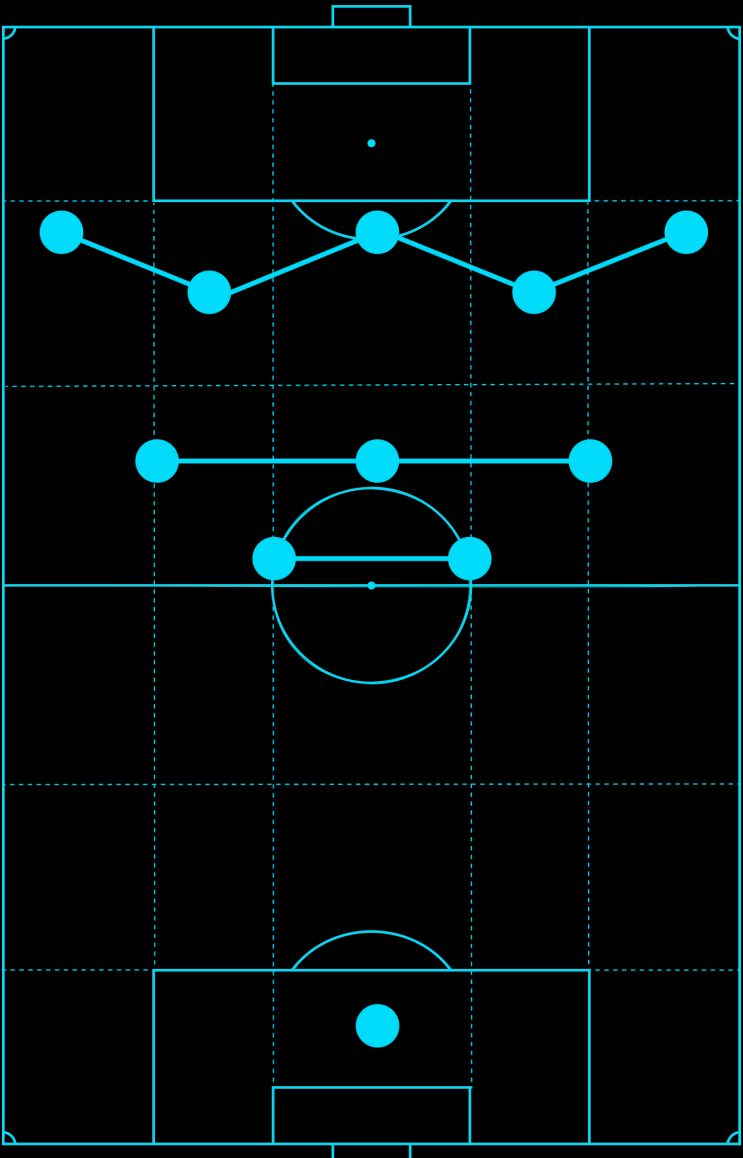
De Zerbi's formations and their fluid transformations reflect a deep tactical understanding and an emphasis on control, whether in possession or out of it. By mastering the rational occupation of space and the dynamic adaptation of formations, De Zerbi's teams are able to dominate games, create scoring opportunities, and adapt to the challenges posed by different opponents and game situations.



De Zerbi is normally using 4-2-3-1 as the base formation

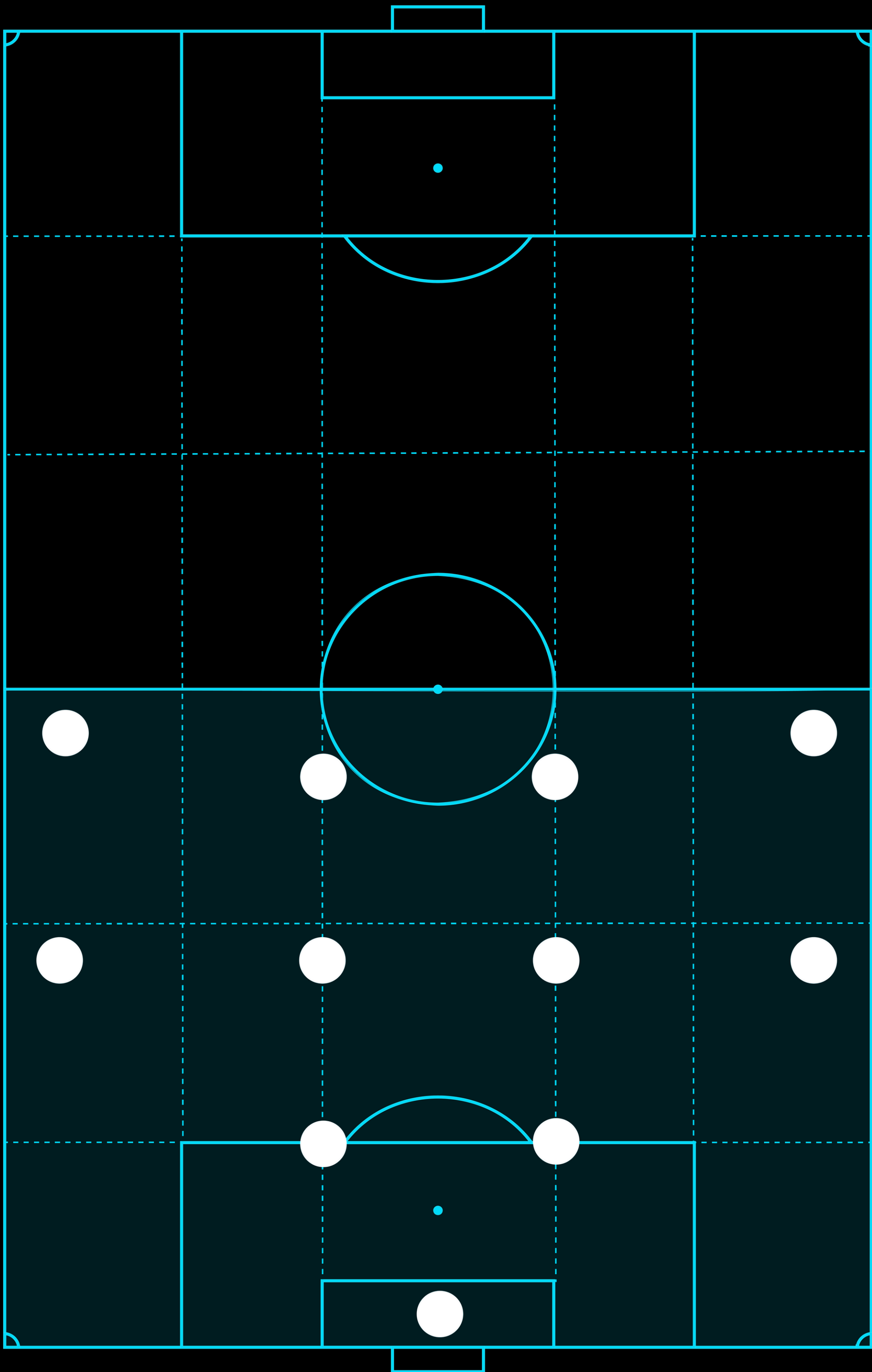


De Zerbi is using 2-4-2-2 as the build-up structure



De Zerbi is often using 2-3-5 structure when penetrating opponent's low block.

PART I: PLAYING OUT FROM THE BACK VS HIGH PRESS



PLAYING OUT FROM THE BACK AS THE KEY PRINCIPLE

“Playing out from the back is first part of the game, which influences how the team is progressing higher up the pitch. I choose to build from the back, which means, we can’t kick a long ball forward hoping to win the second ball. It doesn’t feel coherent or logical to me. I like control of possession with short passing, which suits players with good technical ability, it also gives the players confidence that they are the protagonists in the game”. - Roberto De Zerbi

Roberto De Zerbi's philosophy of playing out from the back fundamentally transforms traditional football tactics, promoting a progressive, possession-based style that heavily influences how his team operates throughout all phases of the game. By starting play from the goalkeeper and defenders, De Zerbi establishes a foundational strategy that sets the tone for the entire match, emphasizing meticulous ball control and strategic buildup over hasty advances.

- The Strategic Foundations of Playing from the Back: This approach does more than just dictate the initial play; it lays the groundwork for establishing dominance in midfield and creating structured attacks. By insisting on playing out from the back, De Zerbi's teams develop a rhythm and understanding that permeate through to the attacking third. It encourages players to make intelligent runs, utilize space effectively, and engage in continuous movement, which collectively complicates the defensive strategies of opponents.
- Coherence and Strategic Flow: De Zerbi's rejection of long balls is rooted in a philosophy that values coherence and fluidity over randomness and chaos. He views the football pitch as a canvas where each pass represents a stroke of the brush contributing to a larger picture. In this context, long balls represent a disruption—sudden and uncontrolled. Instead, he champions a methodical approach where each phase of play seamlessly transitions into the next, maintaining a logical and controlled progression that aligns with an overarching tactical framework.
- Technical Mastery and Tactical Intelligence: The emphasis on short passing requires players to exhibit superior technical skills, such as close ball control, acute awareness, and precise passing. These skills are crucial because De Zerbi's football not only demands that players maintain possession under pressure but also that they make smart decisions quickly. This style is particularly well-suited to players who thrive under the demands of intensive possession play, offering them a platform to showcase their abilities in tight spaces.
- Empowerment and Protagonism: De Zerbi's approach goes beyond mere tactics; it is about instilling a mindset. By encouraging players to control the game through possession, he empowers them to feel like the main architects of their team's fate. This empowerment fosters a strong sense of agency and responsibility among the players, reinforcing their roles as protagonists on the pitch. They are not merely participants reacting to the opposition's moves but are active influencers of the game's flow and outcome.

Roberto De Zerbi's tactical ethos represents a paradigm shift in how football can be played. It's an approach that demands a lot from the players but also gives them a framework within which they can excel and dominate. His teams' performances are not just about winning matches but doing so in a manner that is both tactically enriching and visually compelling. The philosophy of playing out from the back thus serves as the cornerstone of a broader tactical identity that champions skill, control, and proactive football, making De Zerbi's methodology both revolutionary and a testament to the evolving nature of the beautiful game.

ARTIFICIAL TRANSITIONS

“Brighton is the best team in the world at build-up and passing the ball to the free man at the right time.” - Pep Guardiola

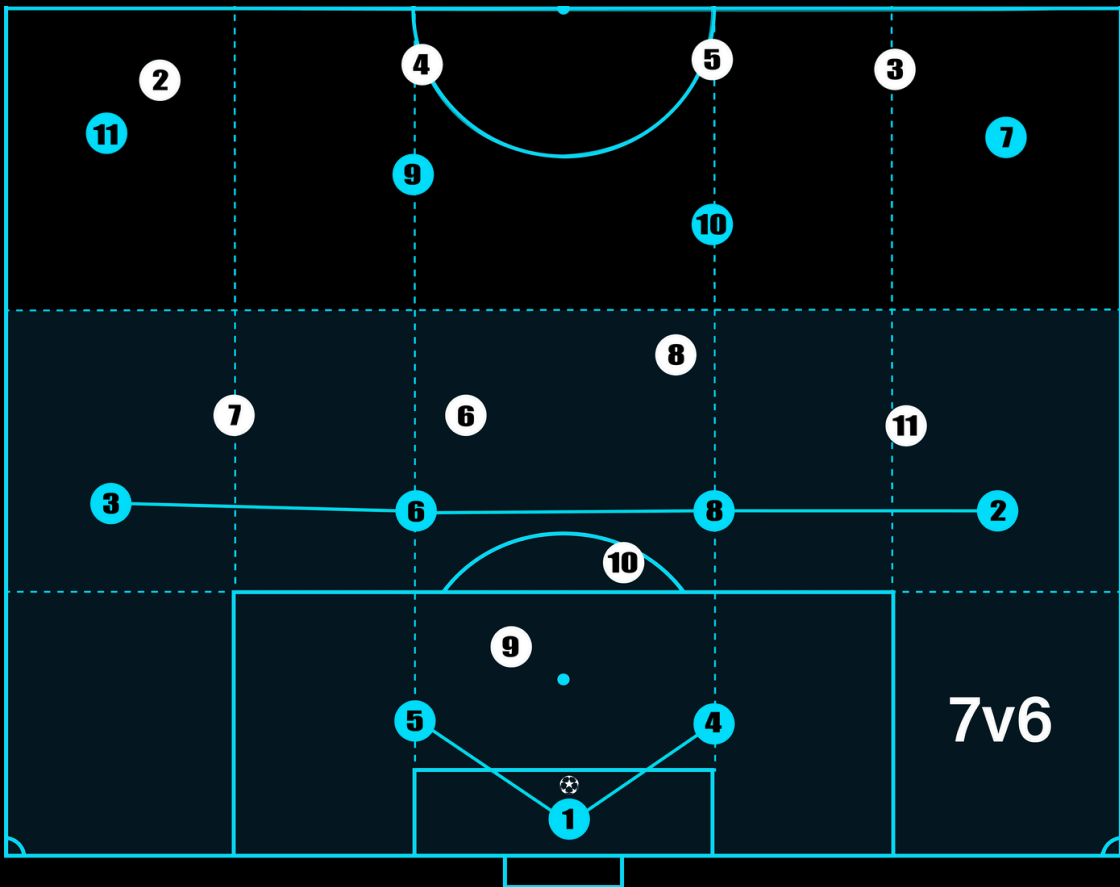
De Zerbi is known for employing strategies that invite high press from the opponents, only to then exploit the spaces created by such a press. This approach creates "artificial transitions". The concept based on a form of 'trap' or 'bait'. In the build-up phase, De Zerbi's team would circulate the ball in a way that tempts the opponents to press high and leave their defensive line. Once the opponent commits to the press, the team quickly transitions into an attack, using speed and precise passing to bypass the press and exploit the spaces left in the opponent's half. This tactic creates numerical superiority in the final third because the opponents have less time to transition back to a defensive shape, having committed players forward for the press.

De Zerbi asks 6 (4 defenders and 2 defensive midfielders) of his outfield players to drop deep and control possession (with goalkeeper actively participating in order to help create numerical superiority), while 4 attacking players would stay high up to create space vertically. Having 6 outfield players actively participating in the build-up phase, provides De Zerbi’s teams with numerical superiority most of the time.

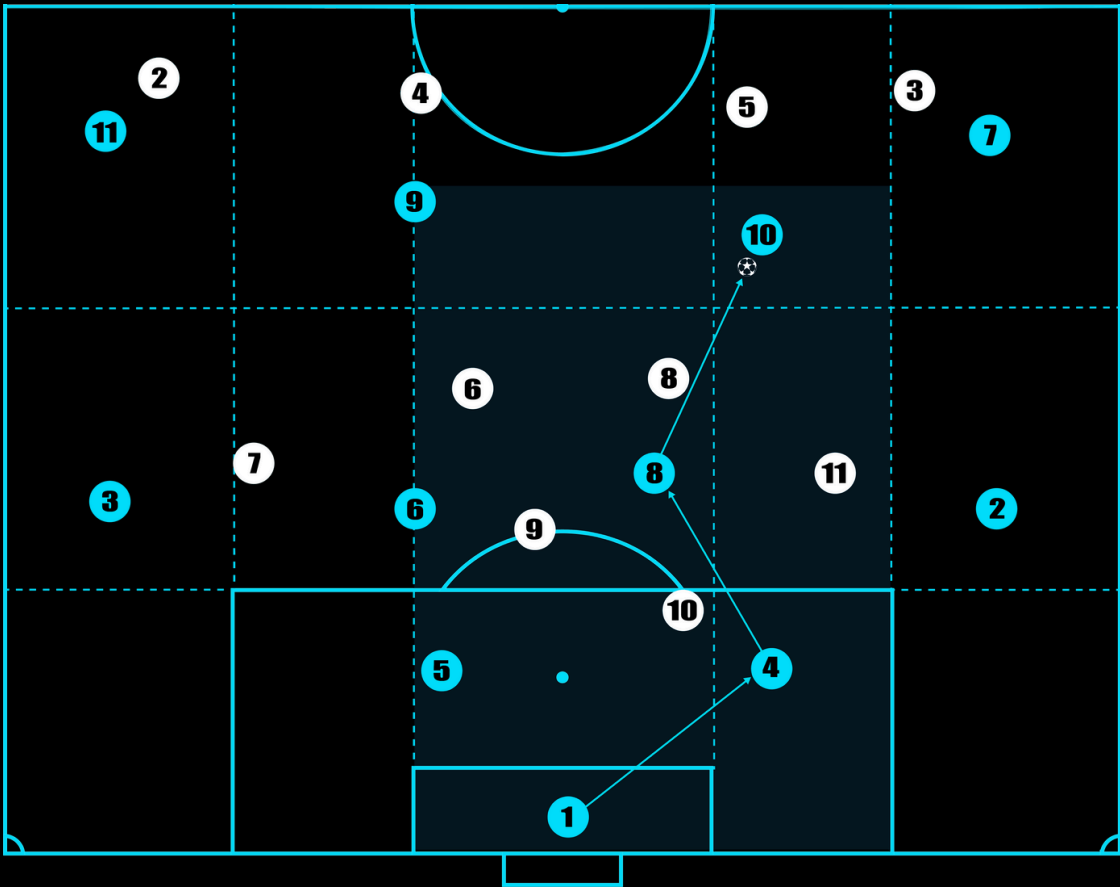
In a 2-4-2-2 build-up formation:

- 1. Two centre-backs: would drop low and wide to create space for the goalkeeper to act as an additional passing option, which helps to alleviate pressure from the high press.
- 2. Two central midfielders (double pivot): would drop deep, positioning themselves in line with the full backs. This creates a 4-player line that helps to maintain numerical superiority and provides multiple passing options against the opposition's press.
- 3. Two full backs: would stay in line with the double pivot, providing width and stretching the opposition's press. Their presence ensures that the opponents must commit more players to the press, which could leave spaces further up the pitch.
- 4. Striker and attacking midfielder: would take central positions, looking to exploit gaps in the opposition's defence and provide direct passing options.
- 5. Two wingers: would stay high and wide, stretching the opposition's defence and providing passing options, should the build-up succeed in bypassing the press.

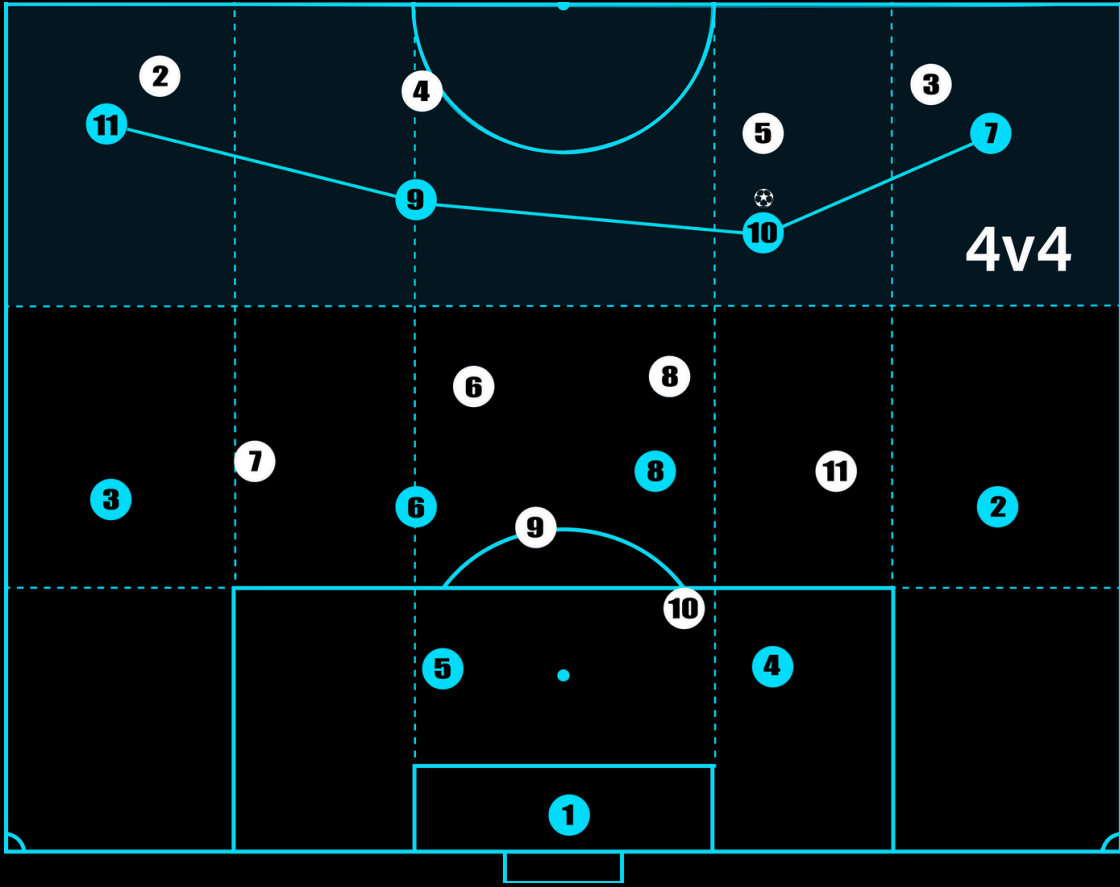
If the opposition commits six players to the press, it opens opportunities for De Zerbi's team to quickly transition into a 4v4 situation in the attacking half. The vertical passes and fast attacks are crucial to capitalize on the spaces left by the opposition's press, turning a high-risk build-up into a high reward attacking opportunity.



7 players normally participate in the initial build-up phase vs the high press, which provides De Zerbi’s teams with numerical superiority in most occasions.



Once the opposition commits to high press, players in De Zerbi’s teams are expected to evaluate and decide on the optimal way to progress forward. Which usually is a vertical combination into the direction the pressure comes from.

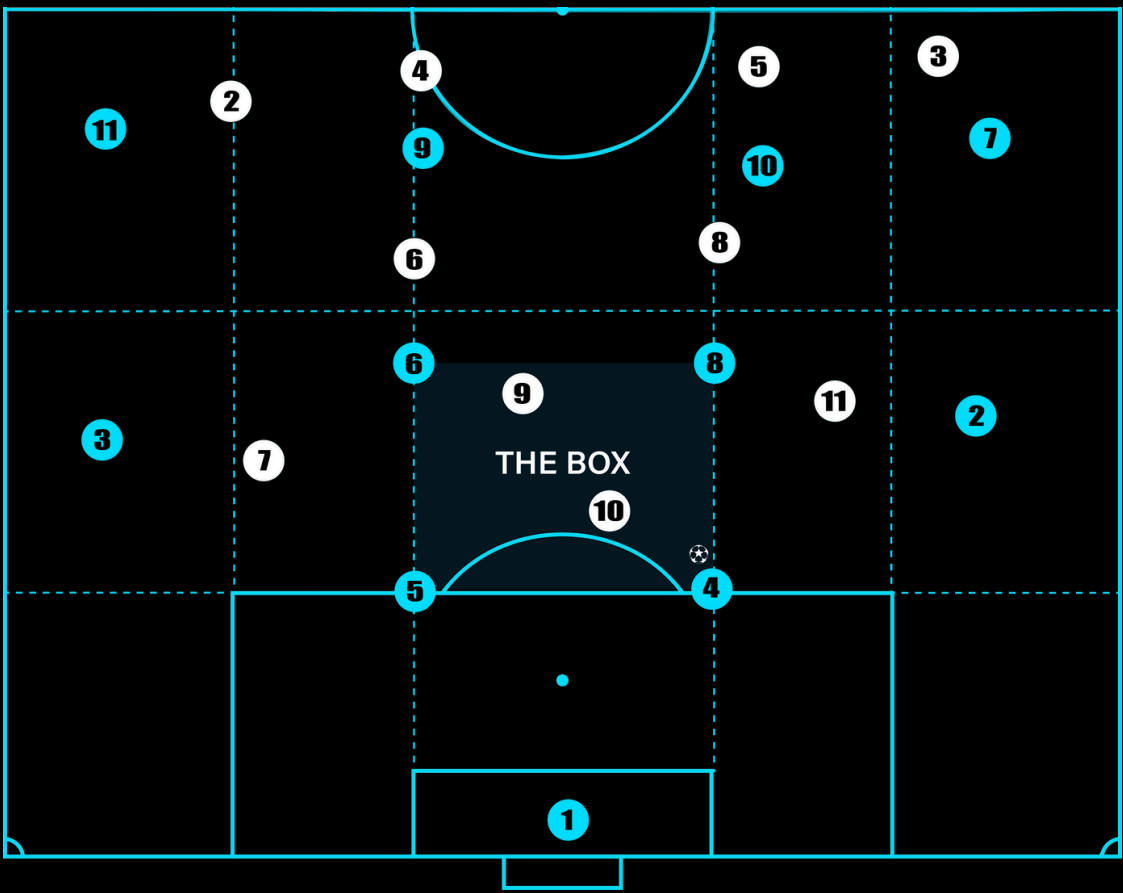


If the defending team commits 6 players to the high press, it creates a 4v4 situation higher up the field, which De Zerbi’s teams look to exploit with speedy attacks. Most attacks by Ze Zerbi’s teams feels like counter-attacks.

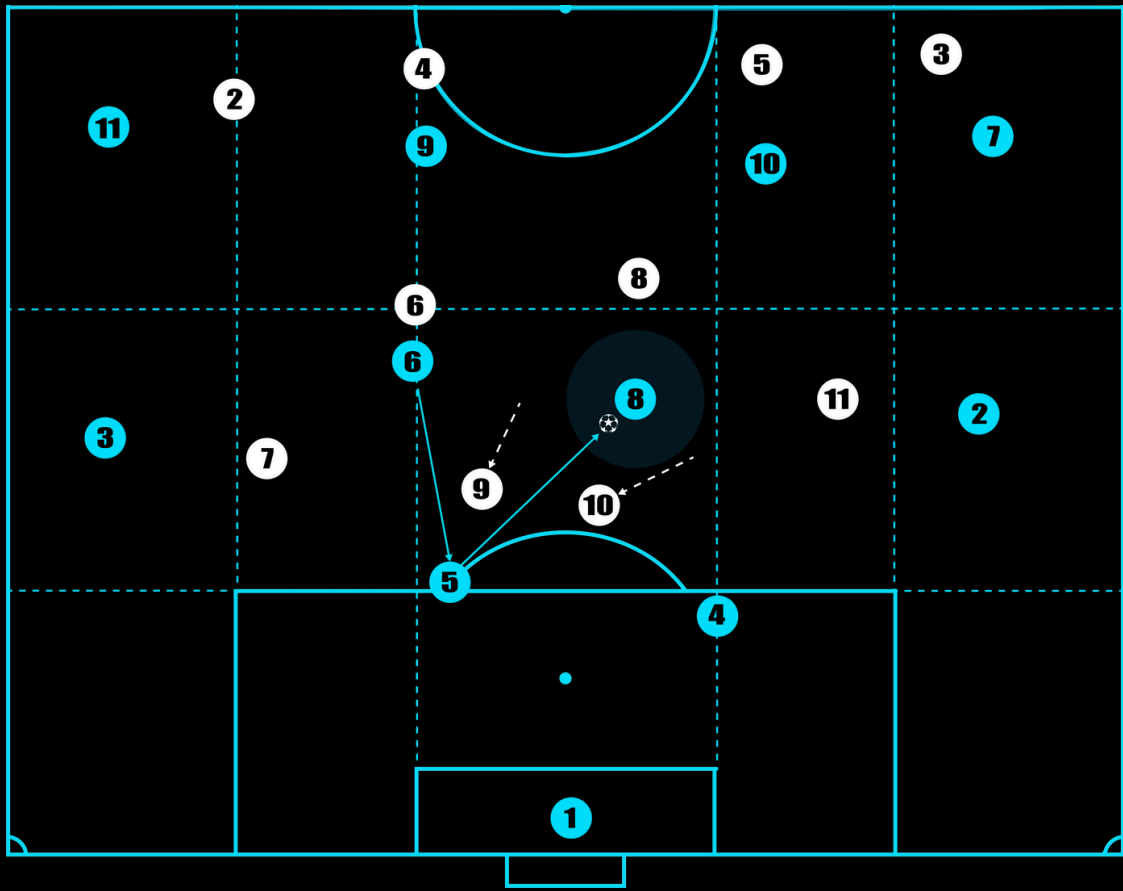
“THE BOX” SHAPE

Roberto De Zerbi’s “The Box” formation, characterized by two center-backs and a double pivot in a 2-4-2-2 setup during the build-up phase, exemplifies his tactical ethos which revolves around control, manipulation of space, and intelligent positional play. This core structure is pivotal in dictating the rhythm of the game and executing strategic maneuvers to outplay the opposition. The key principles of this approach:

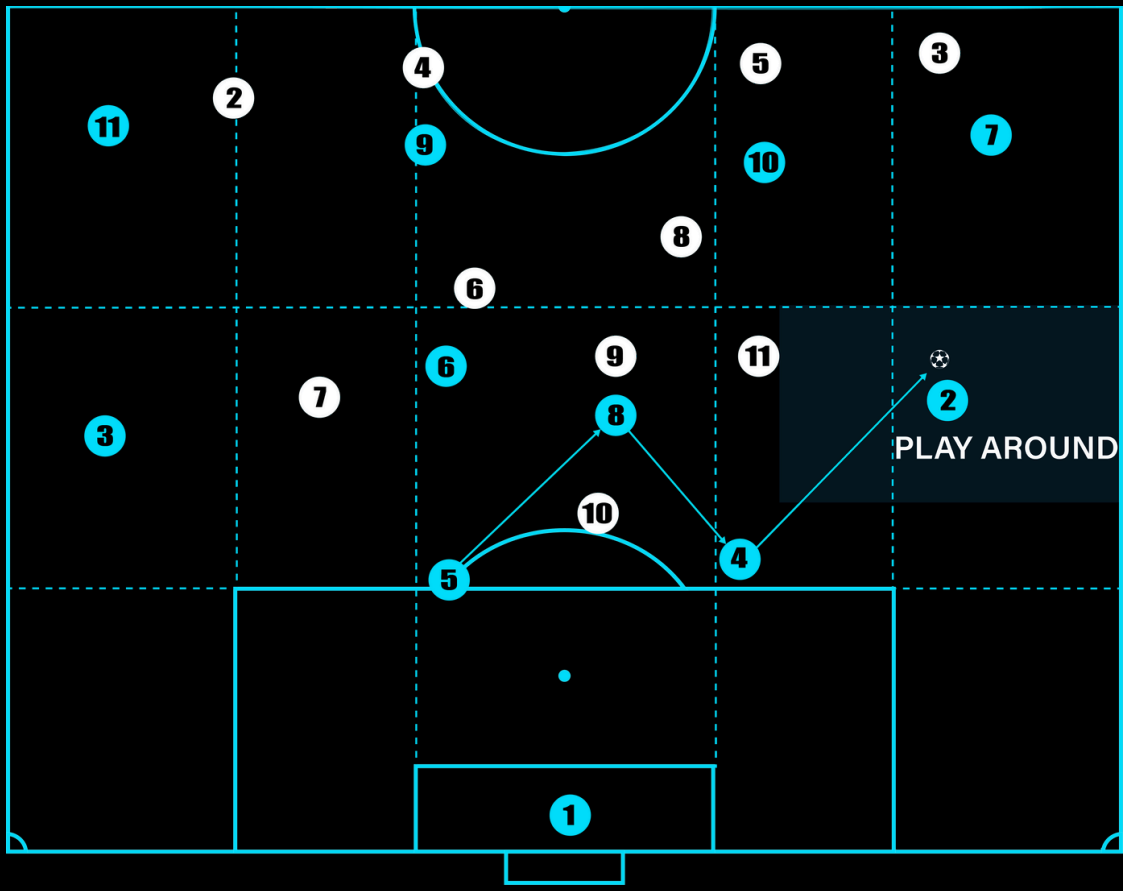
- First Play Through the Middle: The central areas of the pitch are critical because they offer the most direct path towards the opponent's goal and provide the best angles for spreading the ball to all parts of the field. By initiating play through the middle, De Zerbi's teams can effectively engage the maximum number of players in the game, facilitating better control and creating opportunities to penetrate the opposition's defensive line. The double pivot and center-backs are crucial for this. They work together to find space and pass the ball between each other, drawing the opposition in and creating gaps to exploit further up the pitch.
- Play Around if Opposition Focus Their Press Centrally: When the opposition concentrates their press in the central areas, it often leaves flanks less guarded. Playing around this central press exploits these weaker spots, allowing the team to advance the ball into less contested areas, which can lead to crossing opportunities or diagonal balls back into the center from a more advantageous position. The center-backs and pivots need to be adept at quickly switching the play.
- Play Back to Attract Pressure: Playing the ball backwards is a tactical ploy to draw the opposition further up the field, thereby increasing the space behind them. This can be particularly effective against high-pressing teams, as it tempts them out of their defensive structure, creating opportunities for quick breaks through fast, forward passes into the space created. The center-backs and the goalkeeper are often involved in this tactic, circulating the ball among themselves and occasionally back to the goalkeeper to encourage the opposition to press higher, thus opening up space elsewhere.
- Play Into the Direction Where the Pressure Comes From: This principle uses the momentum of the pressing team against them. By playing into the direction of the press, De Zerbi's team can exploit the brief moments when pressing players are out of position, having committed to a certain direction. This creates opportunities to bypass multiple layers of the press with a single well-timed and directed pass. This requires high technical skill and calm under pressure, as the players must make accurate, quick passes back towards and then immediately away from the pressing threat. The players must also anticipate the press effectively, knowing beforehand where the subsequent pass should go.



“The box” is the core structure for De Zerbi’s build-up play, consisting of two center-backs (blue 5 and 4) and two holding midfielders (blue 6 and 8).



Playing back invites the pressing from opposition, once opposition baits, it opens up space, playing into direction of pressure is the principle often used by De Zerbi’s teams.

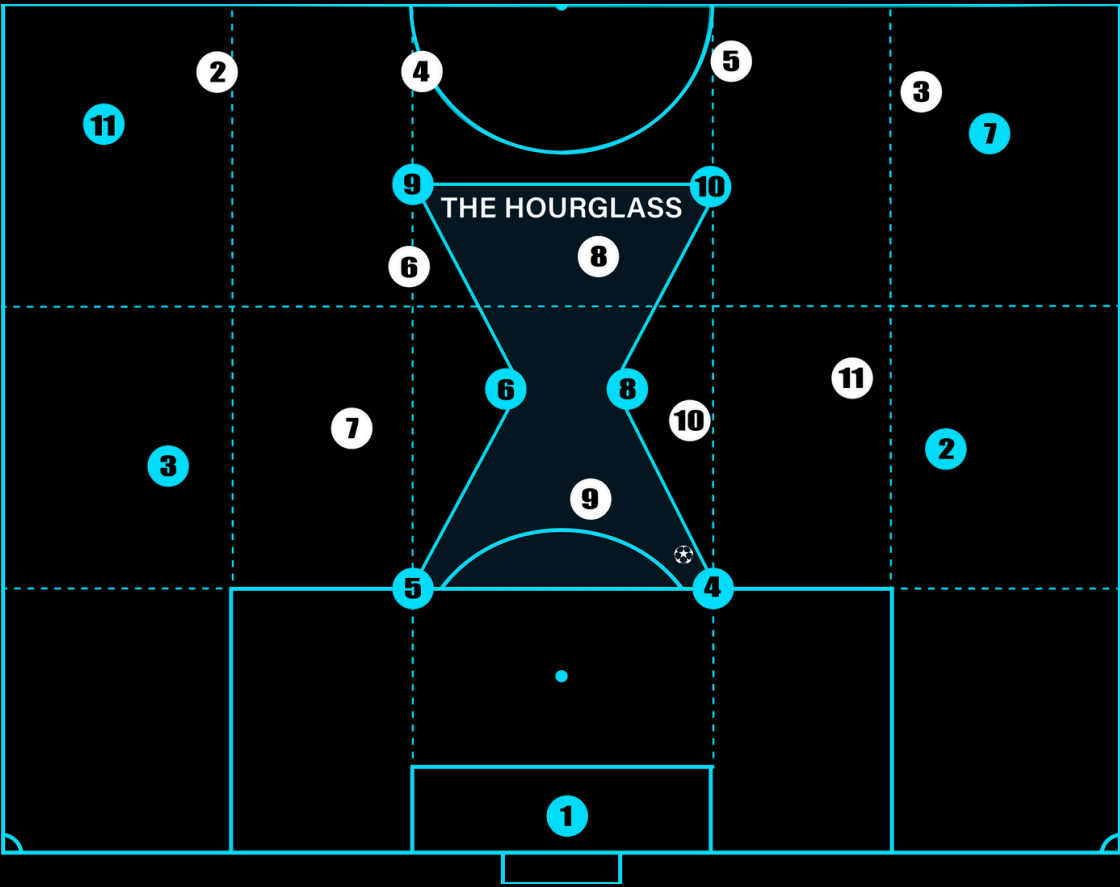


If opposition focus their pressing centrally, Brighton will look to play around using the width provided by full-backs.

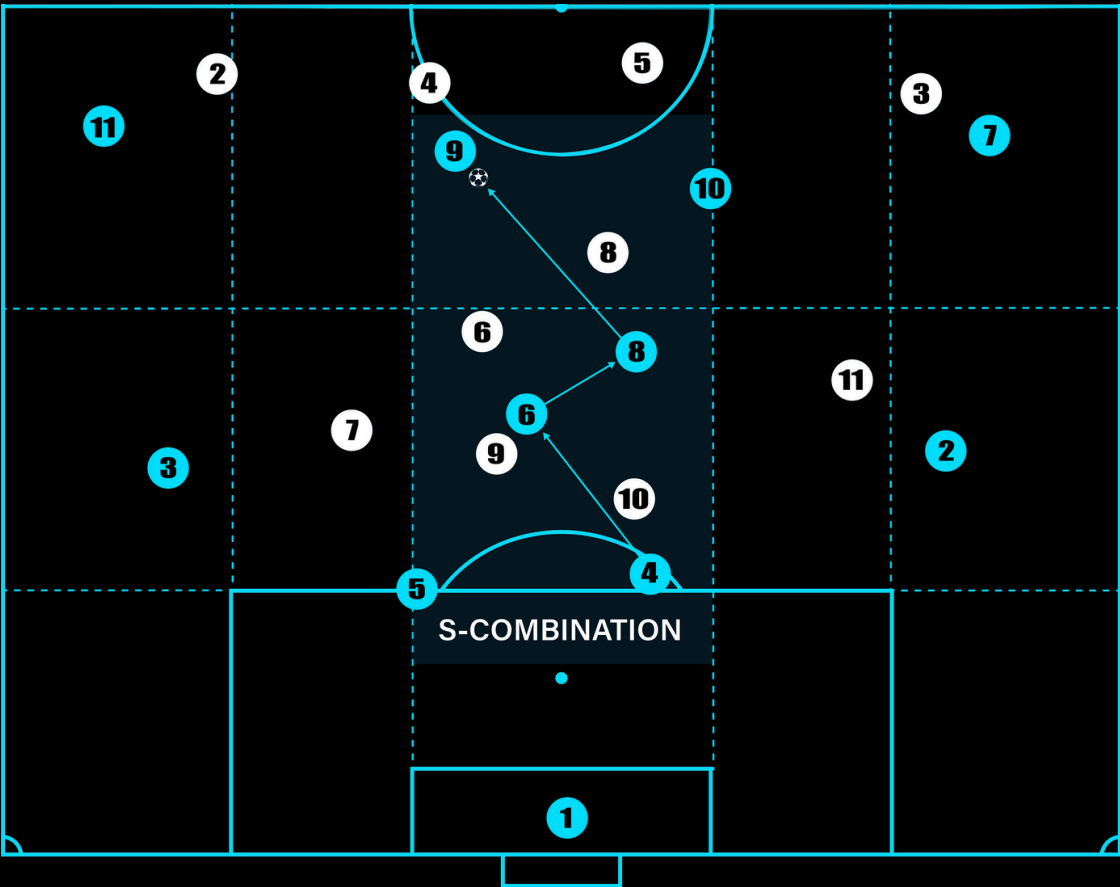
“THE HOURGLASS” SHAPE

Roberto De Zerbi's tactical adaptations in his 2-4-2-2 formation often evolve from a basic "The Box" configuration to a more dynamic "Hourglass" shape during the build-up. This transition emphasizes not just possession and control, but also an intelligent exploitation of space through structured yet fluid player movement. The double pivot—the two central midfielders—plays a crucial role in linking the defense with the attack, facilitating smooth transitions and maintaining the structural integrity of the team. The formation's inherent adaptability allows it to morph in response to different defensive strategies employed by opponents. This flexibility is critical not only for maintaining possession and control but also for creating meaningful attacking opportunities through structured yet adaptable patterns of play. Key Features of the Hourglass Shape:

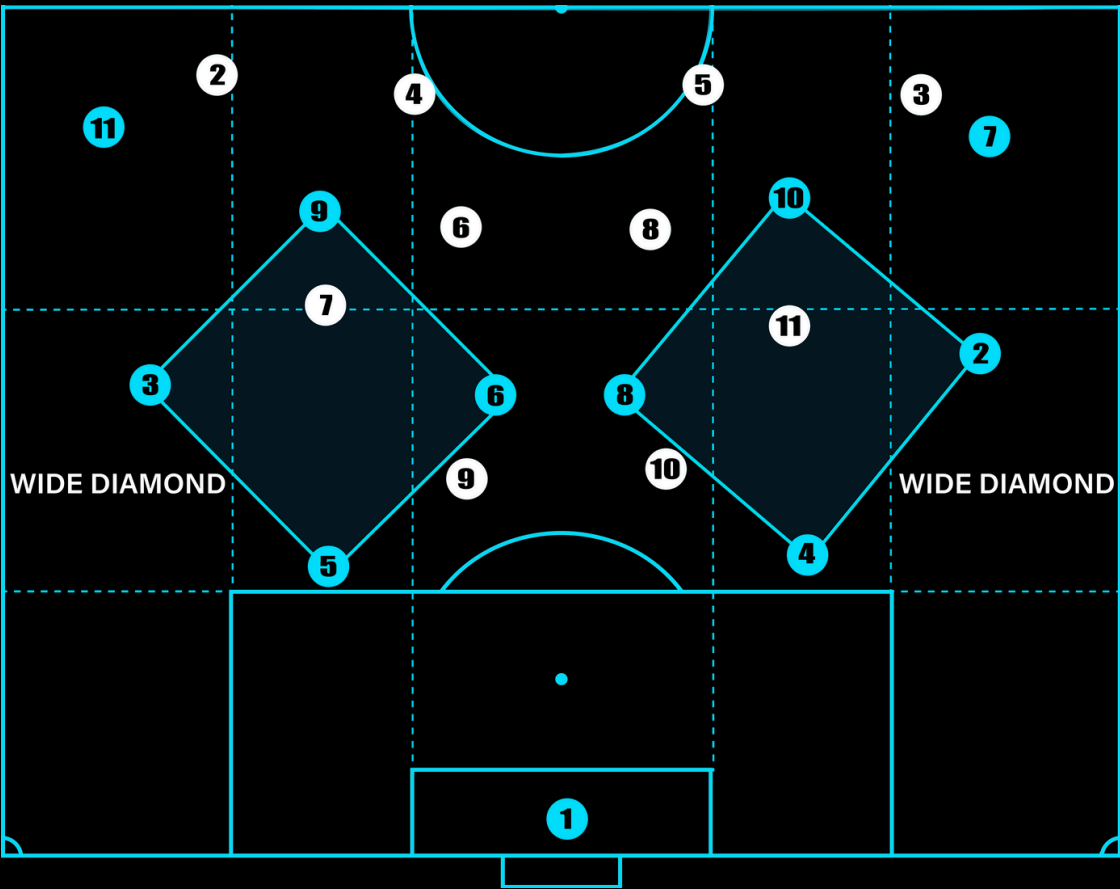
- Vertical Staggering and Space Creation: To create vertical channels that can be exploited for progressive, attacking play. Staggering players vertically helps in pulling opposing players out of position, thereby creating space to operate within the midfield and attacking third. In De Zerbi's system, the double pivot adjusts their positioning based on the ball's location and the opposition's structure. One might drop deeper to receive the ball from the center-backs, while the other positions slightly higher, ready to link up with the attackers. This vertical staggering ensures that there are always multiple options for the player in possession, whether to recycle the ball or progress it forward.
- Vertical Attacking Combinations: The "S-Combination" starts with a center back who plays the ball to the first pivot. This pivot then executes a short pass to the second pivot. The fluid movement and passing continue with the second pivot turning to play an incisive pass to one of the two attacking midfielders positioned higher up the field. This series of passes forms a quick, zigzagging movement pattern, resembling the letter "S". This combination is effective in breaking lines, especially in tight spaces. It allows the team to quickly shift the point of attack from a deep, central area to more advanced positions, exploiting gaps in the opponent's midfield and defensive lines. The quick, short passing disrupts the opponent's shape and draws them out, creating spaces for attacking midfielders or forwards to exploit.
- Utilizing Diamond Structures in Wide Areas: When central areas are congested, shifting the build-up to wide areas can help in maintaining the flow of the game. Creating diamond structures on the flanks utilizes the full-backs and wingers effectively, providing width and additional passing options. As the hourglass shape naturally draws the opposition inward, it leaves spaces on the flanks that can be exploited. The full-backs, who are crucial in this setup, move up to form diamonds with the nearest central midfielder, winger, and forward or attacking midfielder. This structure not only provides stability but also options for back-passes, crosses, or cut-backs into the box.



With addition of 2 attacking midfielders (blue 9 and 10), “the box” shape often transforms into “the hourglass shape”.



“The hourglass” shape facilitates the so called S-combination, often used by De Zerbi’s teams.



With addition of 2 full-backs (blue 2 and 3), “the hourglass” shape forms 2 wide diamonds, which allows to quickly shift focus from central progressions to the wide areas.

COACHING “THE BOX” SHAPE I

2 + 2 v 2 POSITIONAL RONDO:

Objective: improving play between center-back pair and the double pivot when playing in “the box” shape.

Rules: team in possession (blue) has an aim of transferring the ball from one end to another with 2 touches max. Blue players must stay inside their respective halves. A point is scored after the ball is transferred between two halves 8 times in a row. Defending players (black) press with intensity, once the ball is recovered they try scoring (black team has unlimited touches in this scenario) in one of the 4 mini-goals on either side, while the blue team counter-press immediately after the loss of possession.

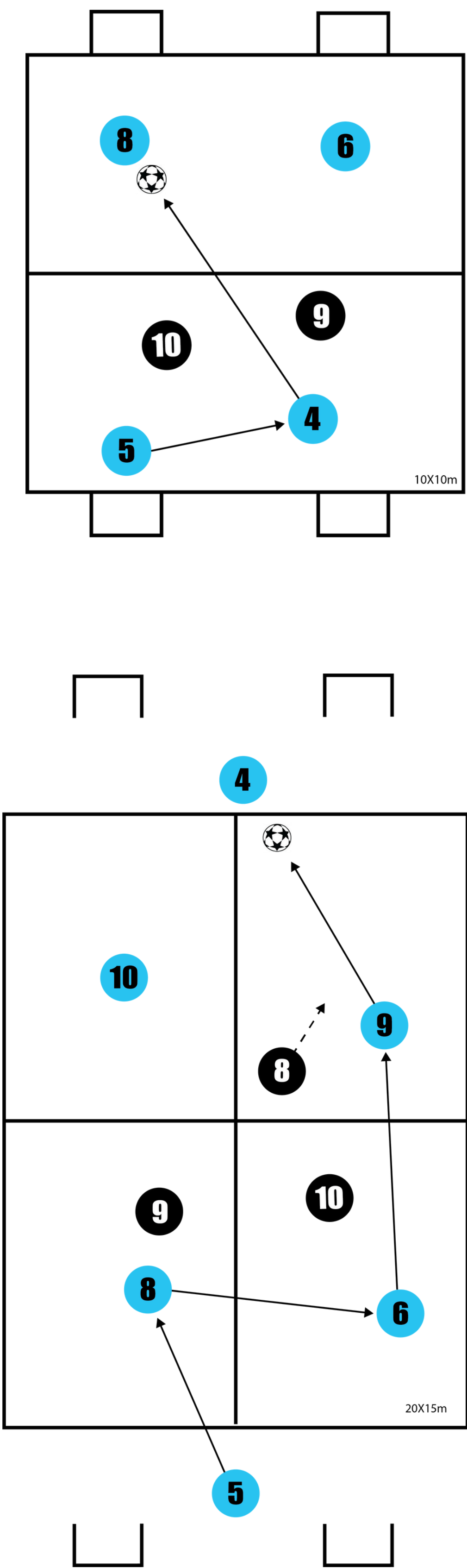
6 v 3 POSITIONAL RONDO:

Objective: improving play between center-back pair, the double pivot and central forwards when playing in “the box” shape.

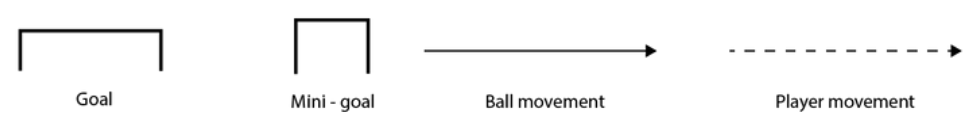
Rules: team in possession (blue) has an aim of transferring the ball from one end to another with 2 touches max. Blue players (6, 8, 9 and 10) must stay inside their respective rectangles. A point is scored after the ball is transferred between two center-backs at the each end, 5 times in a row. Defending players (black) press with intensity, once the ball is recovered they try scoring (black team has unlimited touches in this scenario) in one of the 4 mini-goals on either side, while the blue team counter-press immediately after the loss of possession (they can move freely between the rectangles when out of possession).

COACHING POINTS:

- Support Play: Players must provide support to the player with the ball by offering passing options.
- Positioning: Players should understand when to stay wide and when to come closer to support.
- Quick Thinking: Encourage quick thinking and fast decision-making to keep the tempo high. Players should be aware of their next move before receiving the ball.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING “THE BOX” SHAPE II

4 v 4 + 4 POSITIONAL RONDO:

Objective: improving play between center-back pair, the double pivot and central forwards when playing in “the box” shape.

Rules: team in possession (blue in the diagram) has an aim of transferring the ball from one end to another. Neutral players (green) positioned at each end play with the team in possession. A point is scored when 2 transfers in a row from one end to another are completed. Players can rotate between their rectangle zones, however, only 1 player can stay in 1 rectangle at a time. Start with unlimited touches and progress to 2 touches max to speed up the play.

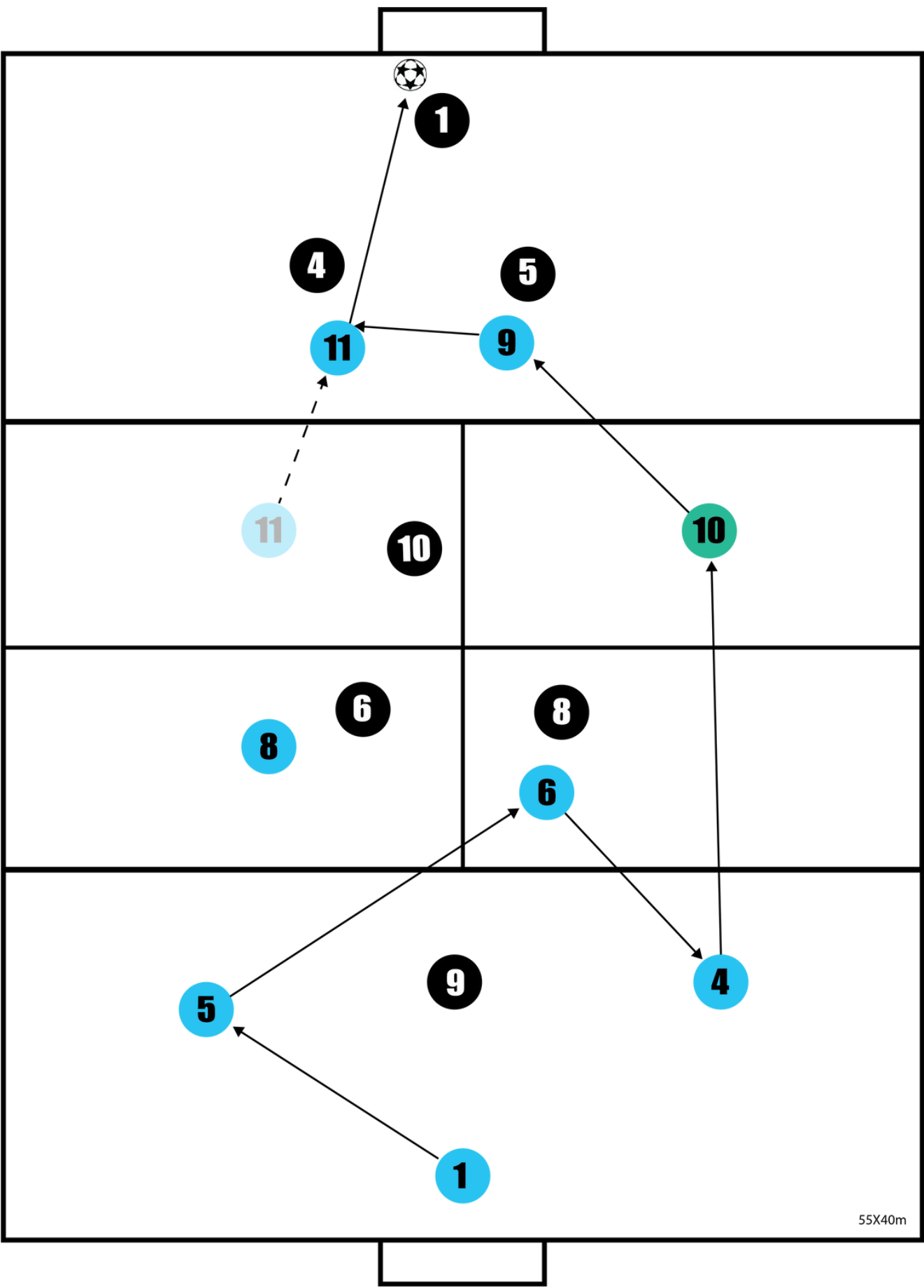
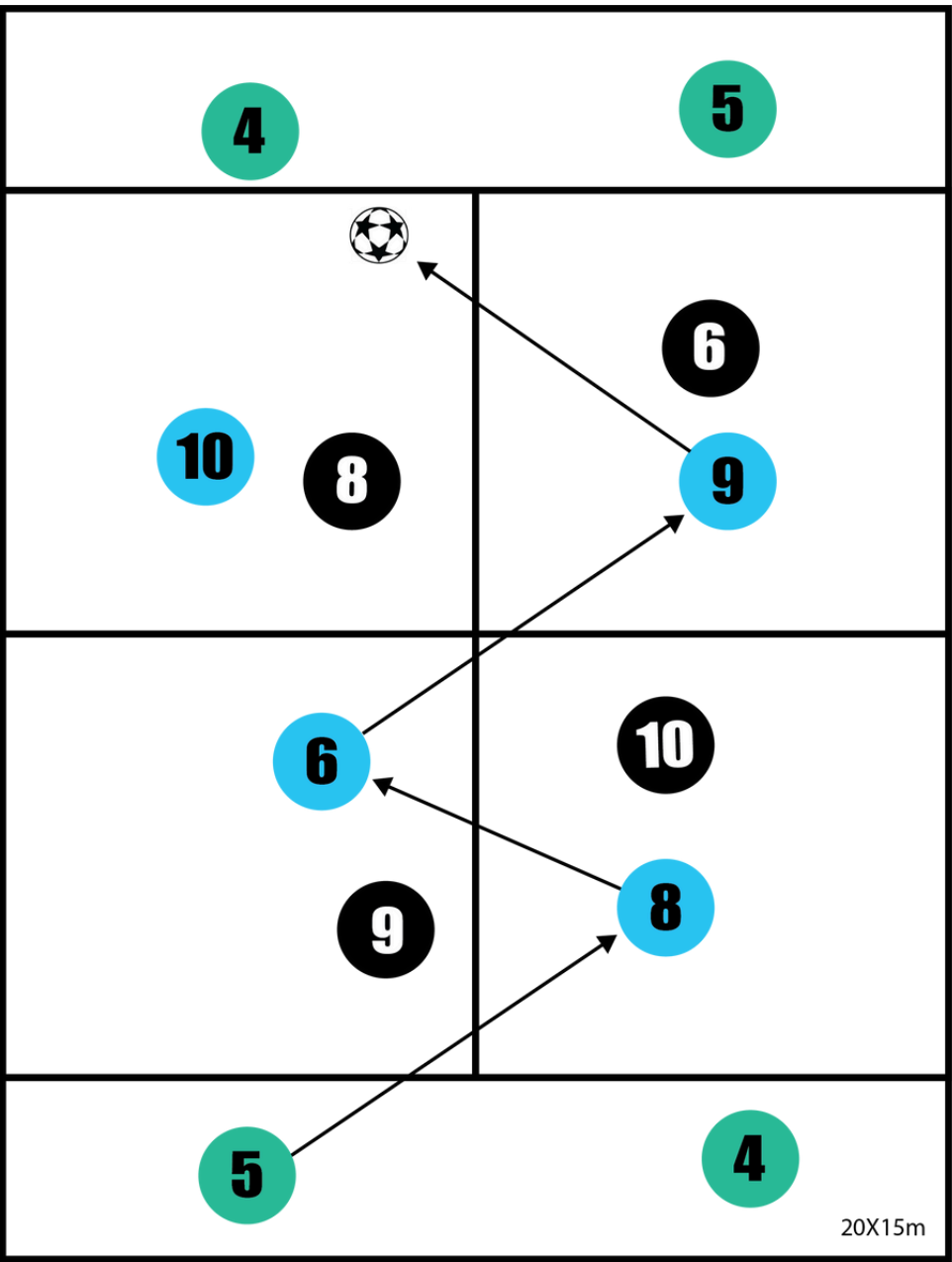
7 v 7 + 1 POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: improving play between goalkeeper, center-back pair, the double pivot and central forwards when playing in “the box” shape when building vs the high press.

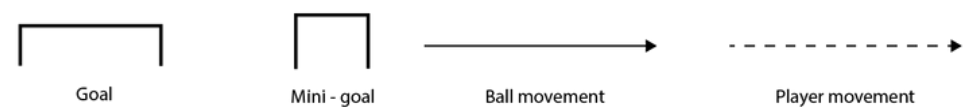
Rules: game starts with a goalkeeper in possession of the ball (blue in the diagram) playing the ball to one of the center-backs with defending team’s striker (black 9) applying the pressure. Center-backs must then pass the ball forward to advanced players, with neutral player (green 10) playing for the team in possession of the ball. Players can rotate between their rectangle zones, however, only 1 player can stay in 1 rectangle at a time. Once the ball is played to striker positioned in the finishing zone (blue 9), a second player (blue 11) can join the striker in the finishing zone in a 2v2+GK situation, after which they have 5 seconds to score. Once the team losses possession they initiate counter-pressing with players allowed to move freely between zones.

COACHING POINTS:

- Support Play: Players must provide support to the player with the ball by offering passing options.
- Positioning: Players should understand when to stay wide and when to come closer to support.
- Quick Thinking: Encourage quick thinking and fast decision-making to keep the tempo high.
- Finding the third-man: Encourage players to look for the third-man, utilizing the numerical advantage provided by the neutral player in midfield.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING PROGRESSING USING THE S-COMBINATION I

S-COMBINATION PASSING ACTIVATION:

Objective: improving play between center-back pair and the double pivot when executing the s-combination.

Rules: center-back (blue 5) plays the ball to his center-back partner (blue 4), who then plays the ball forward with one of the pivots dropping (blue 6) and the second pivot (blue 8) moving forward. Blue 6 plays a one touch diagonal pass to his double pivot partner, while blue 8 needs to score with a one touch pass upon receiving the ball. Keep switching the roles (of the passer and the receiver) as practice progresses.

2 v 2 + 4 POSITIONAL GAME:

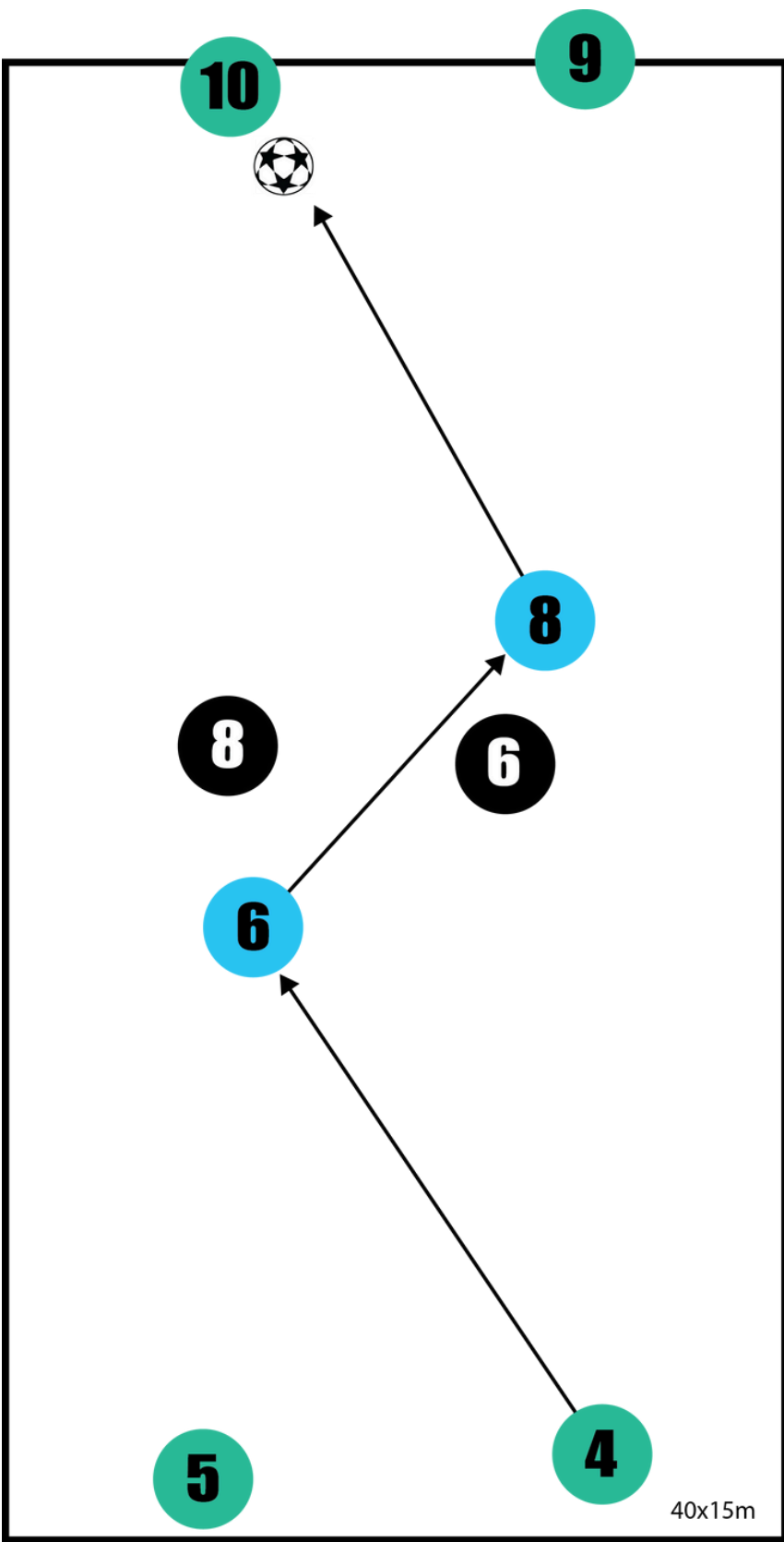
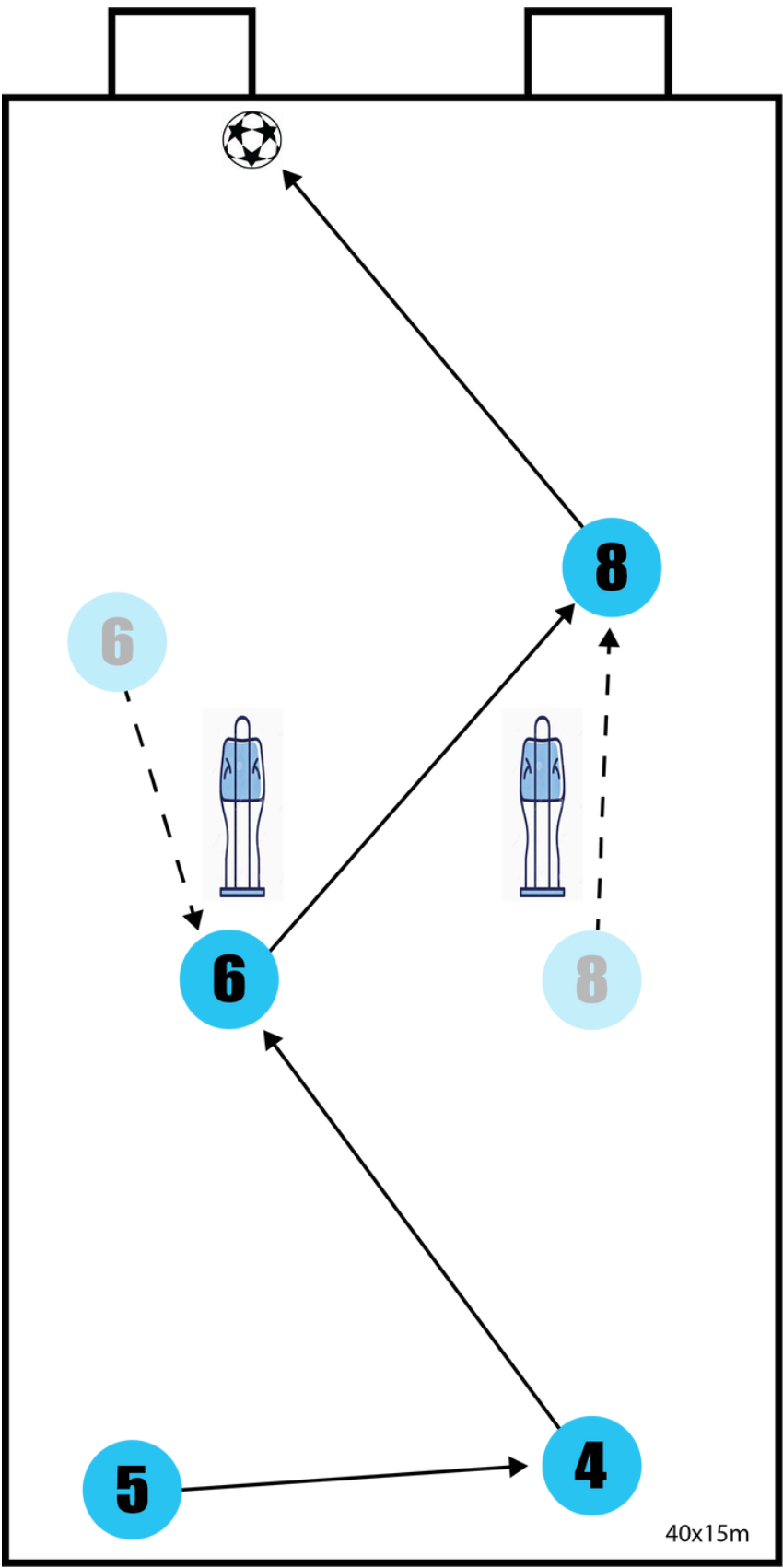
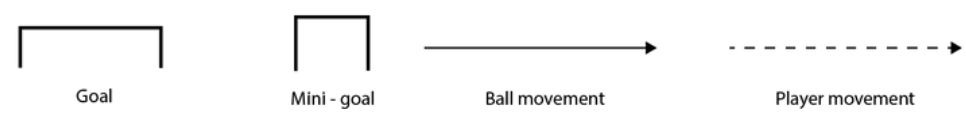
Objective: improving play between center-back pair, double pivot and center forwards when progressing with the s-combination.

Rules: 2 sets of double pivots fight for possession of the ball with an aim of progressing from one end to another, while 4 neutral players (green, 2 center-backs and 2 center-forwards) play with the team in possession. To score a point double pivot need to combine with each other before progressing the ball to the other end. If they progress through a one touch s-combination (as shown in the diagram) they score 2 points.

COACHING POINTS:

- Support Play: Players must provide support to the player with the ball by offering passing options.
- Positioning: Players should understand when to stay wide and when to come closer to support.
- Quick Thinking: Encourage quick thinking and fast decision-making to keep the tempo high. Players should be aware of their next move before receiving the ball.
- Quality of Passing: Focus on the weight and accuracy of passes. Passes should be firm but not overly hard.
- Movement off the ball: Emphasize the importance of intelligent movement off the ball to create space and passing lanes.

Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING PROGRESSING USING THE S-COMBINATION II

6 v 6 SMALL SIDED GAME:

Objective: improving play between center-back pair, double pivot and center forwards when progressing with the s-combination.

Rules: two teams playing with an aim of scoring in one of the two mini-goals, the game has a natural flow to it, but before scoring teams must play through their double pivot (6 and 8). Regular goal is 1 point, however, the goal scored after the double pivot s-combination (as shown in the diagram), is awarded with 2 points. If the team in possession recovers the ball, they can score straight away (without the need of playing through the double pivot), but with only 5 seconds to do so.

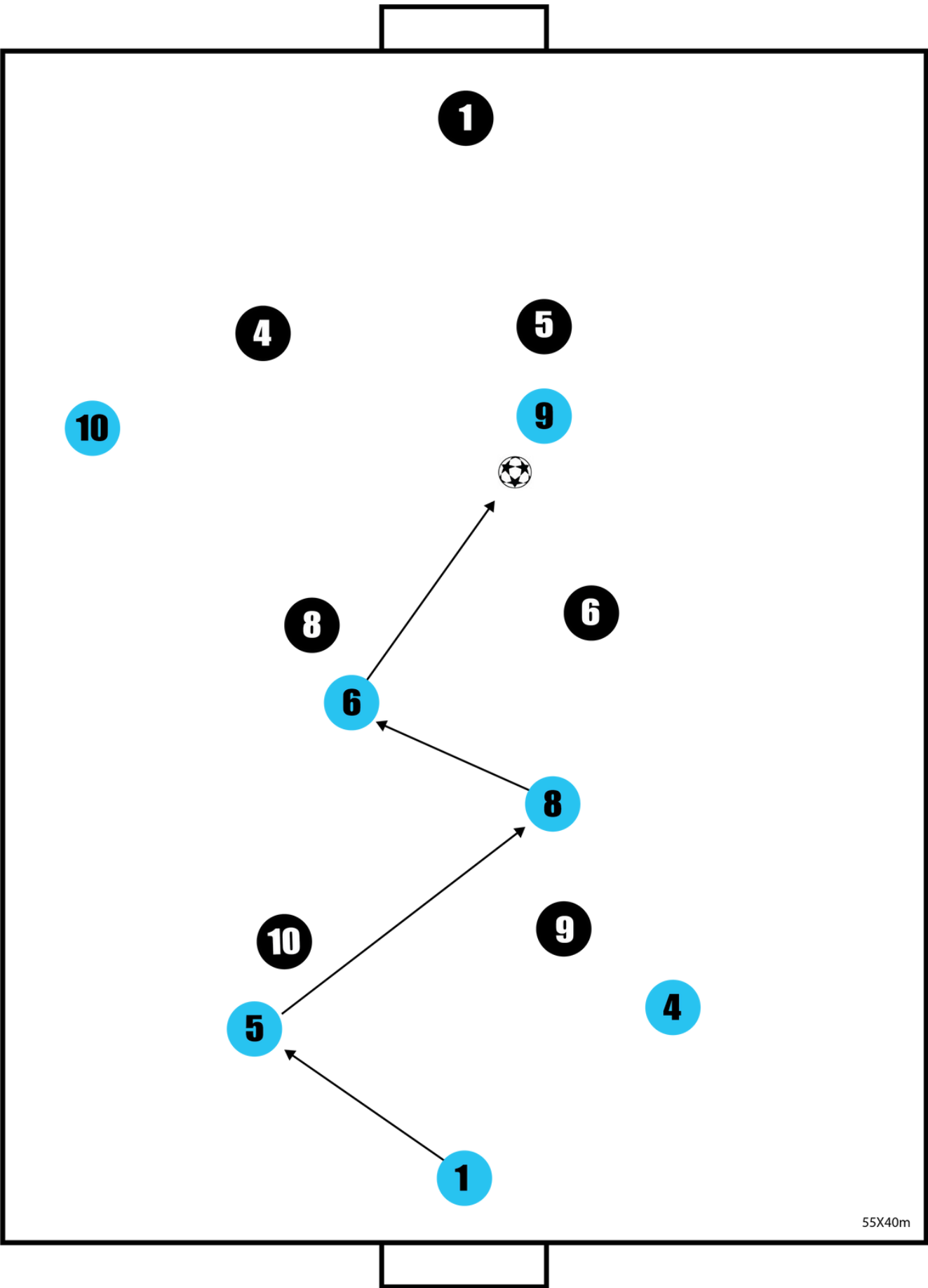
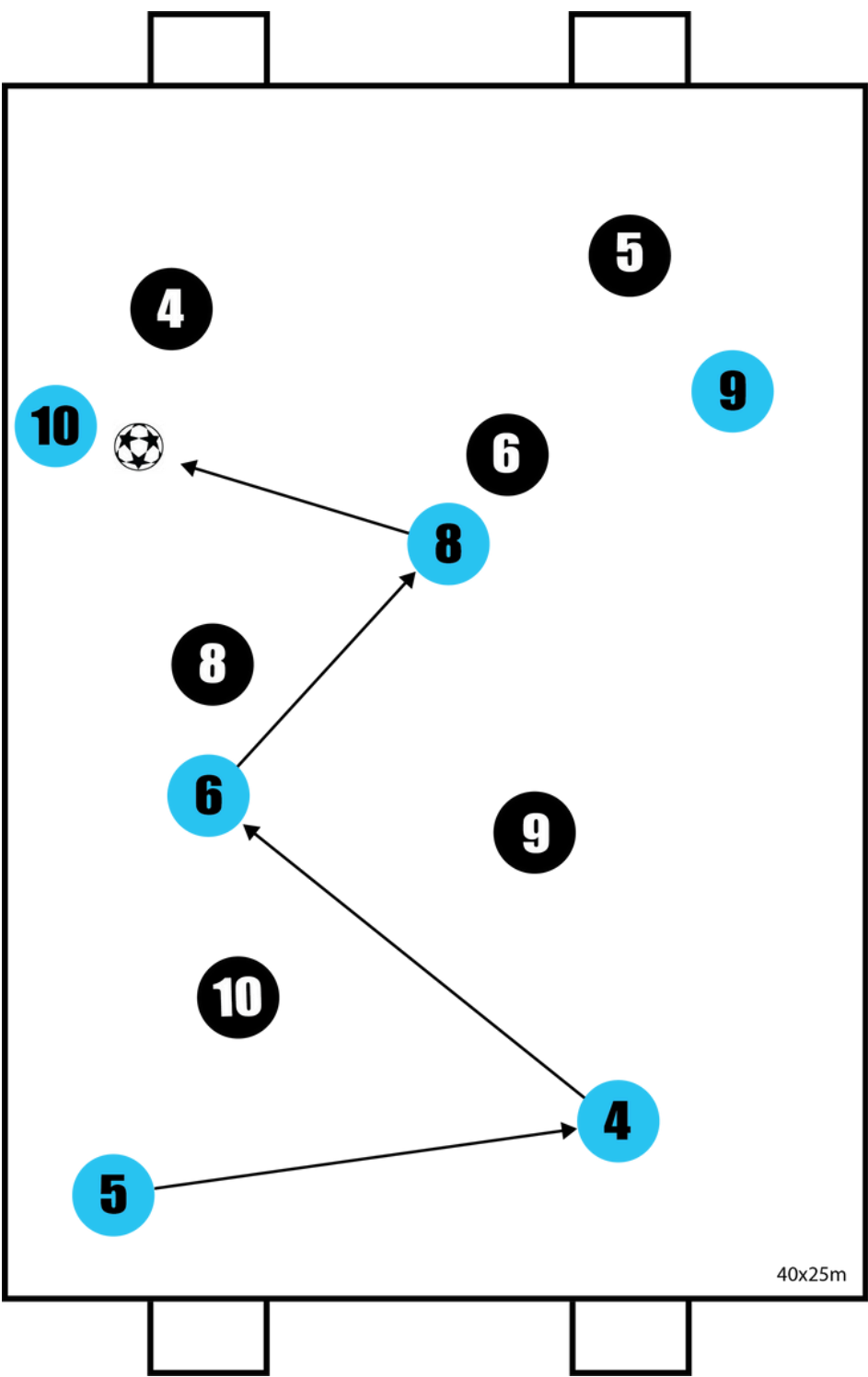
7 v 7 SMALL SIDED GAME:

Objective: improving play between goalkeeper, center-back pair, double pivot and center forwards when progressing with the s-combination.

Rules: two teams playing with an aim of scoring, the game has a natural flow to it, but before scoring teams must play through their double pivot (6 and 8). Regular goal is 1 point, however, the goal scored after the double pivot s-combination (as shown in the diagram), is awarded with 2 points. If the team in possession recovers the ball, they can score straight away (without the need of playing through the double pivot), but with only 5 seconds to do so.

COACHING POINTS:

- Finding the third-man: Encourage players to look for the third-man. The third man should be proactive in their movement, finding pockets of space to receive the ball. Movement should be synchronized with the ball carrier's actions.
- Recognizing Patterns: Develop players' ability to scan the field and anticipate movement. Teach players to recognize when a teammate can run into space created by others.
- Transitions: Emphasize the need for immediate reaction upon losing or winning the ball. Players should switch their mindset instantly. Highlight the importance of the first five seconds after a transition.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING BUILD-UP PLAY IN “THE HOURGLASS” SHAPE

6 v 4 POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: improving play between center-back pair, double pivot and center forwards when building play in hourglass shape.

Rules: team in possession (blue) aiming to progress the ball and score in one of the 3 mini-goals, while the defending team (black) trying to prevent the blue team from progressing by pressing with intensity in a 2-2 shape. If black team recover the ball they are aiming to score into one of the 3 mini-goals. To progress blue team must play through the double pivot (as shown in the diagram). Start with unlimited touches and progress to 2 touches max to speed up the play.

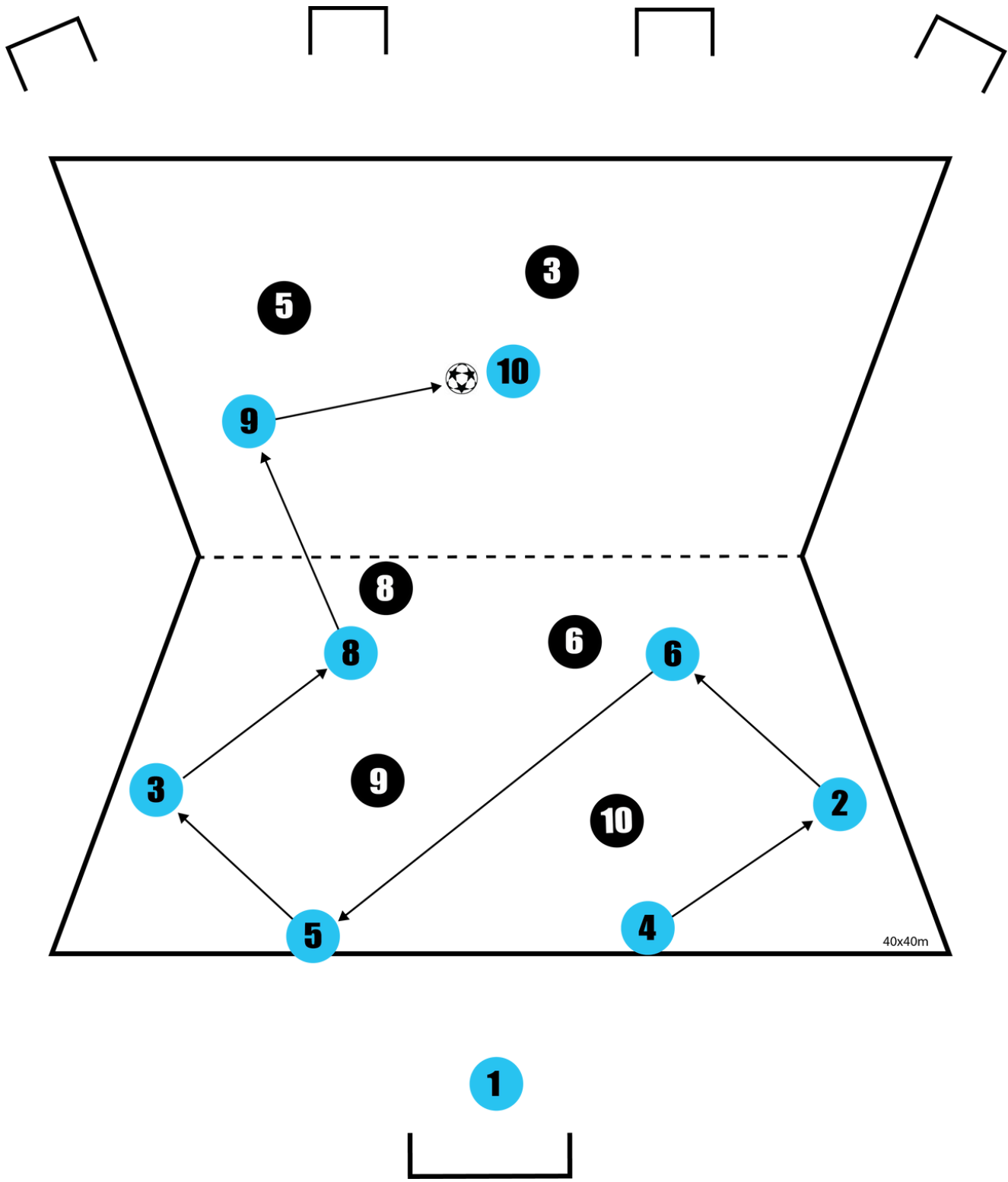
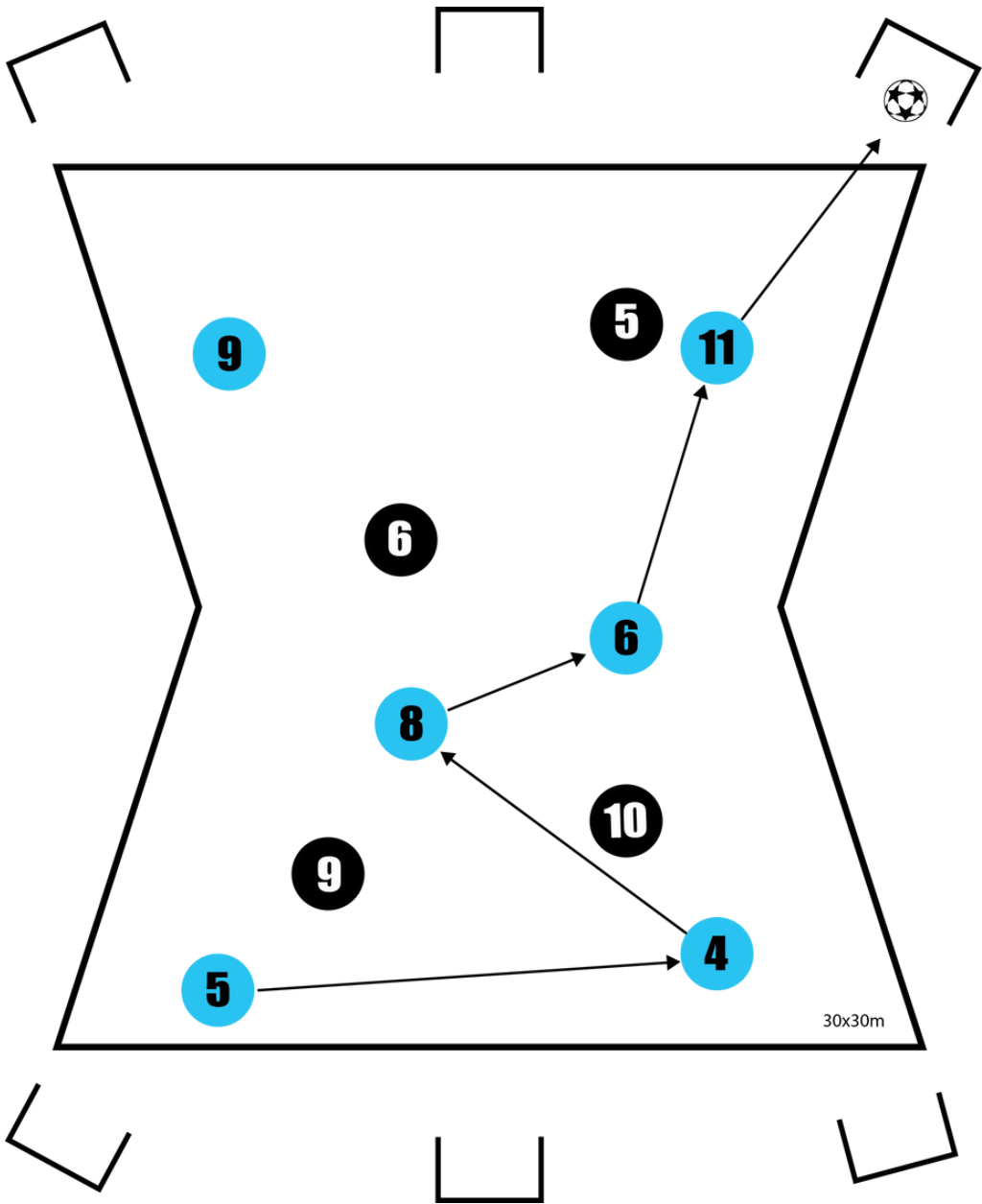
8 + GK v 6 POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: improving play between goalkeeper, full-backs, center-backs, double pivot and center forwards when building play in hourglass shape vs the high press.

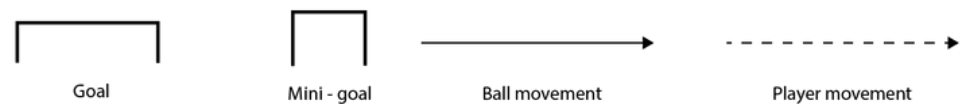
Rules: team in possession (blue) aiming to progress the ball from the build up zone into the finishing zone where two attacking players (blue 9 and 10) are located. Blue team must complete 5 passes before being able to pass the ball into the finishing zone, once the ball in the finishing zone one player from the build up zone can join attacking players in a 3v2 situation, aiming to score into one of the 4 mini-goals (they have 5 seconds to score once in the finishing zone). Hourglass shape is forcing full-backs from the blue team to focus on playing through the double pivot in order to progress the ball into the finishing zone. Black team press with intensity in a 2-2-2 shape, if the ball is recovered they have 5 seconds to score.

COACHING POINTS:

- Finding the third-man: Encourage players to look for the third-man. The third man should be proactive in their movement, finding pockets of space to receive the ball. Movement should be synchronized with the ball carrier's actions.
- Transitions: Emphasize the need for immediate reaction upon losing or winning the ball. Players should switch their mindset instantly.
- Recognizing Patterns: Develop players' ability to scan the field and anticipate movement. Teach players to recognize when a teammate can run into space created by others.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING BUILD-UP PLAY VS THE HIGH PRESS IN A 2-4-2-2 FORMATION I

7 v 4 POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: improving play between center-back pair, full-backs, double pivot and attacking midfielder when building in a 2-4-2-2 formation vs the high press.

Rules: game starts with the blue team in possession of the ball with 2 touches max, they need to connect five passes in a row before being able to score in one of the two mini-goals (as shown in the diagram). Mini-goals placed at a diagonal angle forcing players to find the attacking midfielder in the center for the best finishing angle. Defending team (black) press with intensity in a 2-2 formation, once they recover the ball they have unlimited touches and 5 seconds to score in one of the 3 mini-goals.

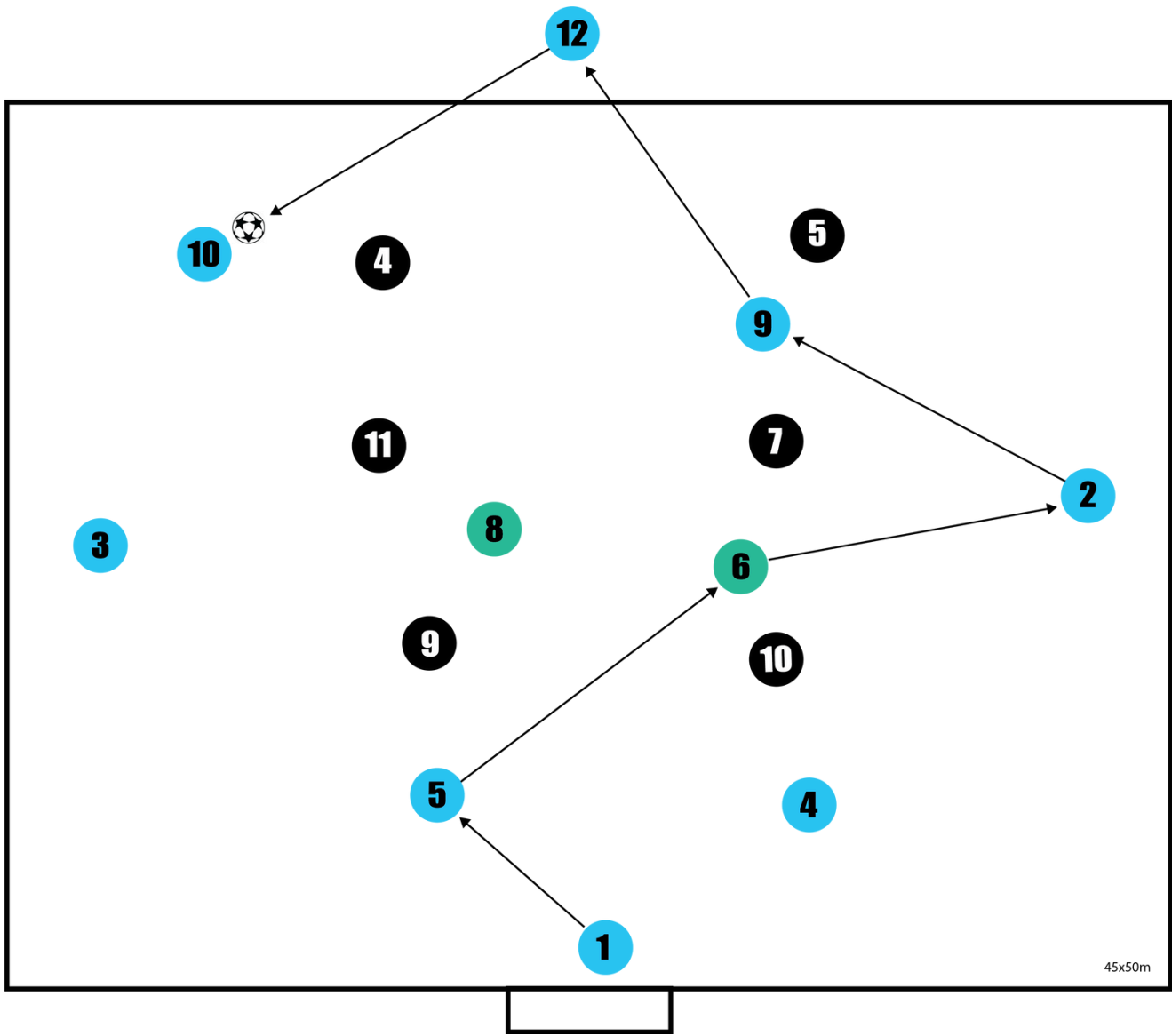
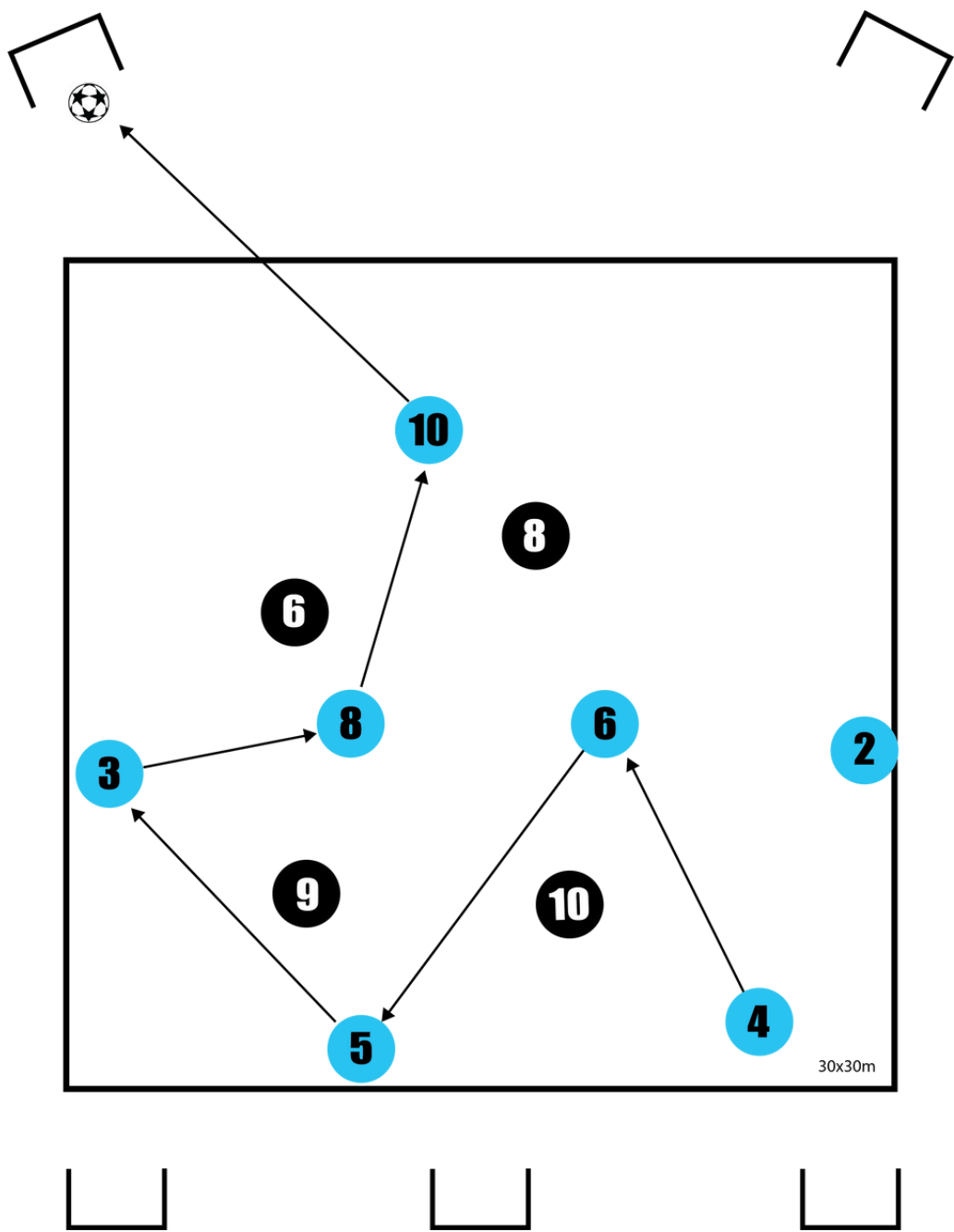
6 + 2 GK v 6 + 2 POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: improving play between goalkeeper, center-back pair, full-backs, double pivot and attacking midfielders when building in a 2-4-2-2 formation vs the high press.

Rules: game starts with the goalkeeper (blue 1) in possession of the ball, blue team controls possession with an aim of progressing the ball to the second goalkeeper (blue 12) positioned at the other end of the play area. Blue team has 2 touches max and needs to connect 5 passes before progressing the ball to blue 12. A point is scored once the ball travels from blue 1 to blue 12 and back. Double pivot (green) act as neutral players and play for the team in possession of the ball. Defending team (black) press with intensity in a 2-2-2 formation, once they recover the ball they have unlimited touches and 7 seconds to score. When the possession is lost, blue team immediately initiates the counter-pressing effort.

COACHING POINTS:

- Finding the third-man: Encourage players to look for the third-man. The third man should be proactive in their movement, finding pockets of space to receive the ball. Movement should be synchronized with the ball carrier's actions.
- Understanding Roles: Ensure all players understand their specific roles and responsibilities within the 2-4-2-2 formation when building up play.
- Quick, Short Passes: Emphasize quick, short passes to avoid losing possession and to outplay the pressing players. Look for opportunities to play vertical passes through the lines to break the press.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING BUILD-UP PLAY VS THE HIGH PRESS IN A 2-4-2-2 FORMATION II

8+GK v 8 PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

Objective: improving play between center-back pair, full-backs, double pivot and attacking midfielders when building in a 2-4-2-2 formation vs the high press.

Rules: game starts with the blue team's goalkeeper in possession of the ball. Blue team aiming to progress the ball up the pitch and score in one of the five mini-goals located in each of the vertical channels. Defending team (black) press with intensity in a 2-4-2 formation, once they recover the ball they have 7 seconds to score, while the blue team immediately initiates the counter-pressing effort.

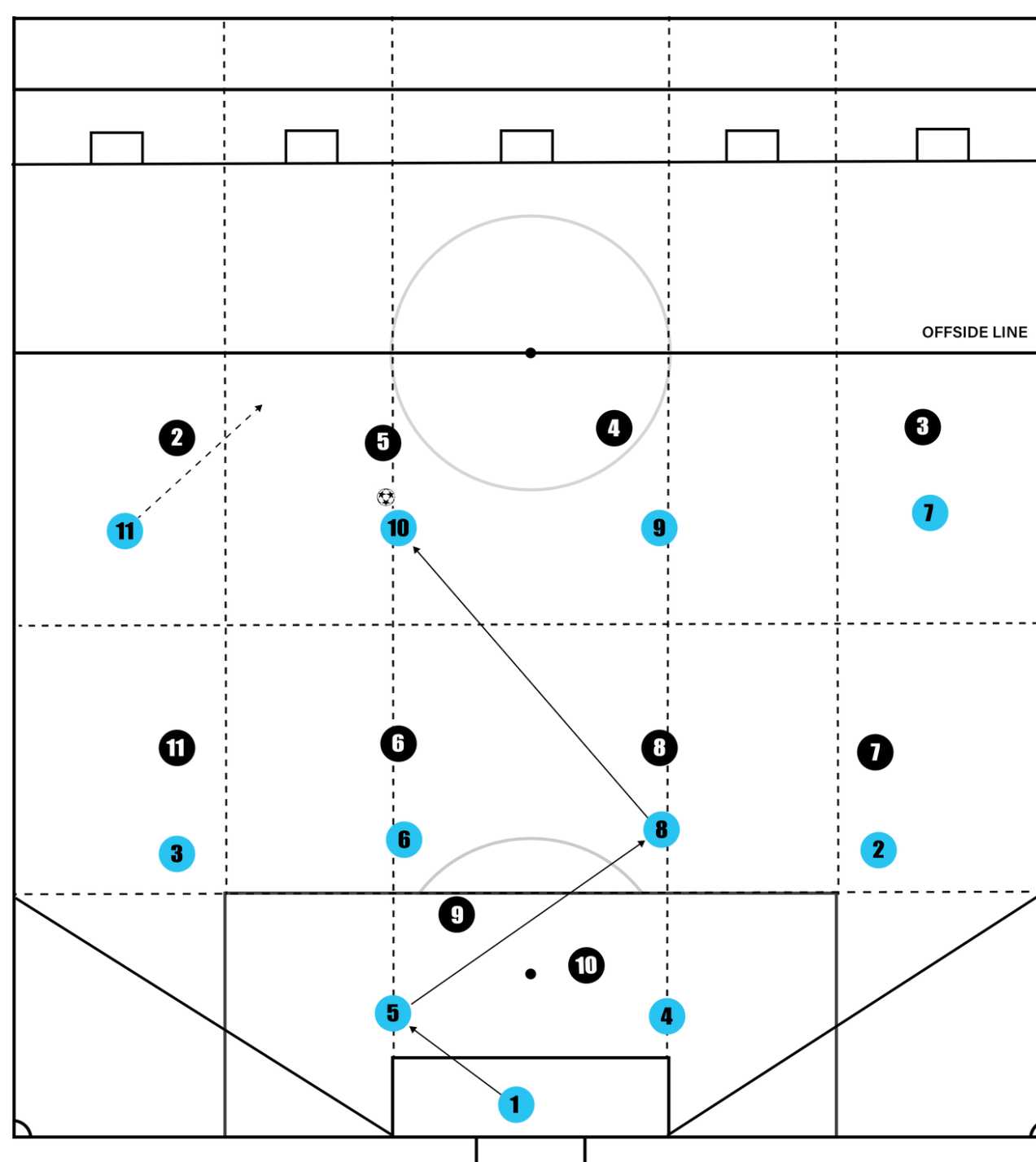
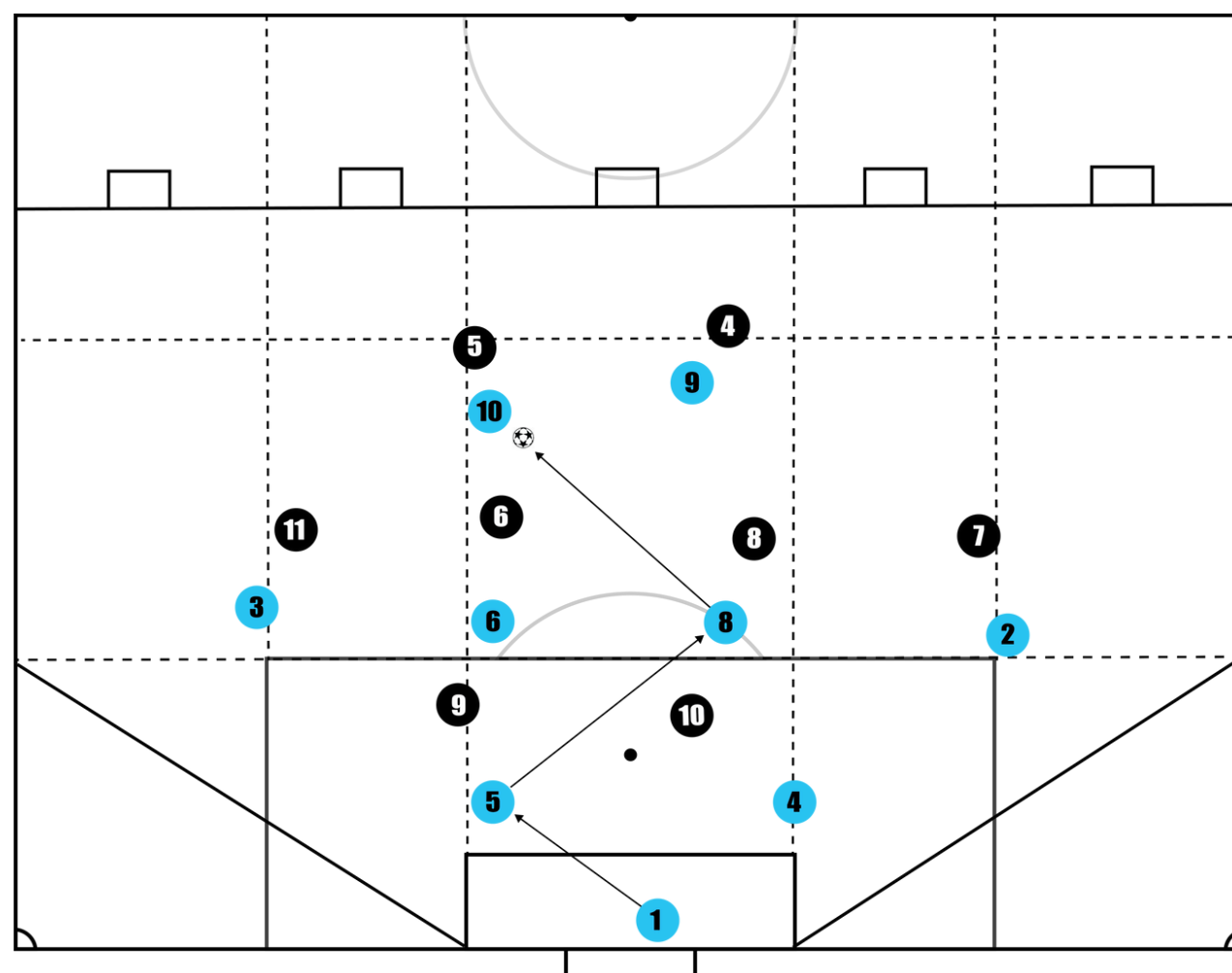
10 + GK v 10 PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

Objective: improving full squad play when building in a 2-4-2-2 formation vs the high press.

Rules: game starts with the blue team's goalkeeper in possession of the ball. Blue team aiming to progress the ball up the pitch and score in one of the five mini-goals located in each of the vertical channels. Defending team (black) press with intensity in a 4-4-2 formation, once they recover the ball they have 8 seconds to score, while the blue team immediately initiates the counter-pressing effort.

COACHING POINTS:

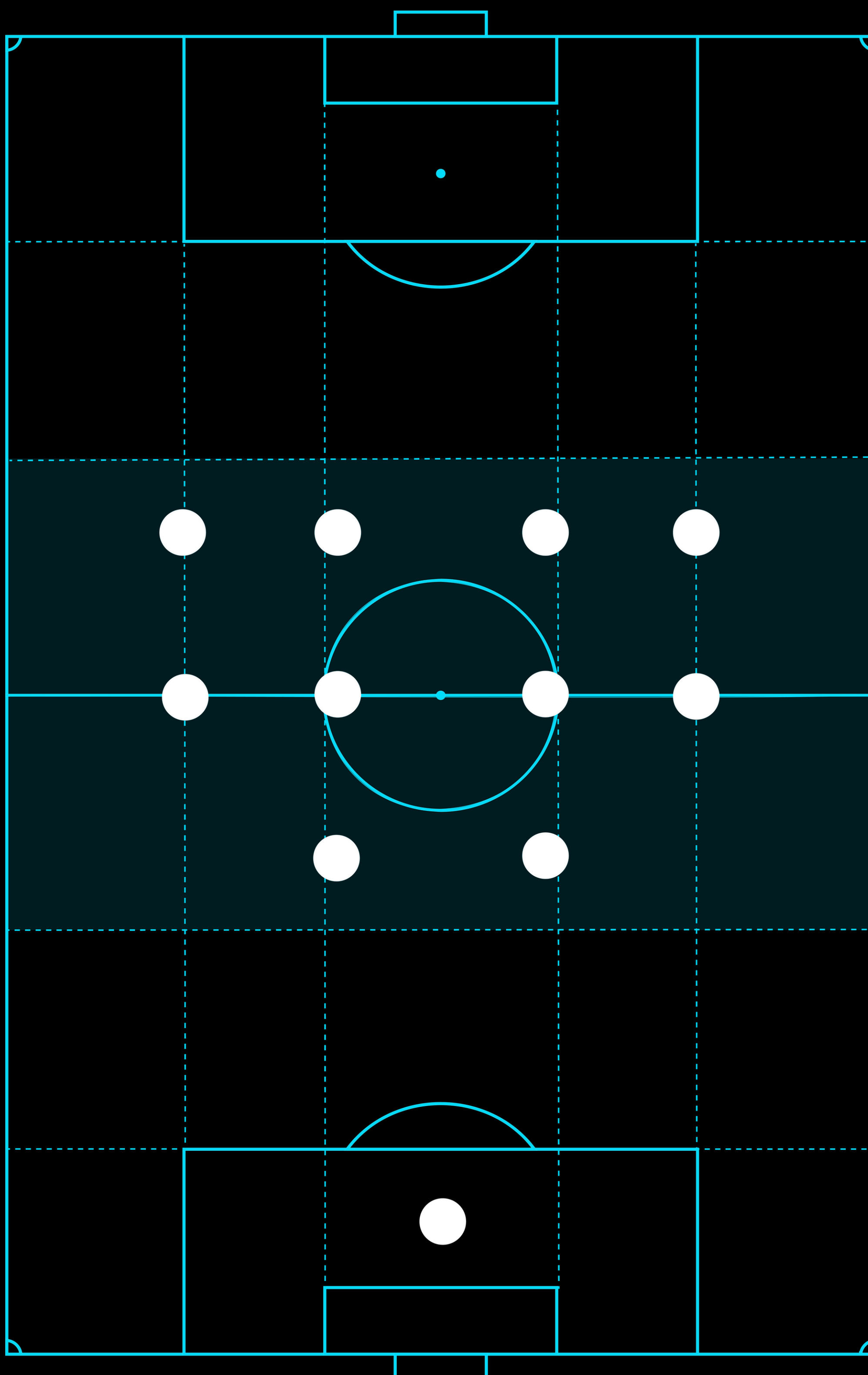
- Understanding Roles: Ensure all players understand their specific roles and responsibilities within the 2-4-2-2 formation when building up play.
- Finding the third-man: Encourage players to look for the third-man, use goalkeepers to create numerical superiority. Movement should be synchronized with the ball carrier's actions.
- Invite the pressure: Players must be patient with the ball, inviting the opposition to press by holding possession in deeper areas and creating space higher up the pitch.
- Decision making: Once opposition initiates the press, players must quickly assess the situation and make a decision whether to progress through short passing combinations (s-combinations) or play more direct.
- Transitions: Emphasize the need for immediate reaction upon losing or winning the ball. Players should switch their mindset instantly.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



PART II: PLAYING THROUGH THE MID-BLOCK



RISK AS A STRATEGY VS MID-DEFENSIVE BLOCK

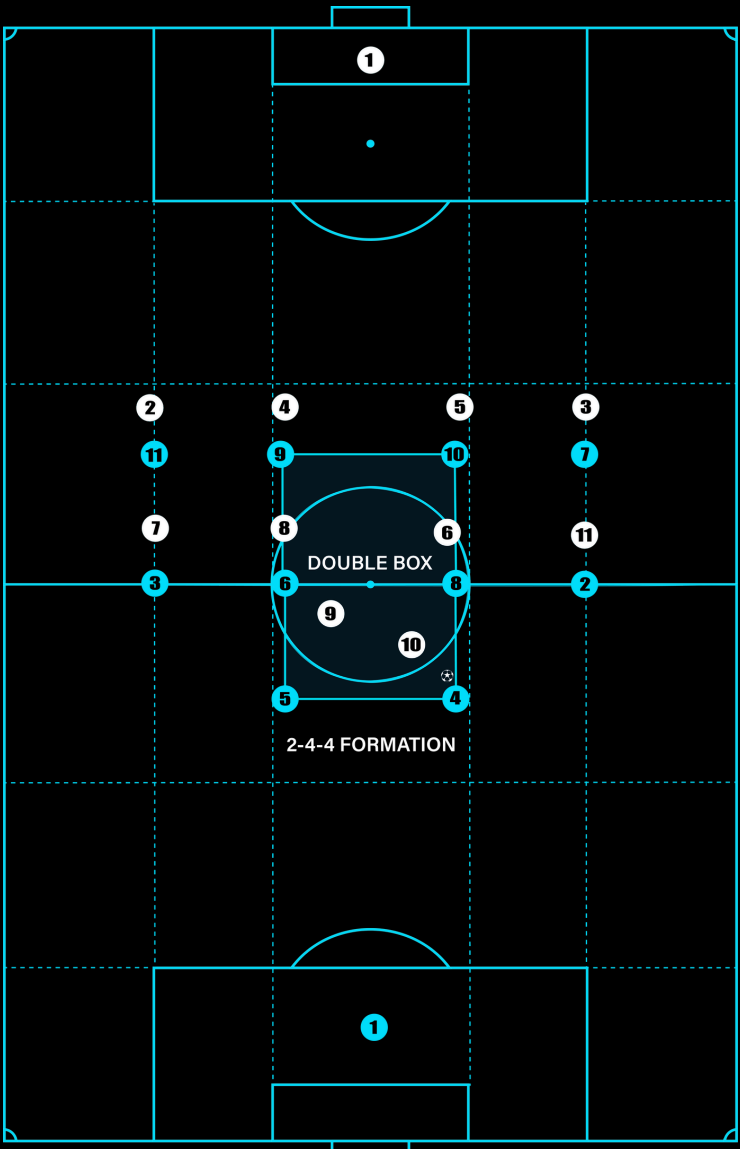
“Against De Zerbi’s Brighton you have to go fully high man to man or stay deep. Never get caught in the middle or they will play around you.” - Thomas Frank

Thomas Frank's quote highlights the tactical acumen of Roberto De Zerbi's Brighton, especially when navigating through an opposition's defensive mid-block. Their tactical setup is designed to manipulate space efficiently, requiring opponents to commit fully in one defensive strategy to counteract them effectively navigating through an opposition's defensive mid-block.

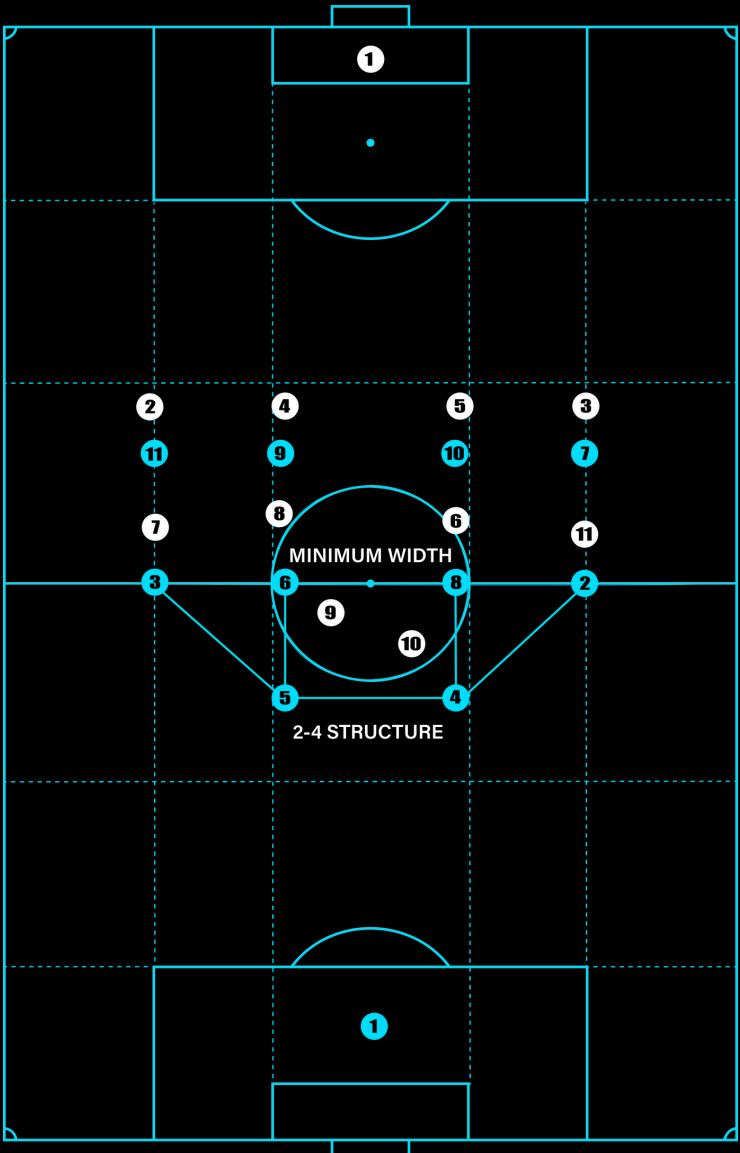
Brighton excels in playing in the transitional spaces between the midfield and defense lines, where they can use quick passes and movement to destabilize the structure. Brighton's style includes "automatic elements" which means the players are trained to perform certain actions reflexively based on specific triggers or scenarios. This results in a game that is fluid and rapid, minimizing the time and space the opposition has to react. This speed and synchronicity in both thought and action enhance their ability to seamlessly connect plays, often making their movements seem un-intuitive to opponents.

Pep Guardiola's tactical approach is rooted in a philosophy where possession of the ball is synonymous with control over the game. His teams, such as Manchester City, are known for their meticulous ball retention, which serves multiple purposes: defensive strategy, transition management and pinning the opposition to low defensive block. Roberto De Zerbi, while also valuing possession, leans towards a more dynamic and riskier use of the ball. His tactical ideology is characterized by rapid vertical movements that contrast with Guardiola’s more horizontal, patient build-up. The phrase “the quicker the ball goes forward, the quicker it comes back” encapsulates De Zerbi's acceptance of the risks associated with losing the ball in advanced positions. While this increases the threat of opposition counters, it also creates opportunities to exploit spaces during initial transitions.

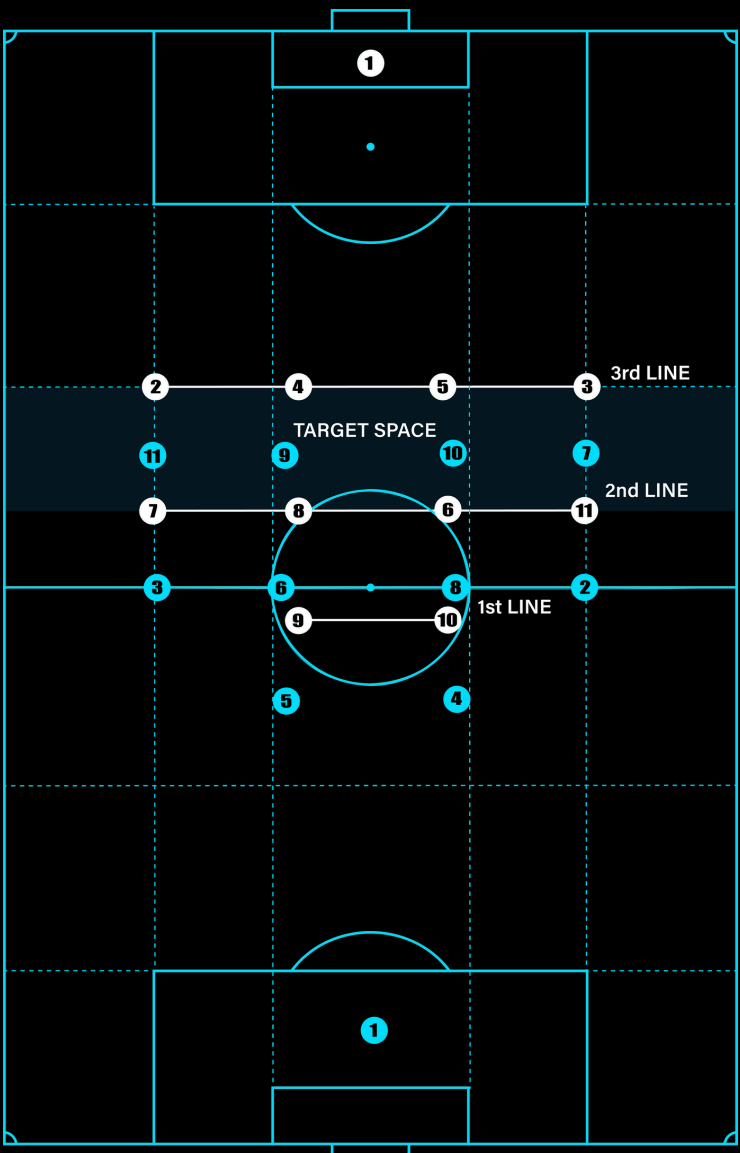
- Against opposition’s mid-defensive block De Zerbi employs a 2-4-4 structure, which is a continuation of his primary build-up formation, with full-backs joining two defensive midfielders in a midfield line. It creates a "double box" in the central area (between two center backs, two defensive midfielders and 2 attacking players). The term "double box" refers to the strategic positioning of players to create two rectangular zones or 'boxes' in central areas — one involving the center backs and defensive midfielders, and the other typically formed by more advanced midfielders and forwards. By creating these central boxes, De Zerbi ensures that his team can control the heart of the pitch. This control is critical in matches where breaking down a mid-defensive block is necessary, as it allows Brighton to concentrate their passing and movement in areas that can dynamically shift the opposition's structure and open up spaces.



2-4-4 formation, with the “double box” structure in the central channel.

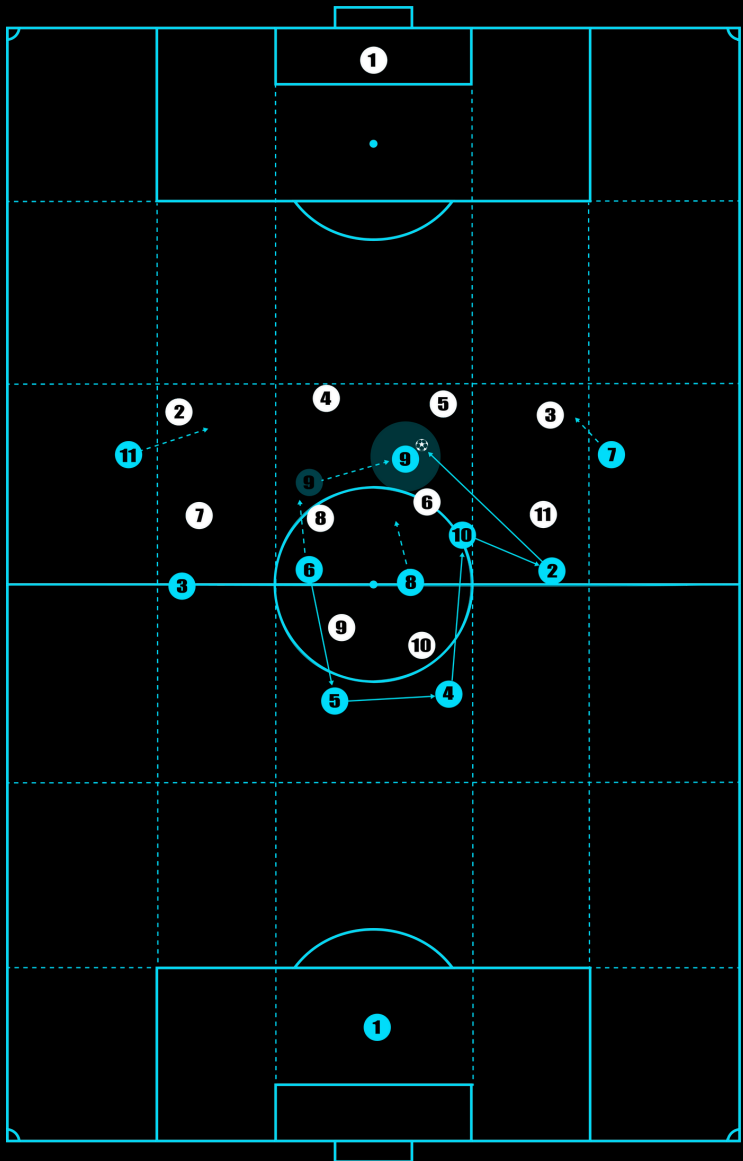


2-4 build up structure with 2 center-backs, 2 inverted full-backs forming a midfield line with 2 defensive midfielders, facilitates short passing, quick combination play and serves as a compact defensive unit in case the ball is lost.

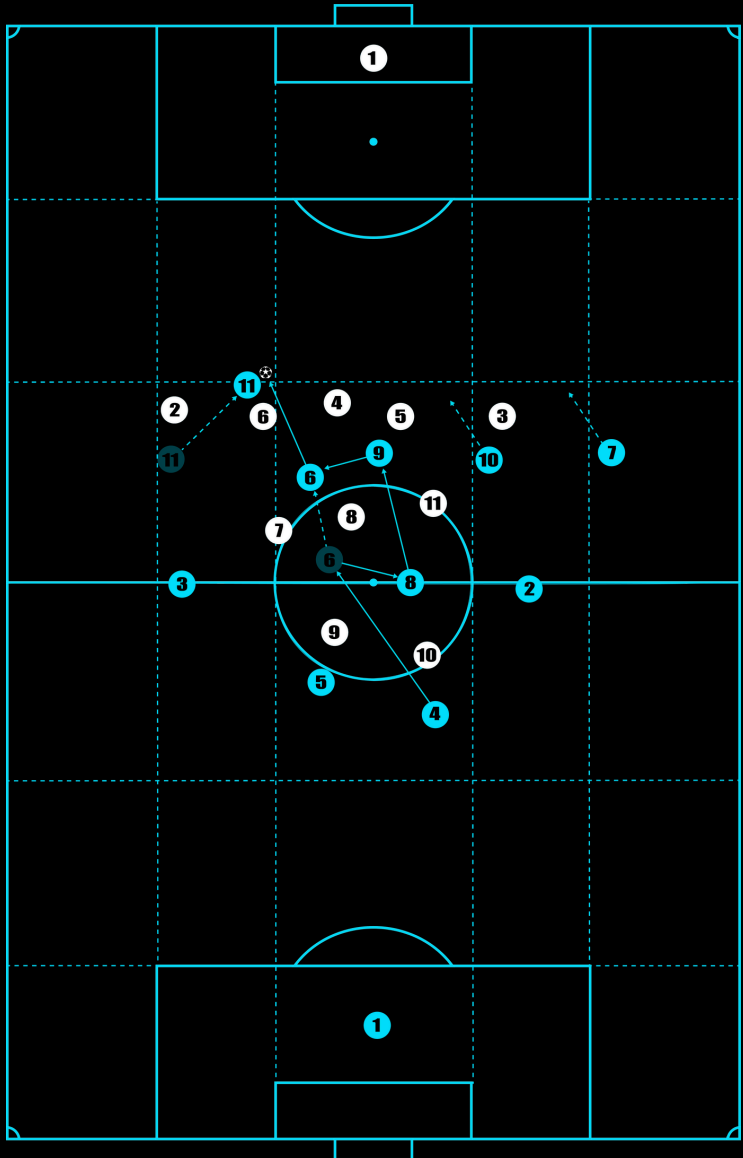


In order to progress through opposition's mid defensive block, De Zerbi targeting the space between the second and third defensive lines.

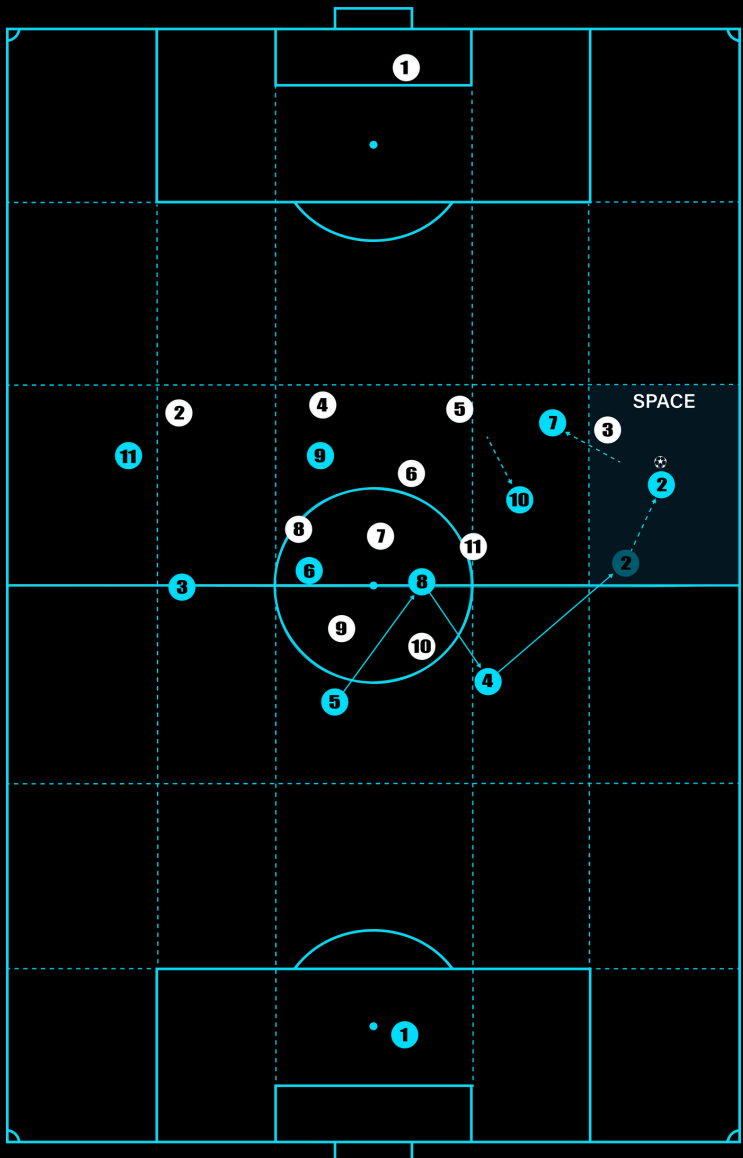
- Minimum width: Roberto De Zerbi's tactical use of the minimum width principle (in a 2-4 structure consisting of: 2 center-backs and 2 inverted full-backs forming a midfield line with 2 defensive midfielders) against opposition's mid-defensive block is a key component of his strategy to maximize control and efficiency in possession, and to create meaningful attacking opportunities. The close proximity of players in the central areas allows Brighton to use short, quick passes to maintain possession. By controlling the ball in tight spaces, Brighton invites the opposition to press. This is a tactical ploy designed to draw the opposition out of their defensive structure, creating spaces behind them that can be exploited. Once the opposition commits to the press, Brighton utilizes quick, vertical third-man combinations to break the press, most commonly: "up, back, through" pattern, along with "one-two's" and "S-combinations" are being utilized. These patterns are particularly effective against a mid-block because they quickly change the point of attack, forcing the opposition to continuously adjust their positioning and focus.
- Defensive solidity: The compact 2-4 structure also has defensive benefits. With many players located centrally, it becomes easier to transition to defense if possession is lost. The team can quickly form a dense block that is difficult for the opposition to penetrate, minimizing the risk of being caught out by fast counter-attacks. The central overload means that there are always sufficient numbers back to defend against quick breaks, it also directs a potential counter-attack into wide areas, which provides more time for the defending team to get back.
- Exploiting space between 2nd and 3rd defensive lines: Roberto De Zerbi's tactical approach is centered around exploiting the space between an opponent's second and third defensive lines, effectively targeting the zones that are typically less densely populated but crucial for defensive stability. The false 9, a crucial component in De Zerbi's strategy, often drops into this space, pulling defenders out of position and creating opportunities for teammates to run into the newly opened channels.
- Wide rotations: When facing a well-organized defense that effectively covers central channels, Roberto De Zerbi's teams adapt by shifting their focus to the wide areas of the pitch. This tactical flexibility allows them to circumvent the congested middle and exploit the flanks through wide rotations and diversified attacking patterns. Wide rotations involve the movement of players in and out of the wide channels to create mismatches and disorient the defensive structure of the opposition. This can include wingers moving inside, full-backs pushing high up the pitch, or midfielders drifting wide to overload one side or cover defensively for the full-back who pushed up.



DM (blue 6) plays the ball back to trigger opposition's pressure, once opposition baits, ACM (blue 10) drops and "up, back, through" combination is being played out, with ST (blue 9) receiving between the defensive lines, while other forwards are making supporting runs.



Despite congested central area, De Zerbi's team play a risky "up, back, through" combination to ST (blue 9), who lays off the ball to one of the DM's (blue 6) making forward run. He then plays a through ball to a winger (blue 11) making a run in-behind.



With opposition's defenders saturating the central channel, De Zerbi's team will play around and progress using wide rotations. With winger (blue 7) moving into the half-space channel, full-back in possession has space to progress himself or pass the ball to either (blue 7) or to AMC (blue 10) who is dropping and making himself available as a passing option.

COACHING PROGRESSING USING THE “UP, BACK, THROUGH” COMBINATION I

4 + 1 v 2 TRANSFER RONDO:

Objective: improving progressions using the “up, back, through” third-man combinations.

Rules: team in possession (blue) control the ball in one half of the rondo area with 2 touches max in a 4v2 situation (with 1 blue player remaining in another half, blue 10 in the diagram) and can only progress the ball into the next half via the “up, back, through” combination. A point is given for every progression. Once the ball is progressed to another half (as shown in the diagram), 3 blue players transfer to another half and create a 4v2 situation again. Defending players (black) press with intensity, once the ball is recovered they have unlimited touches and can score in any of the 4 mini-goals.

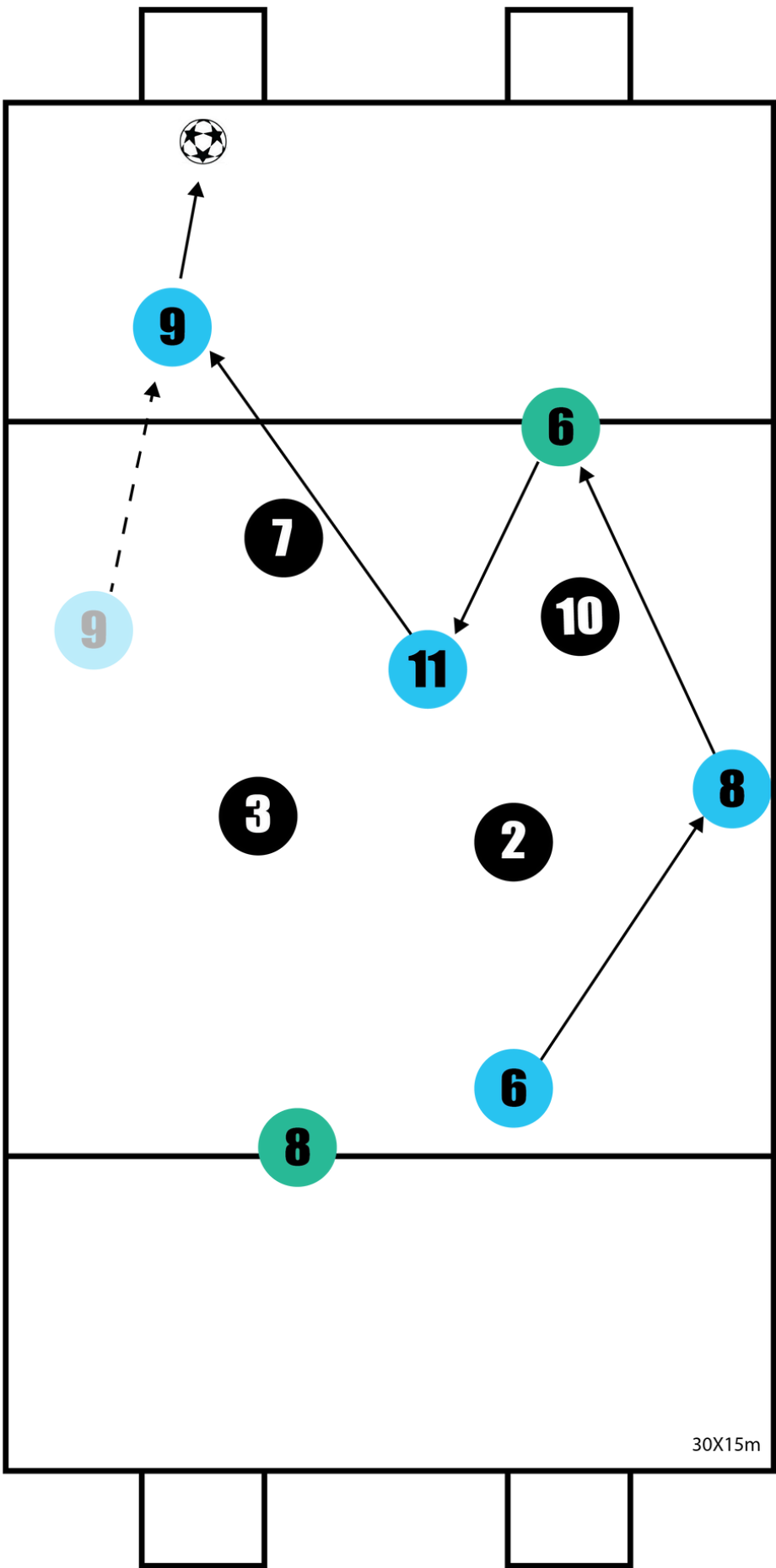
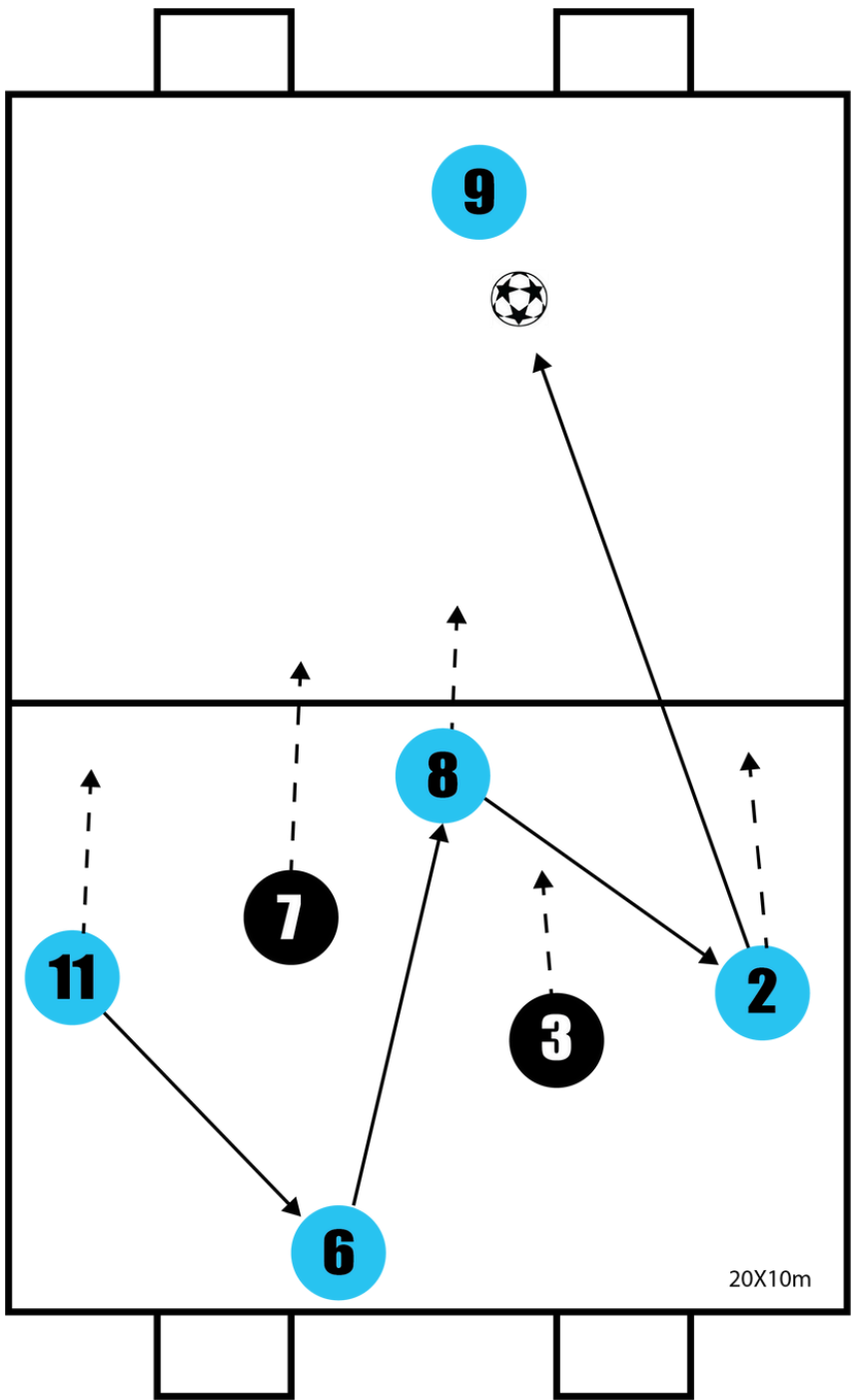
4 v 4 + 2 POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: improving progressions using the “up, back, through” third-man combinations.

Rules: two teams aiming to progress and score using the “up, back, through” combination. Players can only enter the finishing zone after the “up, back, through” combination (as shown in the diagram), once inside the finishing zone, they only have 1 touch to score in one of the 2 mini-goals. Neutral players (green) play with the team in possession and only have 1 touch, start with unlimited touches for the rest of the players and progress to 2 touches max as the game goes on to increase the speed of play.

COACHING POINTS:

- Timing and Speed: The combination should be executed quickly to prevent the defense from reorganizing. Players must move the ball with speed and precision.
- Positional Awareness: The initial pass should help create space by drawing defenders out of position. Players need to be aware of how their movement affects the defensive structure. The support player should position themselves at an angle that facilitates an easy and quick layoff pass.
- Decision Making: Players must read the game and decide whether the "up, back, through" combination is the best option or if other attacking moves are more appropriate. The support player (back receiver) should assess their options quickly upon receiving the ball, deciding whether to play the through ball, switch play, or maintain possession.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING PROGRESSING USING THE “UP, BACK, THROUGH” COMBINATION II

5 + 2 v 5 + 2 SMALL SIDED GAME:

Objective: improving progressions using the “up, back, through” third-man combinations.

Rules: the game has natural flow to it but the goal can only be scored after a one touch back pass from the two players positioned at the end of the play area (blue 4 and 5 in the diagram). Start with unlimited touches and progress to 3 touches max to increase the speed of play.

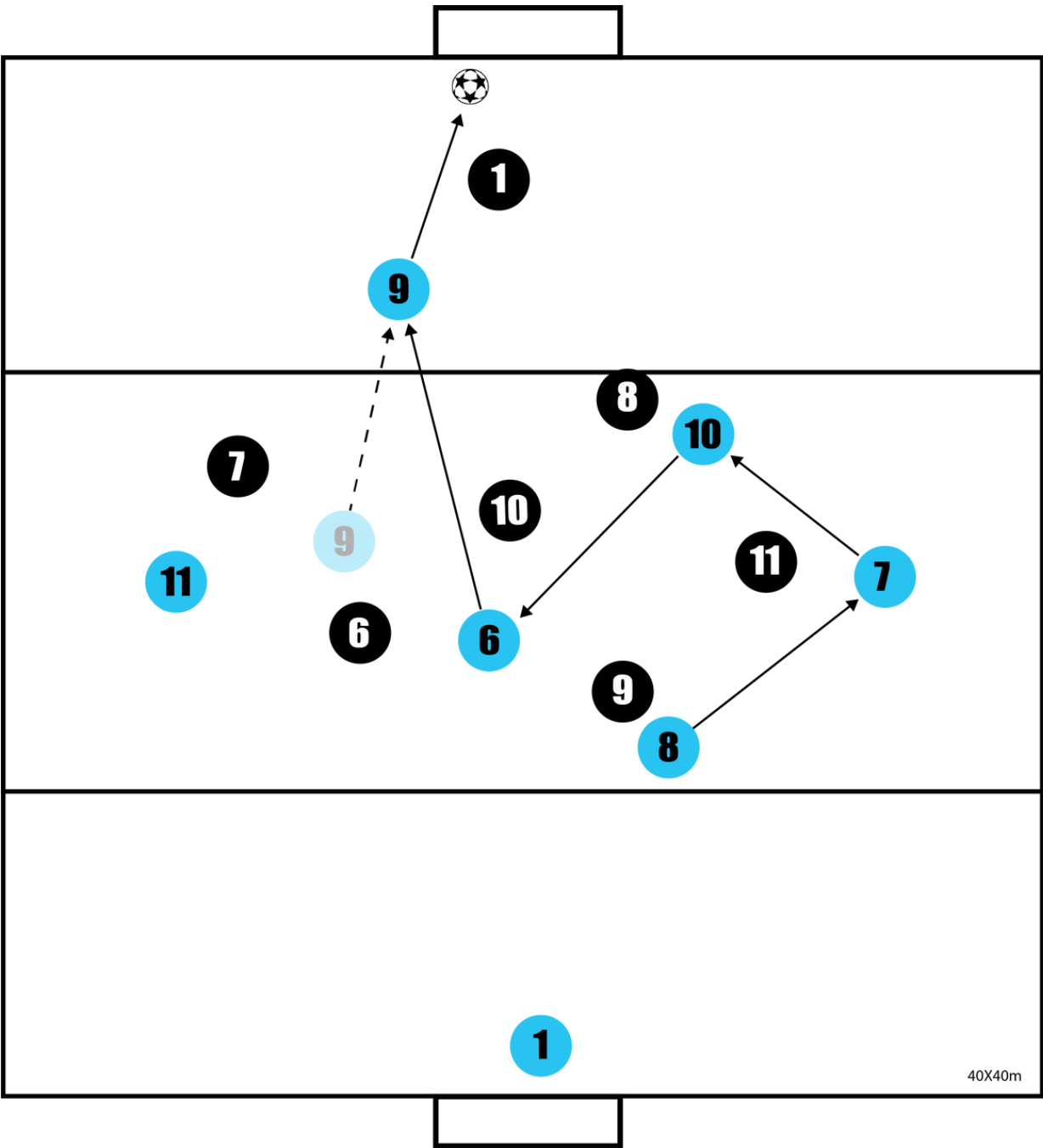
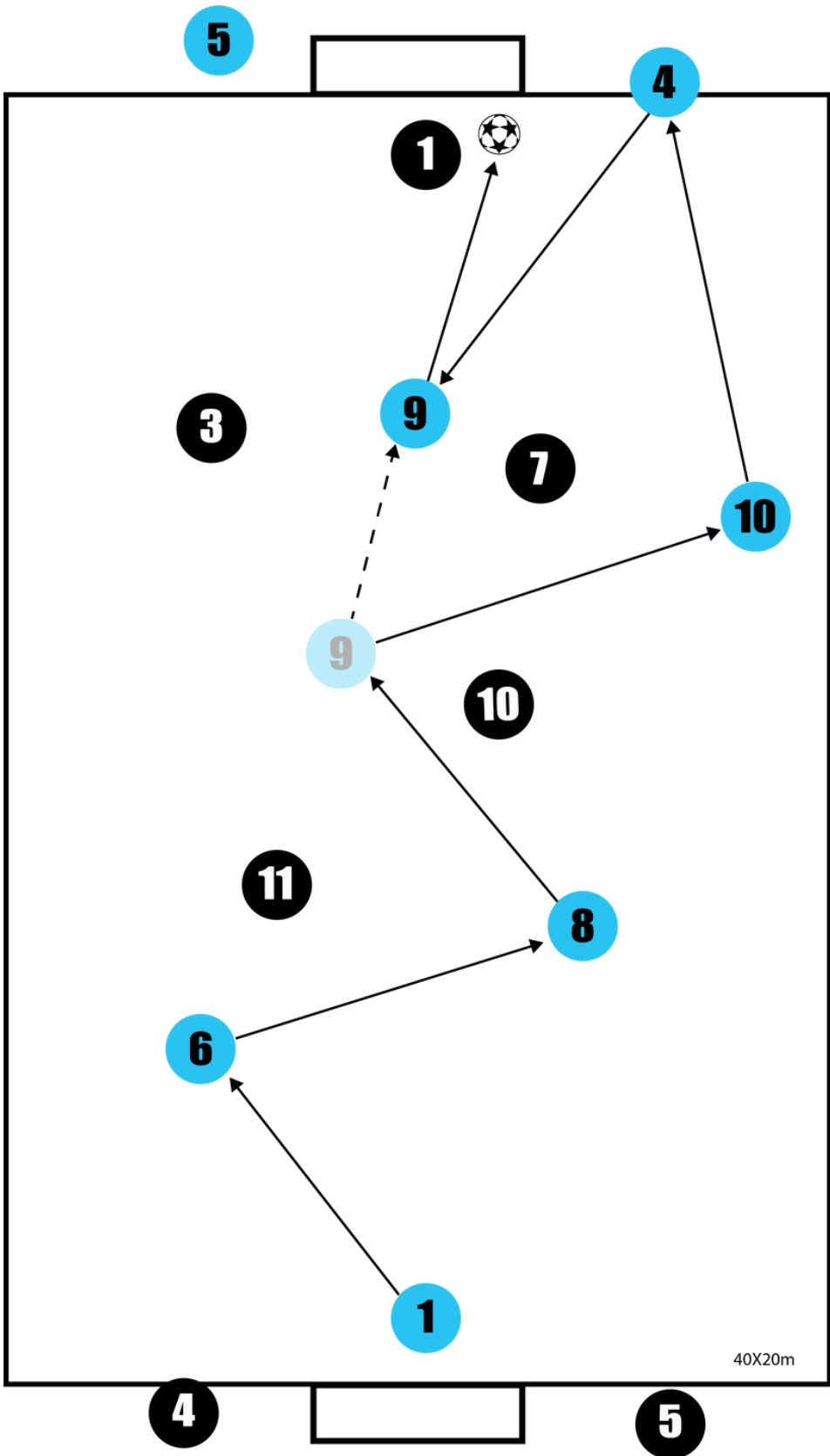
6 + GK v 6 + GK SMALL SIDED GAME:

Objective: improving progressions using the “up, back, through” third-man combinations.

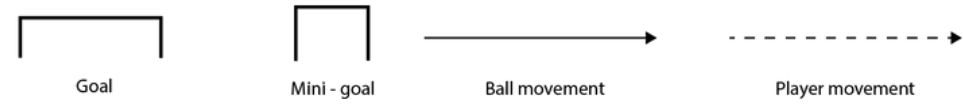
Rules: two teams play in the middle build up zone in a 6v6 situation, aiming to progress and score. Players can only enter the finishing zone after the “up, back, through” combination (as shown in the diagram), once inside the finishing zone, they only have 1 touch to score. Start with unlimited touches for the rest of the players and progress to 3 touches max as the game goes on to increase the speed of play.

COACHING POINTS:

- Timing and Speed: The combination should be executed quickly to prevent the defense from reorganizing. Players must move the ball with speed and precision. The runner must time their movement to stay onside and meet the through ball at the right moment.
- Positional Awareness: The initial pass should help create space by drawing defenders out of position. Players need to be aware of how their movement affects the defensive structure. The support player should position themselves at an angle that facilitates an easy and quick layoff pass.
- Decision Making: Players must read the game and decide whether the "up, back, through" combination is the best option or if other attacking moves are more appropriate. The support player (back receiver) should assess their options quickly upon receiving the ball, deciding whether to play the through ball, switch play, or maintain possession.
- Accurate Passing: Emphasize the importance of precise passes to ensure the sequence can be executed quickly and effectively.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.

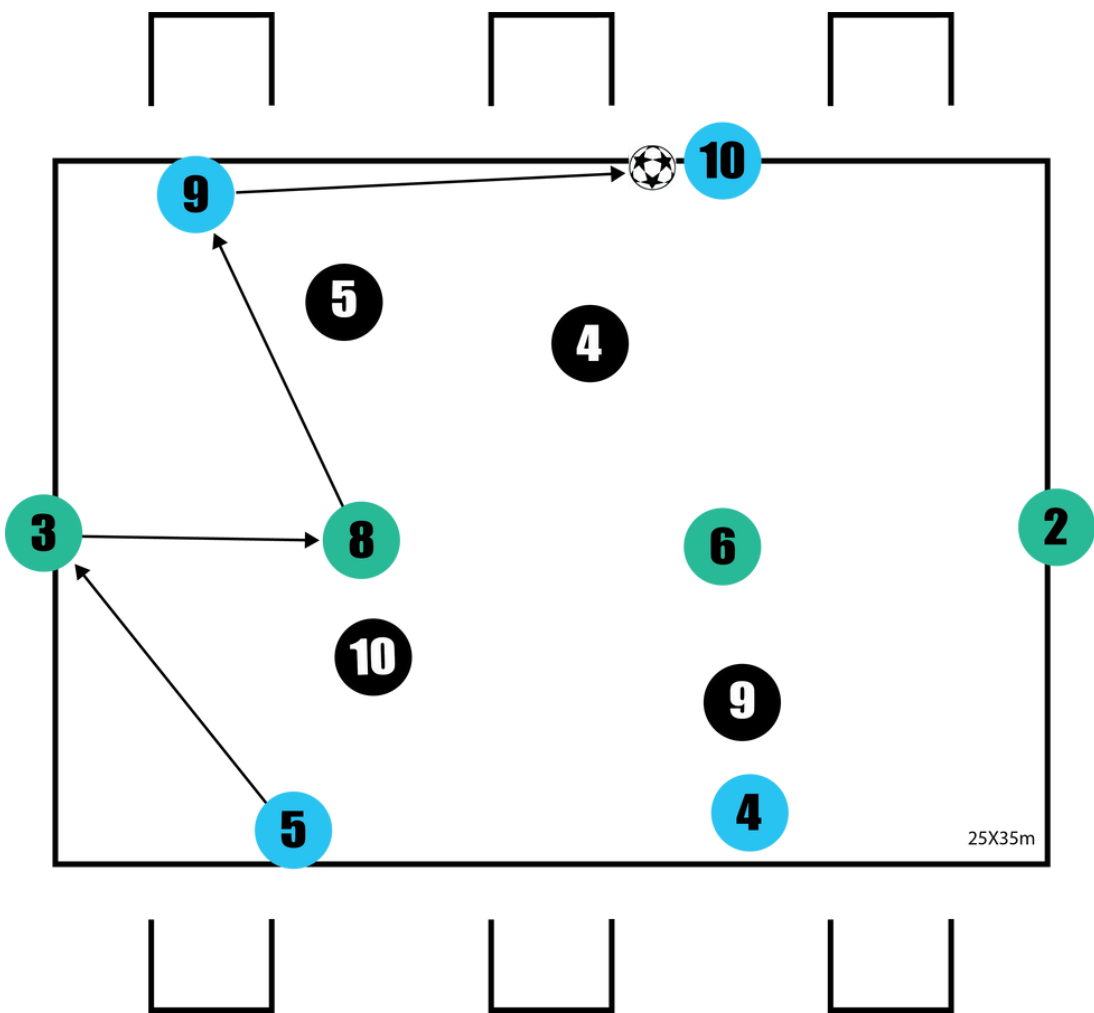


COACHING PROGRESSING VS THE MID-BLOCK IN A 2-4-4 FORMATION I

4 v 4 + 4 POSITIONAL RONDO:

Objective: improving progressions vs the mid-block in a 2-4-2 formation.

Rules: team in possession (blue in the diagram) aim to control the ball and progress it from one end to the other. Neutral players (green) play with the team in possession. Only 2 touches allowed throughout. A point is scored after a sequence of 10 passes in a row including a progression from one end to another. When out of possession team (black in the diagram) recovers the ball, they can score into one of the 6 mini-goals, while the team that lost the possession engages in the immediate counter-pressing effort. If the goal is scored, defending team becomes the team in possession.



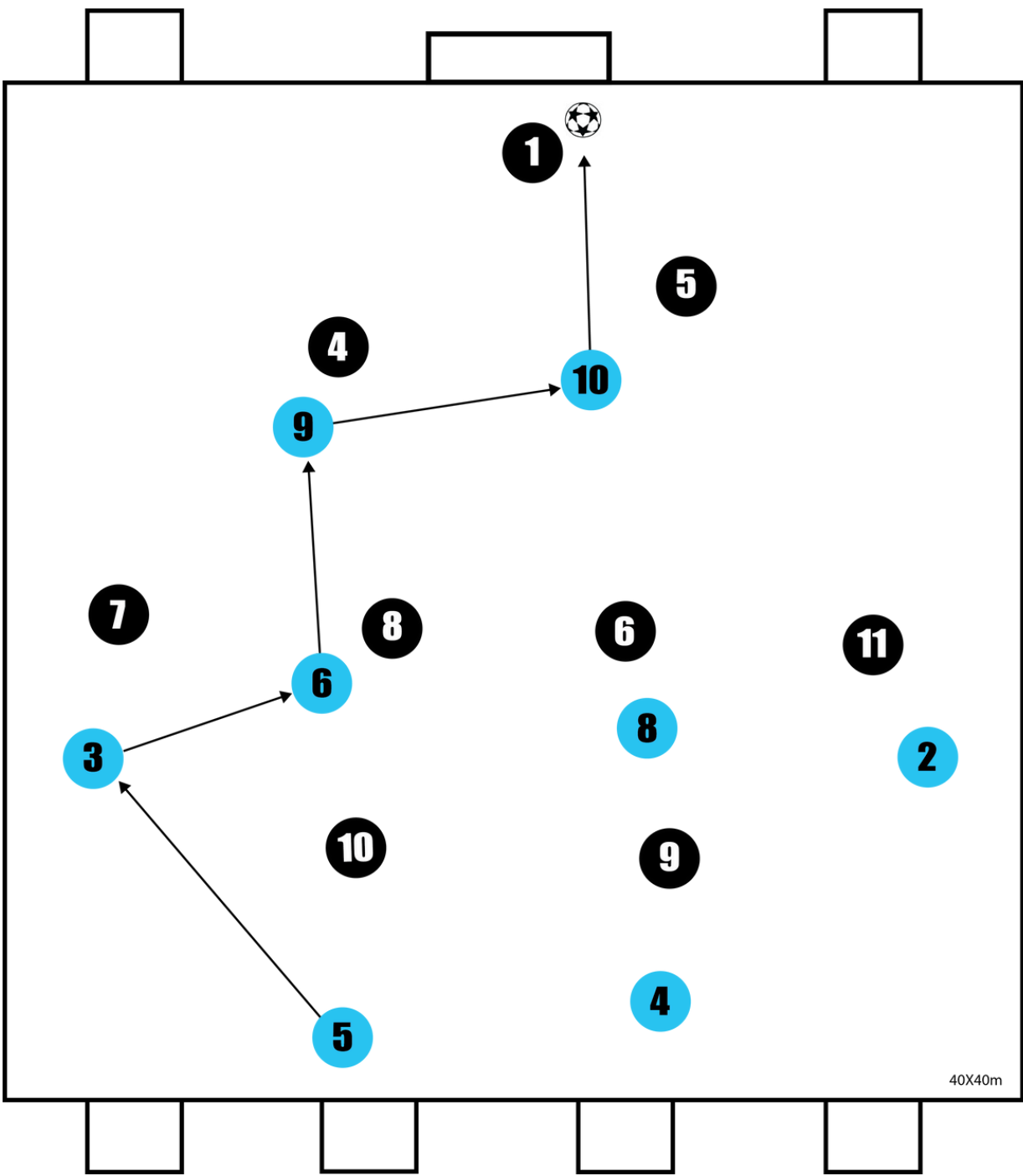
8 v 8 + GK POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: improving progressions vs the mid-block in a 2-4-2 formation.

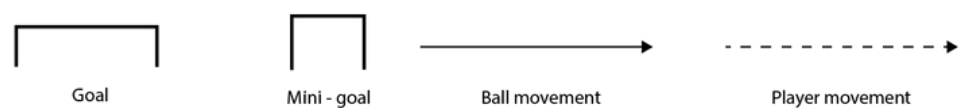
Rules: attacking team (blue) aim to progress through the opposition's defensive block in a 2-4-2 formation and score in one big goal or two mini-goals in the wide areas. Defending team (back) press with intensity in a 2-4-2 defensive shape and has 8 seconds to score into one of the 4 mini-goals when the ball is recovered, while the blue team engages in the immediate counter-pressing effort. Start with unlimited touches and progress to 3 touches max to speed up the play.

COACHING POINTS:

- Understanding Roles: Ensure all players understand their specific roles and responsibilities within the 2-4-2 formation when building up play vs the mid-block.
- Finding the third-man: Encourage players to look for the third-man.
- Invite the pressure: Players must be patient with the ball, inviting the opposition to press by holding possession in deeper areas and creating space higher up the pitch.
- Decision making: Once opposition initiates the press, players must quickly asses the situation and make a decision whether to progress through short passing combinations or play more direct.
- Transitions: Emphasize the need for immediate reaction upon losing or winning the ball. Players should switch their mindset instantly.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING PROGRESSING VS THE MID-BLOCK IN A 2-4-4 FORMATION II

10 v 10 + GK PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

Objective: improving progressing centrally vs the mid-block in a 2-4-4 formation.

Rules: attacking team (blue) aim to progress through the opposition's defensive mid-block and score. Pitch restriction forcing the blue team to progress centrally. Once the ball is played to the forward line, blue team has 8 seconds to score. If the black team recovers the ball, they have 8 seconds to score in one of the 5 mini-goals. When the ball is with the black team, pitch restrictions do not apply. When the ball is lost, blue team immediately initiates the counter-pressing effort.

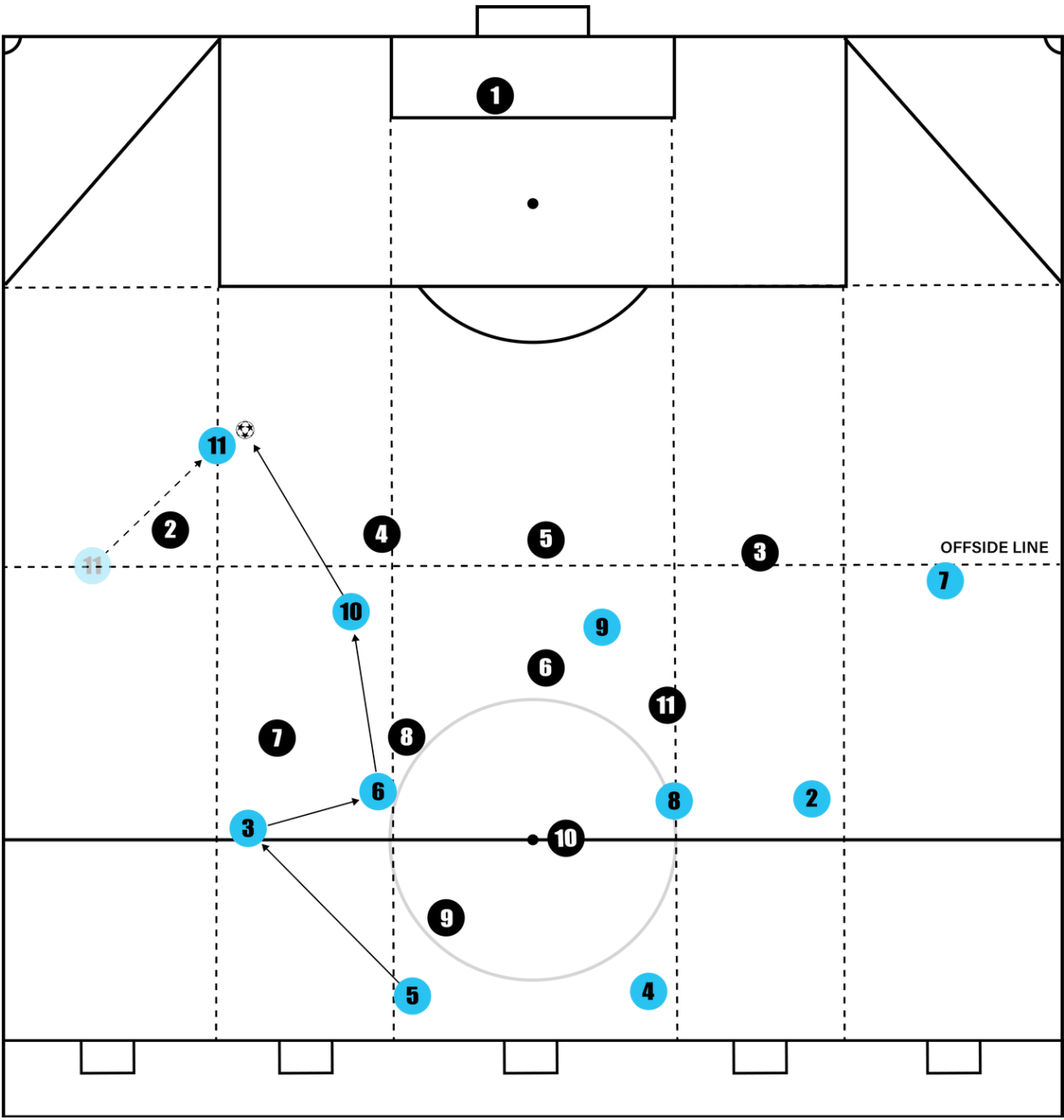
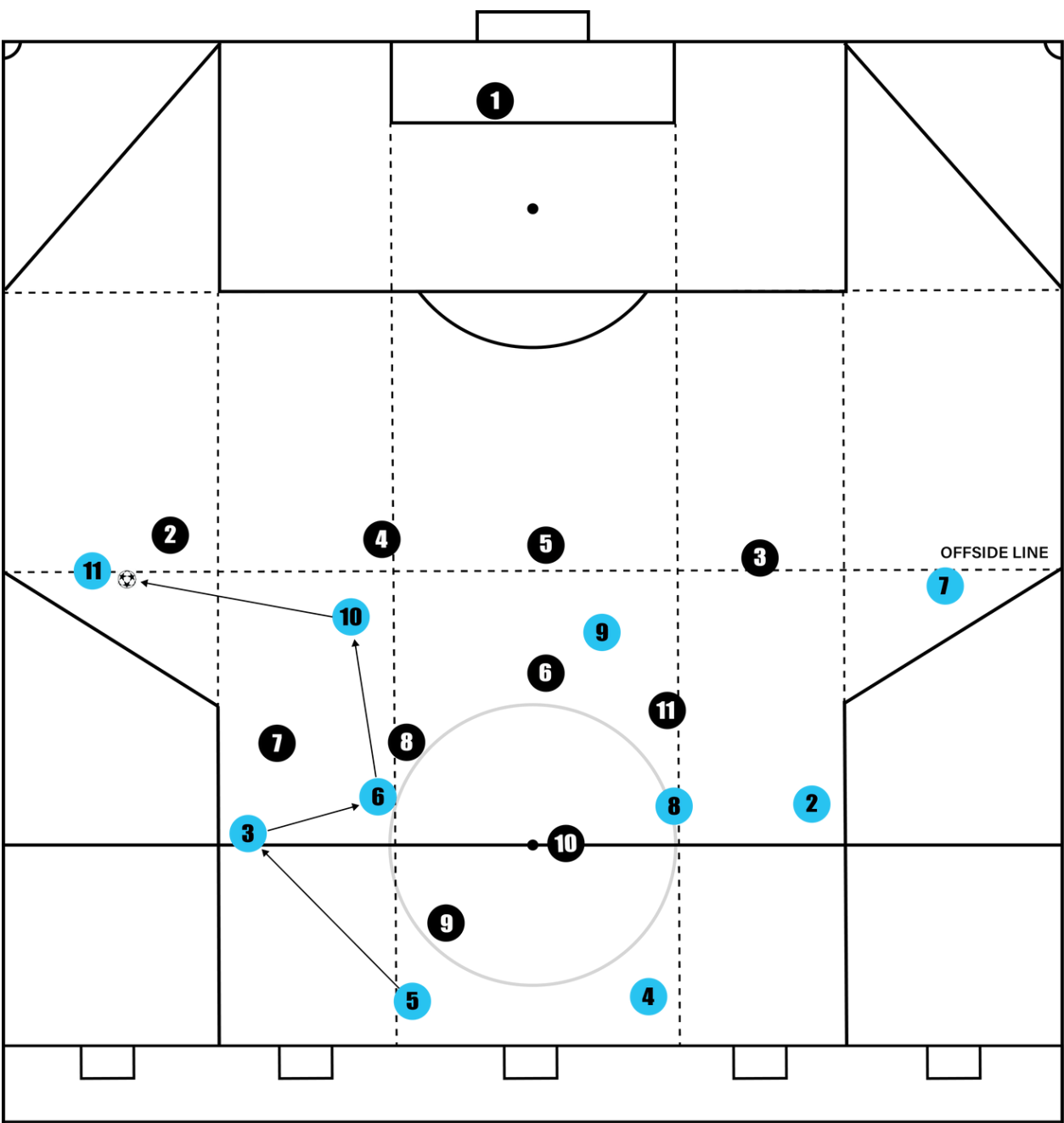
10 v 10 + GK PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

Objective: improving progressions vs the mid-block in a 2-4-4 formation.

Rules: attacking team (blue) aim to progress through the opposition's defensive block in a 2-4-4 formation and score. Once the ball is played to the forward line, blue team has 8 seconds to score. Defending team (black) press with intensity in a 4-4-2 defensive shape and has 8 seconds to score into one of the 5 mini-goals when the ball is recovered, while the blue team engages in the immediate counter-pressing effort.

COACHING POINTS:

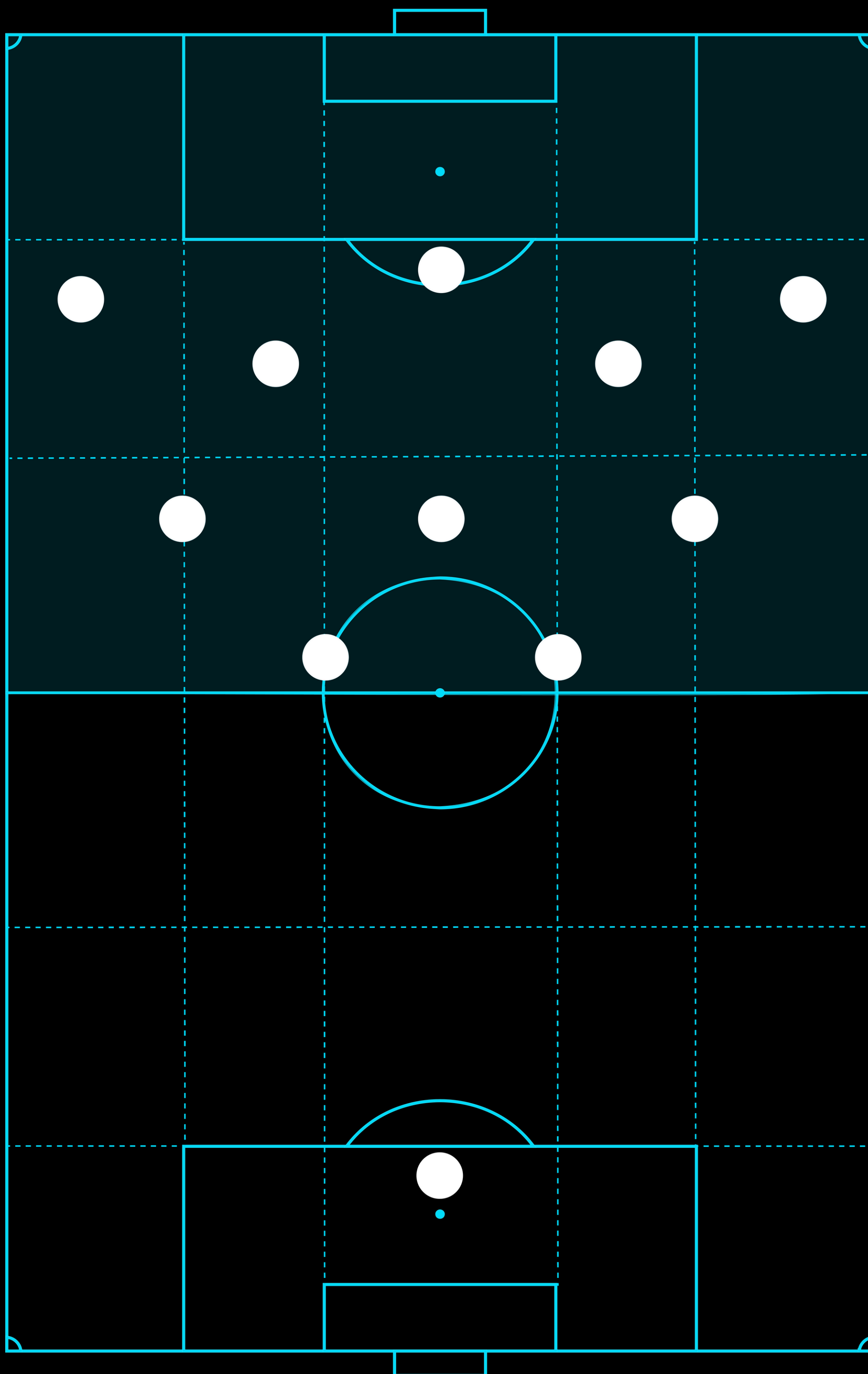
- Combination Play: Encourage the use of one-twos and other combination plays to navigate through tight spaces and disrupt the defensive structure.
- Find Pockets of Space: Midfielders and attackers should position themselves in the spaces between the opposition's midfield and defensive lines to receive the ball.
- Vertical Play: Encourage vertical passes that advance the ball quickly through the lines.
- Runs In-Behind: Players need to time their runs to exploit gaps in the defensive line. Early or late runs can result in offside or missed opportunities.
- Invite the pressure: Players must be patient with the ball, inviting the opposition to press by holding possession in deeper areas and creating space higher up the pitch.
- Transitions: Emphasize the need for immediate reaction upon losing or winning the ball.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



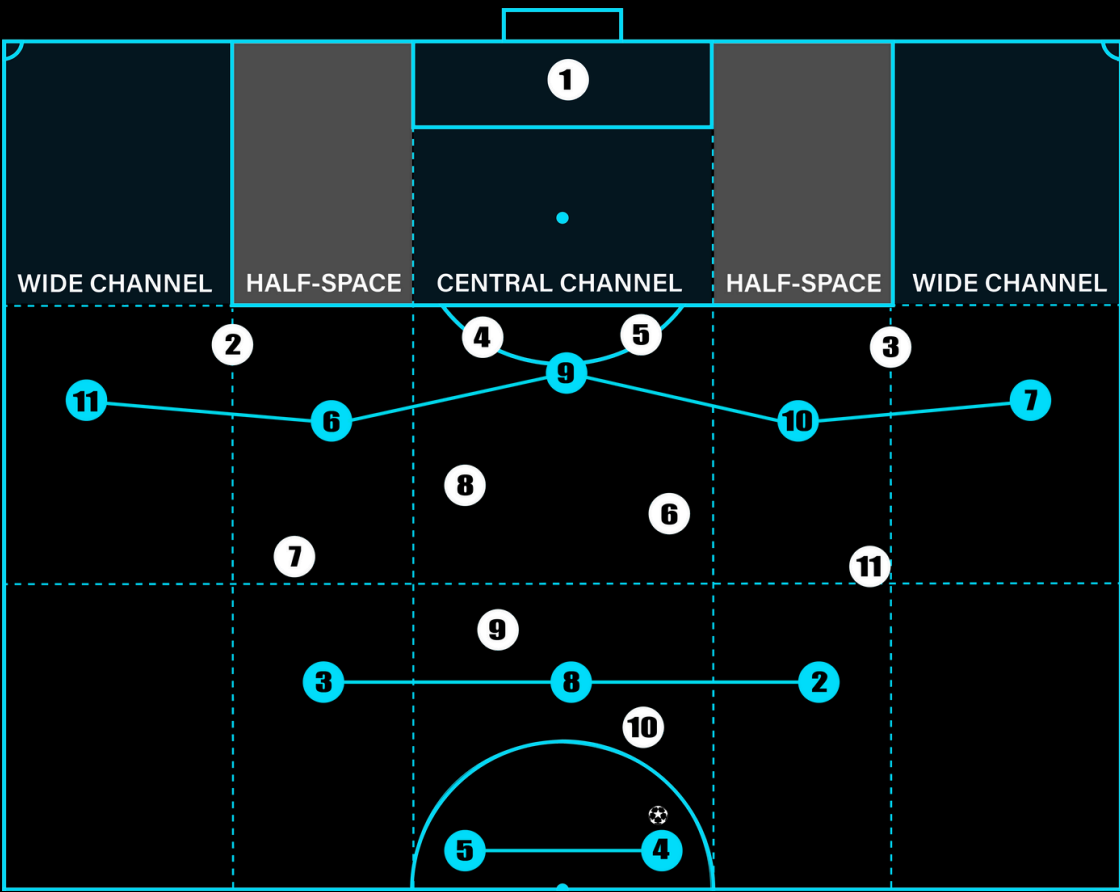
PART III: PLAYING THROUGH THE LOW-BLOCK



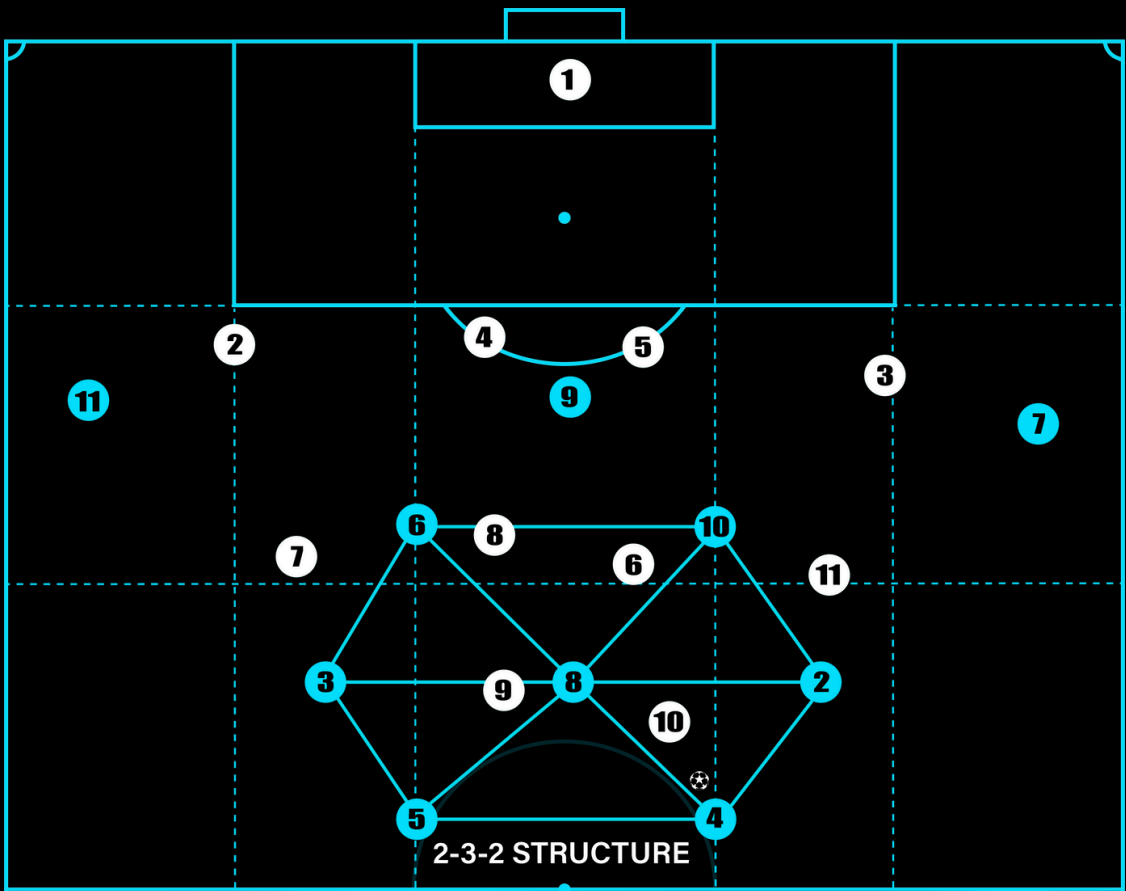
PENETRATING LOW DEFENSIVE BLOCK

De Zerbi’s tactical setup against low blocks emphasizes fluidity, movement, and positional interchanges. His approach not only seeks to exploit the physical spaces within the defense but also to mentally pressure the opposition into making mistakes by constantly challenging their defensive organization and discipline.

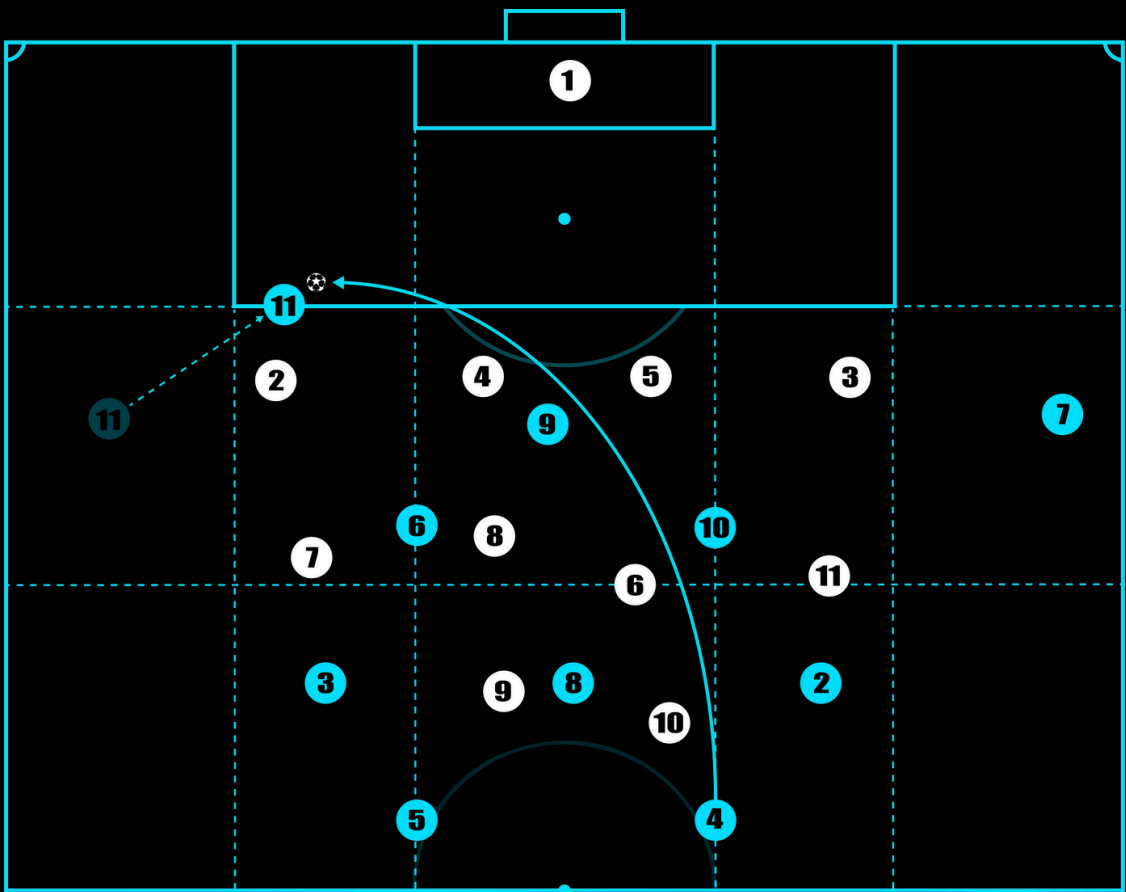
- 2-3-5 Attacking formation: When facing a low block, De Zerbi’s teams often morph into a 2-3-5 during the attacking phase. In most cases (it must be pointed out that different players can occupy different positions in the formation), two full-backs join one defensive midfielder in the midfield line, while second defensive midfielder joins the front 5 in one of the half-spaces. The two center-backs provide security against counter-attacks, while the midfield trio controls the game's tempo and distributes the ball. The five attackers stretch the opposition defense horizontally and vertically, creating and exploiting gaps: Wide players maintain width, pulling the defensive line apart and creating spaces in the central areas. Meanwhile, vertical stretching is achieved through direct runs from deeper positions into these created gaps.
- Central penetration via combinations: The primary option is to try and play through centrally using short passing combinations. The principle of minimum width is again employed. To aid the central combination play 2 attackers positioned in the half-spaces would drop to form a 2-3-2 structure, which facilitates fast, short, intense combinations. These combinations are designed to draw defenders out and disrupt the defensive structure, creating space for penetrating passes or shots from distance. If central progression is successful it will mostly result into a through ball played into one of the attacking players making a run into the gap created.
- Direct passes and runs off the ball: Because opposition is often aware of how effective De Zerbi’s teams can be when penetrating through the central combinations, they focus on defending them, which often creates opportunities higher up the pitch. Center back of midfield line player can opt to play a direct long pass to wide player making a run into half-space, alternatively, wide player can receive in the wide channel and try to penetrate into half-space through dribble or a quick 1-2, once inside the half-space channel, a low-cross would be played in order to find a teammate to finish the move.
- Switching play and circulating the ball: To unbalance and shift a low block, De Zerbi’s teams frequently switch the play from one side of the pitch to the other. This rapid change in the point of attack forces the opposition to adjust their positions quickly, often creating mismatches or moments of disorganization that can be exploited. If there is no good option to penetrate immediately, ball would be circulated until space to penetrate is found.



2-3-5 Attacking formation, with forward line occupying each vertical channel in order to create space and stretch the opposition, while 2-3 structure offers support and cover.



With two attacking midfielders (blue 6 and 10) dropping back from the forward line, 2-3-5 is often transformed into 2-3-2 structure to facilitate quick central combinations.



While opposition is fully focused on stopping central combinations, De Zerbi’s teams do not shy away from playing direct to wingers or forwards, which can often catch opposition off-guard.

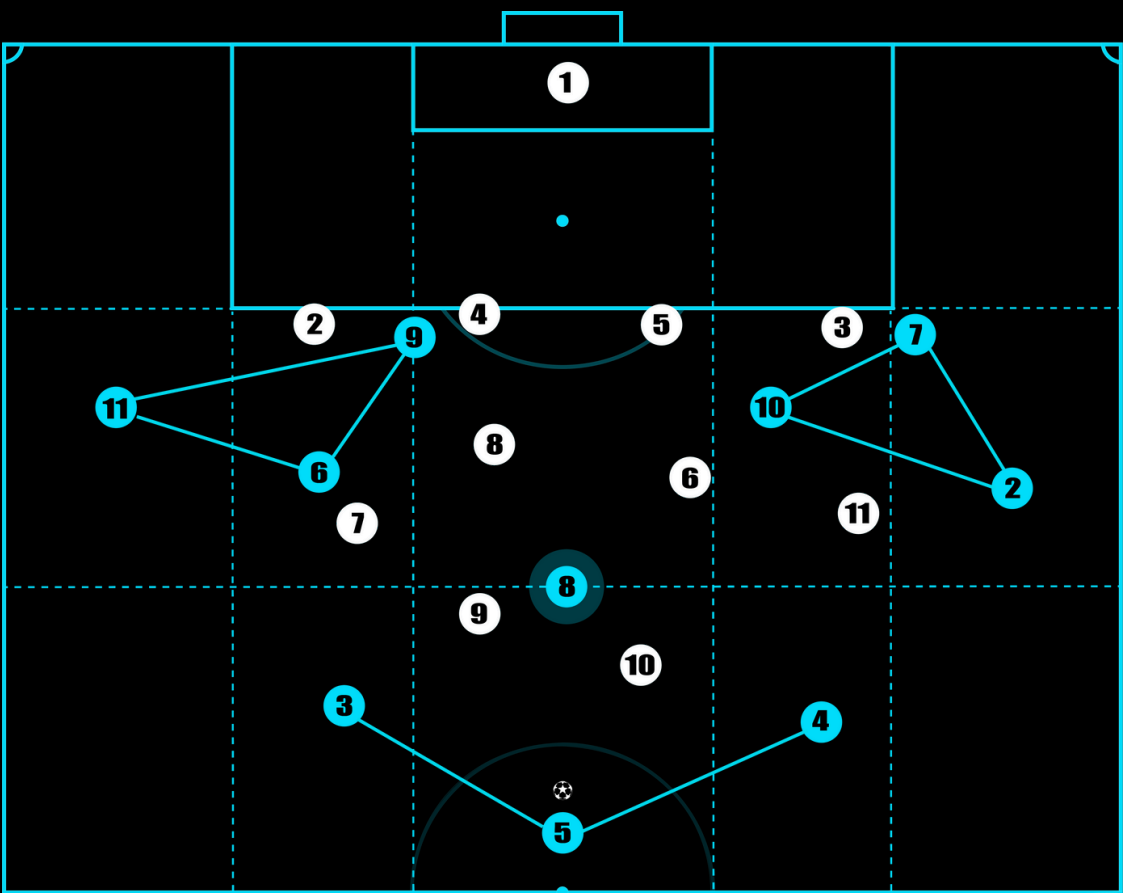
- 3-1-6 Attacking formation: In the later stage of the attack, 2-3-5 formation often transforms into 3-1-6. With one full-back joining 2 center backs in the defensive line to create a back three. This adjustment provides stability and coverage defensively, allowing the other players to focus more aggressively on the attack. While 1 defensive midfielder drops slightly deeper, centrally located to orchestrate play, distribute the ball effectively, and cover defensively if needed. This role is crucial for maintaining the balance between defense and attack. 6 attacking players form 2 wide triangles, each positioned to maximize width and create multiple angles of attack and support. Wide triangles are highly dynamic, with all players constantly on the move in order to find gaps in the opposition's defensive block.

- Wide overloads to penetrate into half-spaces: Wide triangles help create wide overloads with an aim of penetrating into half-spaces. The focus on half-spaces — the areas between the central defenders and full-backs — is critical. These areas often become vulnerable when the defense shifts to manage the wide overloads. Penetrating these spaces allows for cut-ins, through balls, and intricate plays that can break the defensive alignment. With the increased presence on the flanks, the use of varied crosses — from deep, whipped crosses to low cutbacks — becomes a primary tool in De Zerbi's strategy against low blocks. These are aimed at meeting late runs from midfielders or the forwards peeling off their markers.

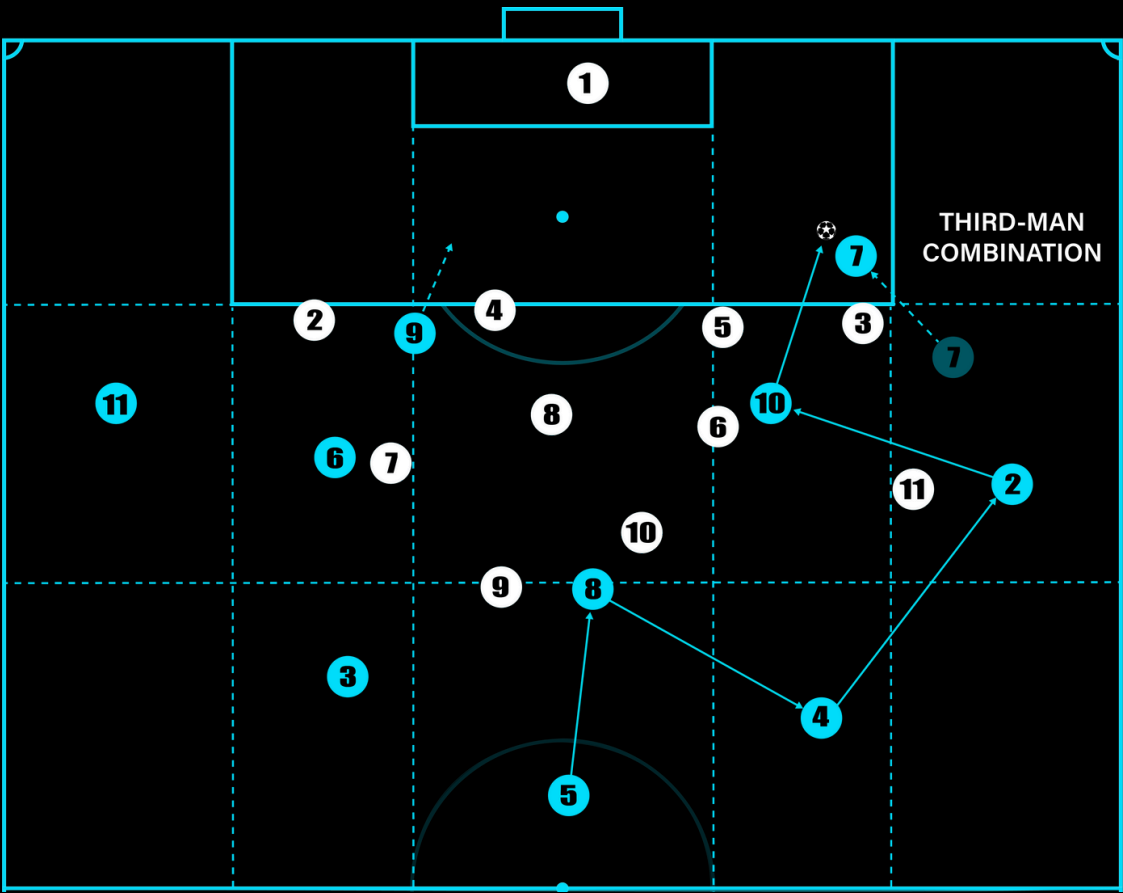
- Third-Man Runs: De Zerbi employs third-man running tactics where one player passes the ball and immediately moves into space to receive it back or to distract defenders, allowing another player to exploit the space created. This is particularly effective in tight spaces against a low block as it requires rapid response from defenders, often leading to missteps or delayed reactions. Third-man combinations are being used extensively when penetrating the low defensive block.

- Overlapping and Under-lapping Runs: Both full-backs and wingers engage in overlapping (running outside the winger) or under-lapping (running inside the winger) runs. These movements increase the confusion and decision-making burden on defenders, stretching them further and creating more opportunities for penetrative crosses and cutbacks.

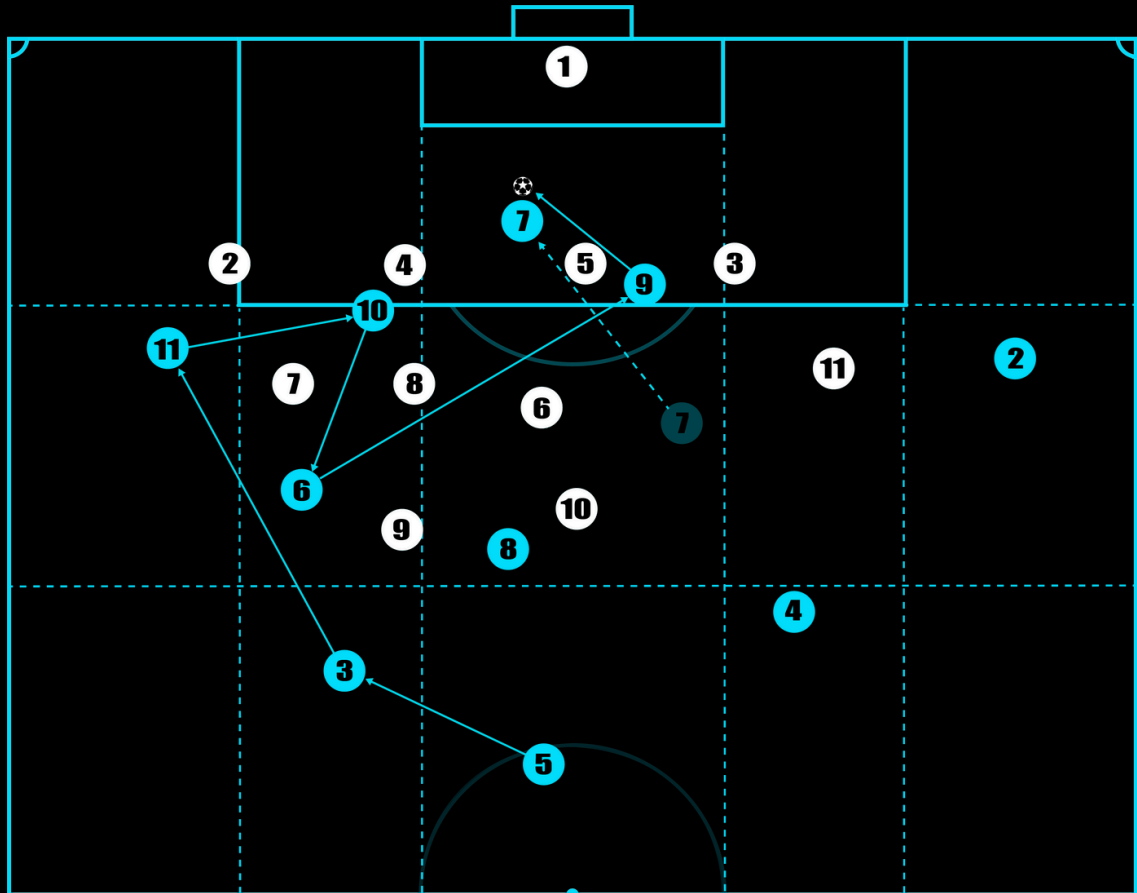
- Wide overloads create central opportunities: The continuous lateral and vertical stretching forces the opposition into uncomfortable defensive transitions, often leading to gaps in the defensive structure or misalignment that skilled attackers can exploit. As the defensive unit shifts to counter the wide overloads, central channels can open up. The attacking midfielders or the false 9, positioned to exploit these central gaps, can receive the ball in dangerous areas, allowing them to either shoot on goal or play decisive passes to penetrate the box further.



In the later stages of the attack 2-3-5 formation often transforms into 3-1-6 formation, with 6 players in the forward line often forming triangular structures in the wide areas.



Once the ball is played into wide areas, third-man combinations are often used to penetrate into the penalty box through half-space channels. Centrally located players (blue 9 in this instance) making runs into the box expecting a cross.



Overloading wide areas often creates space in the central channel. Blue 6 passes the ball to blue 9, who then plays a one-touch pass to blue 7 making a run from the deep, which puts him into one v one situation with the goalkeeper. When executed with speed, these type of third-man combinations are extremely hard to stop.

COACHING ATTACKING PATTERNS WHEN PLAYING AGAINST A LOW DEFENSIVE BLOCK

8 v 4 + GK CENTRAL PATTERN PLAY:

Objective: improving central attacking patterns of play vs the low defensive block.

Rules: game starts with left-back blue 3 passing the ball forward to midfielder blue 8, who then plays it back to midfielder blue 6. Blue 6 plays it vertical to striker blue 9 who then lays it off to blue 8. Once the blue 8 has the ball he has the freedom to choose the next passing option, with the rest of the attacking players making runs into the box. Defending team (black) play in 2-2 formation, with midfielders (black 6 and 8) applying pressure to blue 3, 6 and 2, while central defenders (black 4 and 5) trying to prevent the goal being scored.

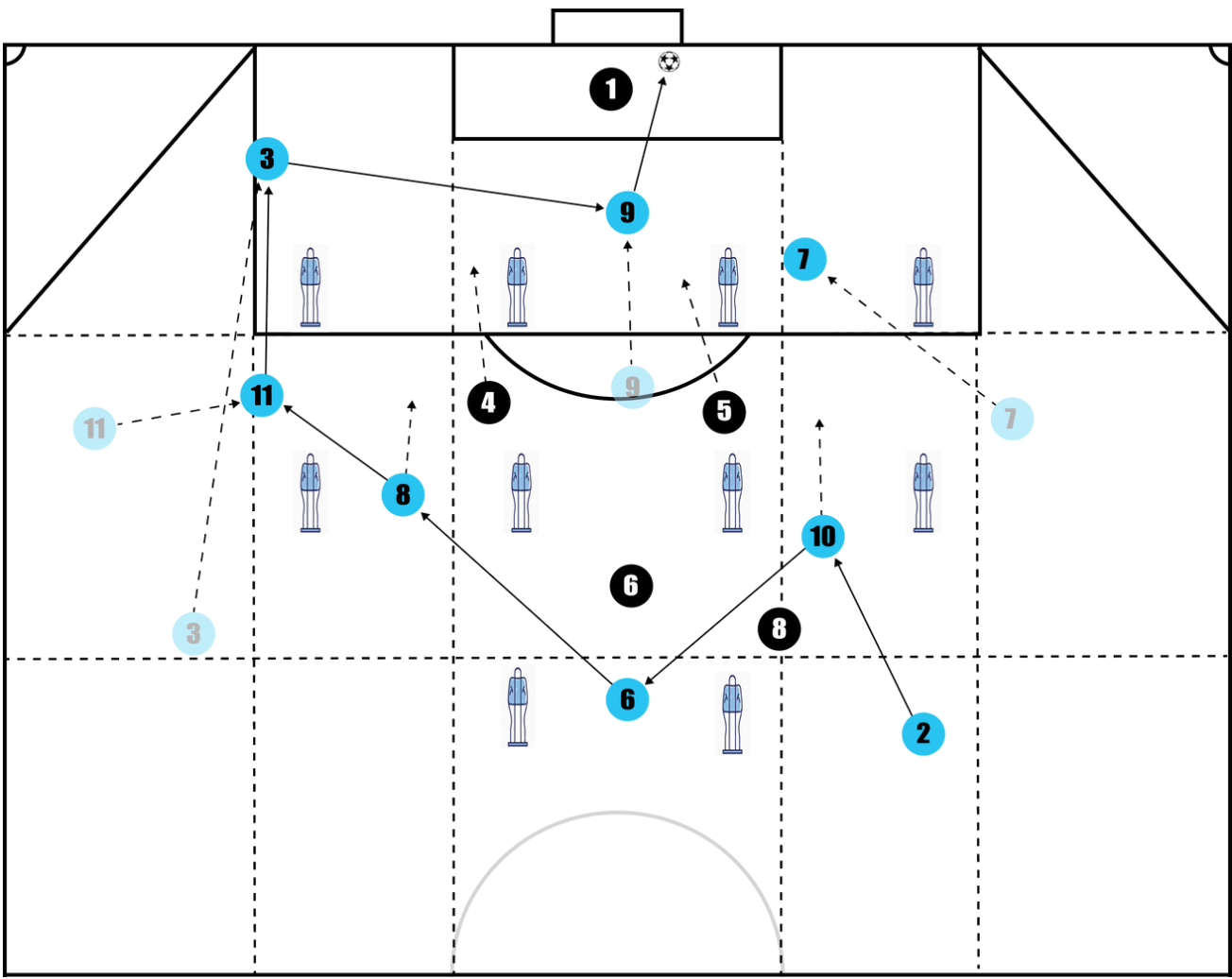
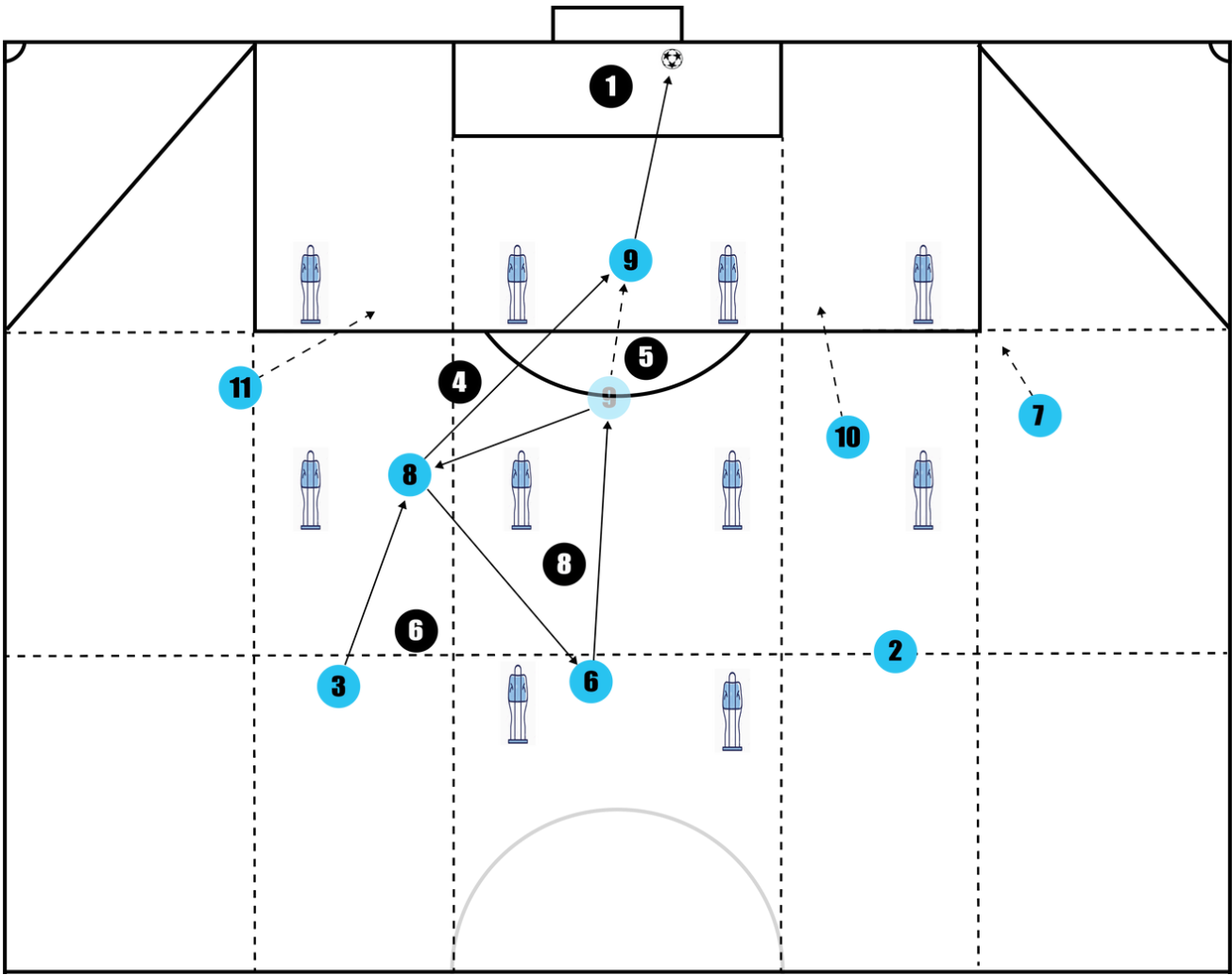
8 v 4 + GK WIDE PATTERN PLAY:

Objective: improving wide attacking patterns of play vs the low defensive block.

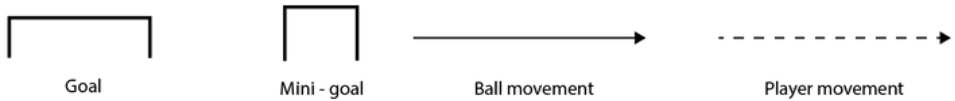
Rules: game starts with right-back blue 2 playing the ball forward to blue 10, blue 10 lays it of to midfielder blue 6, blue 6 plays a diagonal pass to midfielder blue 8. Blue 8 plays a pass to left winger blue 11 while left-back blue 3 is making an overlapping run. Blue 11 makes a pass to overlapping left-back blue 3 with the rest of the players making runs into the box. Defending team (black) play in 2-2 formation, with midfielders (black 6 and 8) applying pressure to blue 2, 6 and 10, while central defenders (black 4 and 5) trying to prevent the goal being scored.

COACHING POINTS:

- Quick, Accurate Passing: Emphasize the importance of quick, precise passes to move the ball effectively and exploit defensive gaps.
- Off-the-Ball Movement: Encourage players to make intelligent runs to create space and passing options. This includes diagonal runs, overlapping runs, and runs in behind the defense.
- Composure in Front of Goal: Train players to stay composed and make the right decisions in front of goal, whether it's a shot, a pass, or a cutback.
- Quality Crosses: Practice delivering accurate crosses from wide areas, varying between low driven balls, cutbacks, and lofted crosses.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING PENETRATING A LOW BLOCK IN A 2-3-5 FORMATION

8 v 8 + GK POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: improving attacking play vs the low defensive block when penetrating centrally in a 3-5 formation.

Rules: game starts with attacking team (blue) in possession of the ball in a 3-5 formation. The aim is to penetrate the low defensive block and score. Defending team (black) line up in a 4-4 formation and have 6 seconds to score after recovering the ball. If/when blue team losses possession they immediately engage in a counter-pressing effort. Offside rule applies after the offside line is crossed.

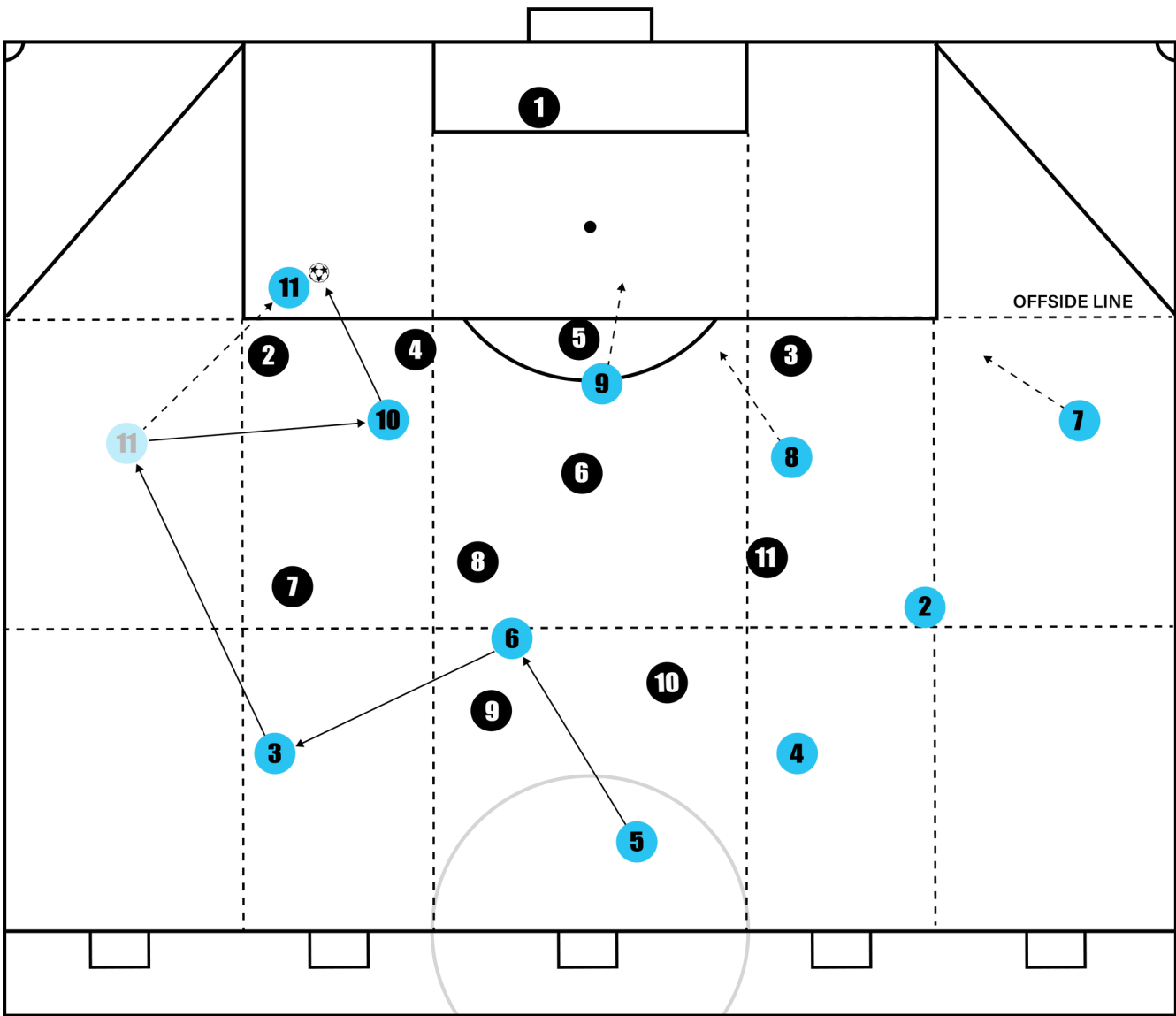
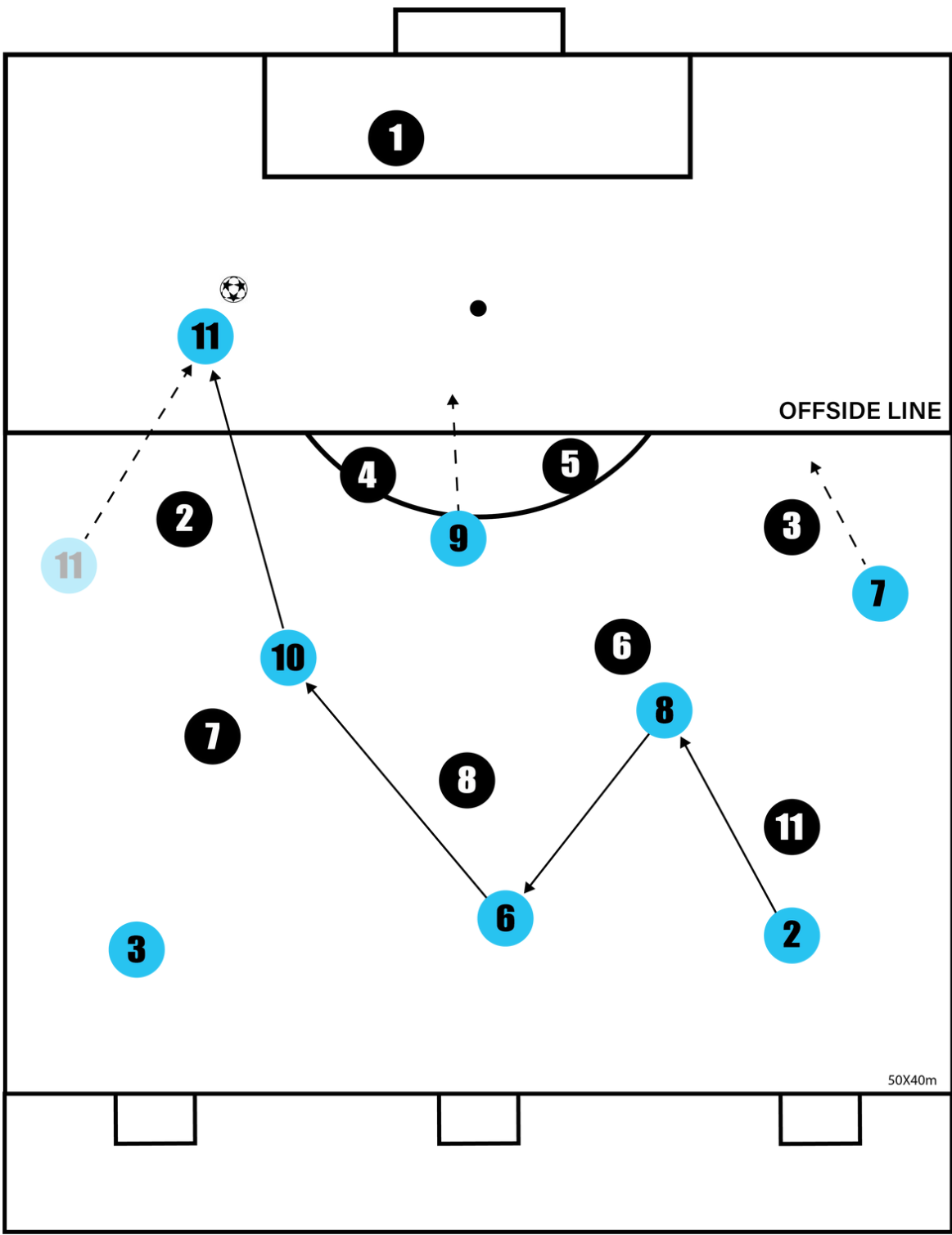
10 v 11 + GK PHASE OF PLAY GAME:

Objective: improving attacking play vs the low defensive block when penetrating centrally in a 2-3-5 formation.

Rules: game starts with attacking team (blue) in possession of the ball in a 2-3-5 formation. The aim is to penetrate the low defensive block and score. Pitch restriction forcing the attacking team to attack centrally, focusing on penetrating through half-spaces and cut-back crosses. Defending team (black) line up in a 4-4-2 formation and have 8 seconds to score after recovering the ball. If/when blue team losses possession they immediately engage in a counter-pressing effort. Offside rule applies after the offside line is crossed.

COACHING POINTS:

- Combination Play: Encourage the use of one-twos and other combination plays to navigate through tight spaces and disrupt the defensive structure. Use “up, back, through” combinations.
- Find Pockets of Space: Midfielders and attackers should position themselves in the spaces between the opposition’s midfield and defensive lines to receive the ball.
- Encourage dribbling: Dribble to draw multiple defenders, creating numerical superiority for teammates in other areas.
- Vertical Play: Encourage vertical passes that advance the ball quickly through the lines.
- Runs In-Behind: Players need to time their runs to exploit gaps in the defensive line.
- Quality Crosses: accurate crosses varying between low driven balls, cutbacks, and lofted crosses.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING COUNTER-ATTACKING AFTER HIGH TURNOVERS

5 v 5 + GK COUNTER-ATTACKING GAME:

Objective: improving the forward line’s counter-attacking play after the high turnovers.

Rules: game starts with black 6 passing the ball to blue 8, after which the blue team have 8 seconds to score, which forces them to act quickly. Pitch restriction forcing the counter-attack centrally. If the black team recovers the ball they have 8 seconds to score in one of the 5 mini-goals, while the blue team initiates the counter-pressing effort. Offside rule applies.

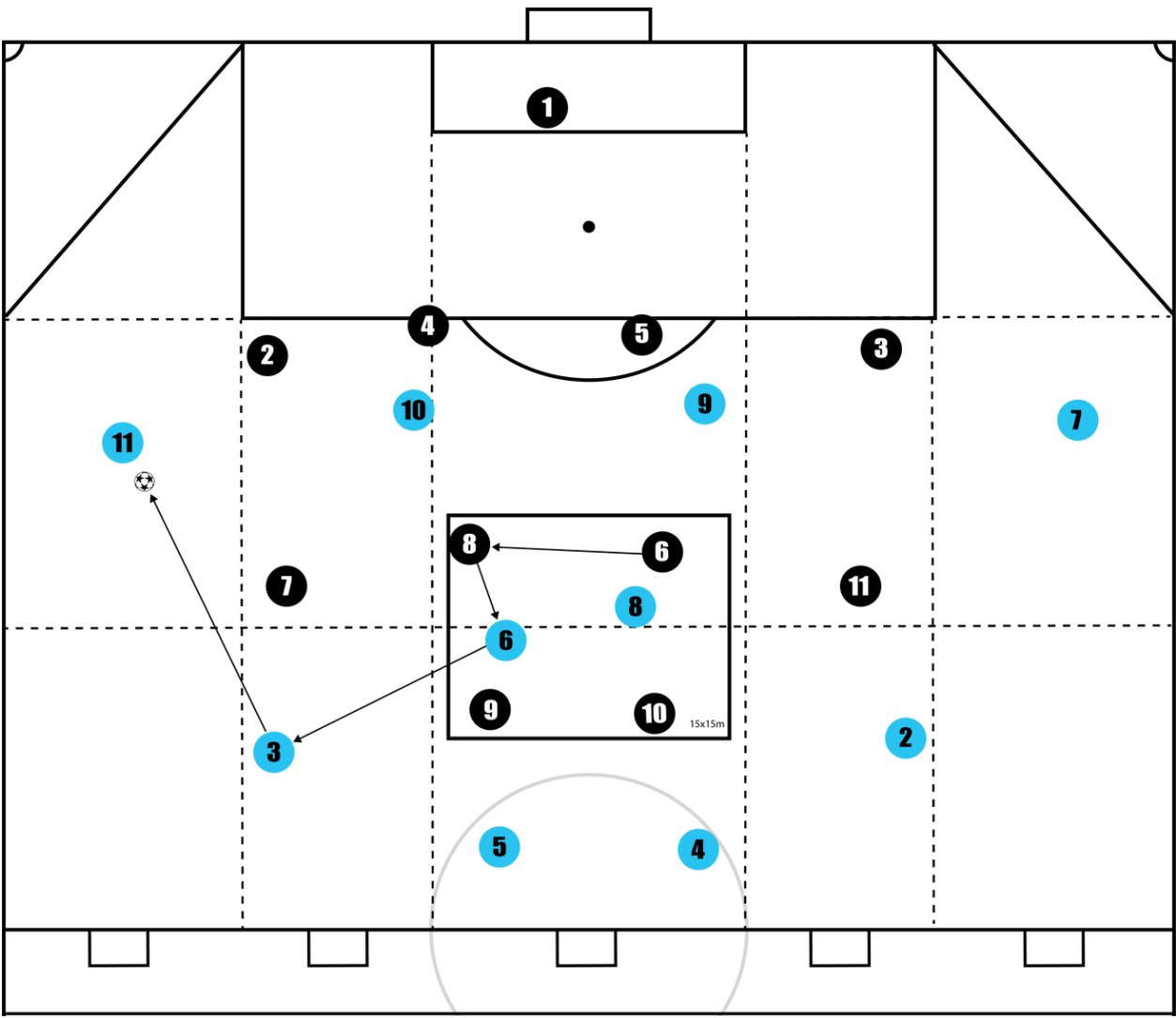
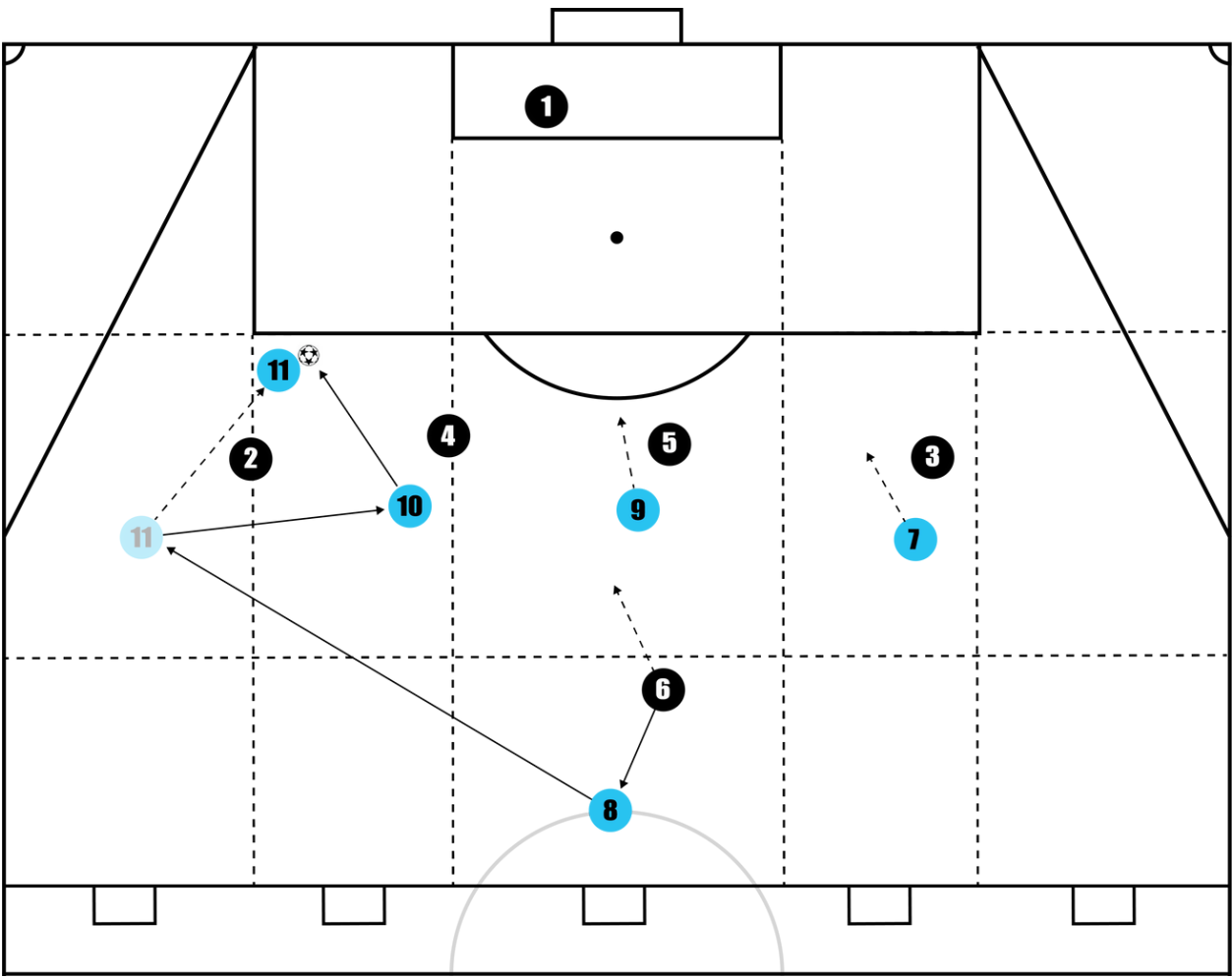
10 v 10 + GK BREAK OUT AND COUNTER GAME:

Objective: improving team’s counter-attacking play after the high turnovers.

Rules: game starts with the black team in possession of the ball in a 4 v 2 rondo. Once the blue players recover the ball, they have 10 seconds to score the goal. Pitch restrictions forcing the counter-attack centrally. If the black team recovers the ball they have 8 seconds to score in one of the 5 mini-goals, while the blue team initiates the counter-pressing effort. Offside rule applies.

COACHING POINTS:

- Quick Decision Making: Instill the need for fast decision-making to capitalize on the opponent's disorganization following a turnover. Players must quickly transition from defense to attack as soon as possession is regained, with an emphasis on rapid response and movement.
- Occupying Key Zones: Players should position themselves in spaces that exploit gaps in the opposition’s defense, especially between the lines.
- Combination Play: Encourage the use of one-twos and other combination plays.
- Supporting Runs: Midfielders and defenders should support the attack by offering passing options.
- Draw Defenders In: Ball carriers should drive at defenders to commit them, creating space for teammates. Emphasize the importance of releasing the ball at the right moment to teammates who have moved into the created space.
- Runs In-Behind: Players need to time their runs to exploit gaps in the defensive line.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING PENETRATING THE BOX USING “UP, BACK, OVER” COMBINATION

6 v 2 + GK PATTERN PLAY GAME:

Objective: improving penetrating the box using “up, back, over” combination.

Rules: game starts with the attacking team (blue) in possession of the ball. Defensive midfielder (blue 6) plays the ball to striker (blue 9), who then lays it off to one of the attacking midfielders (blue 10 or blue 8). Once midfielders receive the ball they play a one touch lobbed pass inside the box, while wingers (blue 11 and blue 7) make runs inside the box. Once the ball is played into the box 2 defending center-backs become active, moving inside the box and trying to prevent the goal being scored. Winger can either score or pass to teammates making supporting runs inside the box. Offside rule applies.

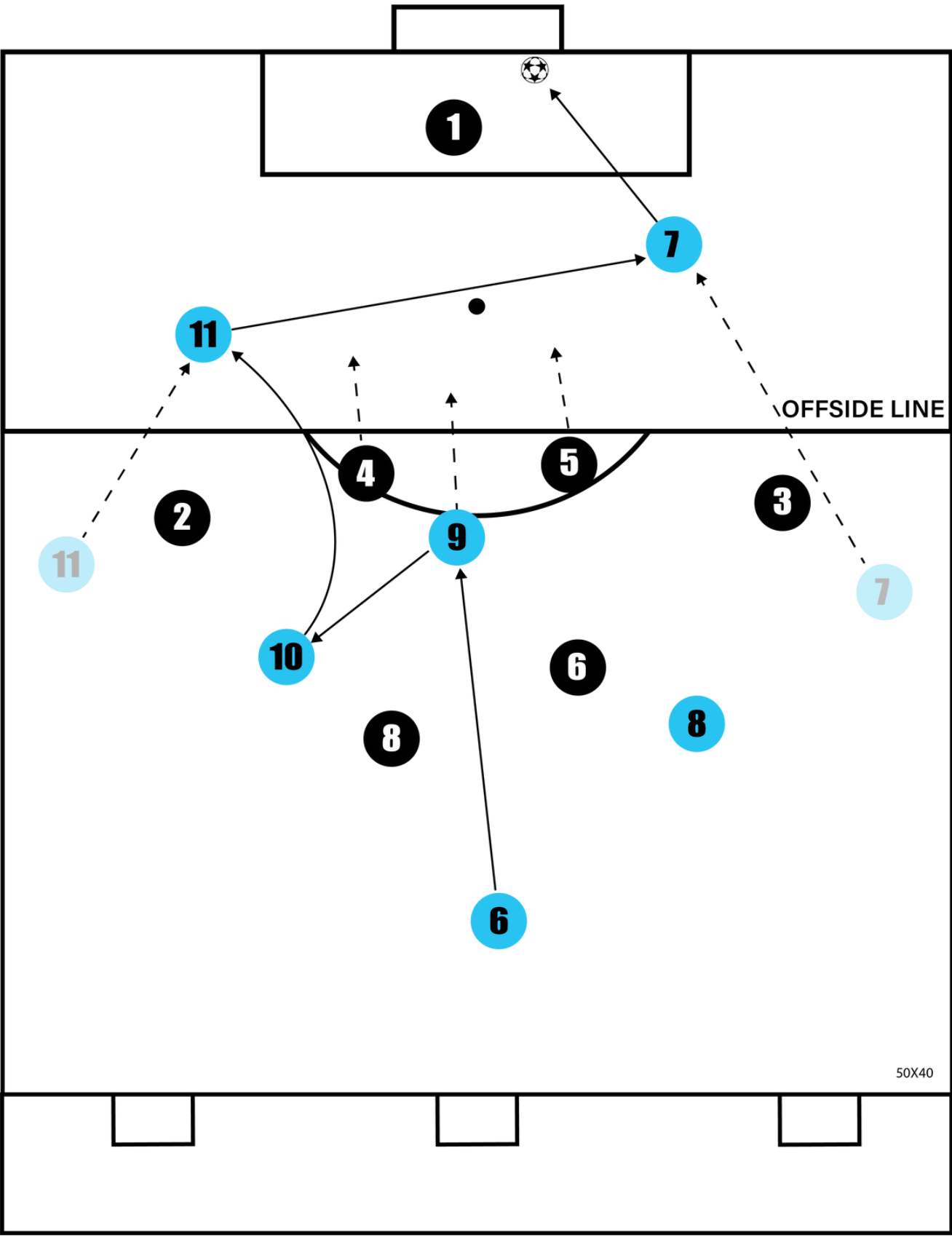
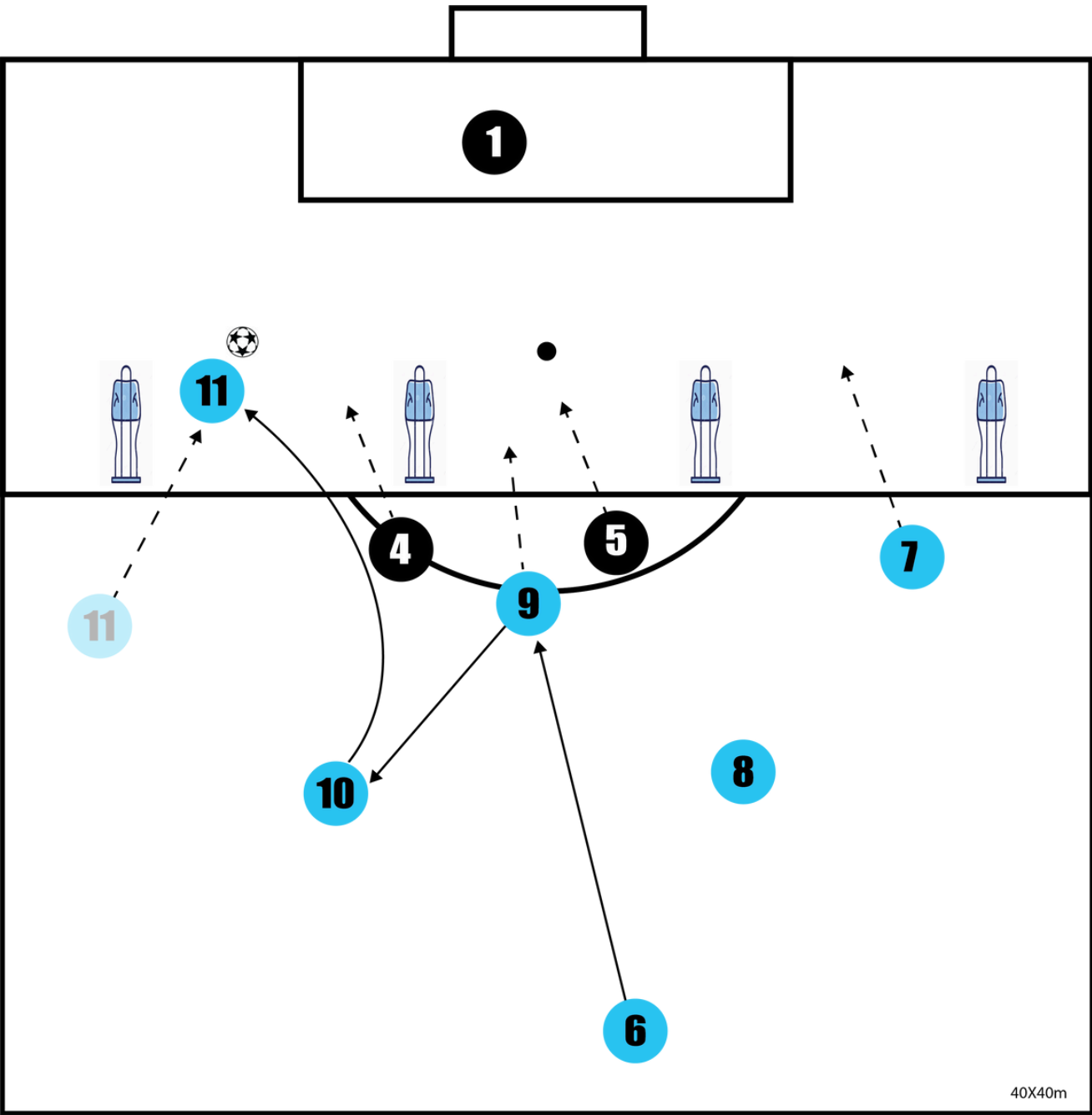
6 v 6 + GK POSITIONAL GAME:

Objective: improving penetrating the box using attacking combination.

Rules: game starts with the attacking team (blue) in possession of the ball with an aim of penetrating inside the box and scoring. If the blue team scores a goal, 1 point is awarded. If the goal is scored after “up, back, through” combination, 2 points are awarded. If the goal is scored after “up, back, over” 3 points are awarded. Defending team (black) trying to prevent from the goal being scored, once they recover the ball they have 5 seconds to score in one of the 3 mini-goals. Offside rule for attacking team applies once inside the box.

COACHING POINTS:

- Movement: Encourage constant movement to lose markers and find space.
- Combination Play: Encourage the use of one-twos and other combination plays to navigate through tight spaces and disrupt the defensive structure.
- Encourage dribbling: Dribble to draw multiple defenders, creating numerical superiority for teammates in other areas.
- Vertical Play: Encourage vertical passes that advance the ball quickly through the lines.
- Runs In-Behind: Players need to time their runs to exploit gaps in the defensive line.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.



COACHING FINISHING INSIDE THE BOX

7 v 7 SMALL SIDED GAME:

Objective: improving finishing inside the box from wide areas.

Rules: two teams play in high tempo with an aim of scoring as many goals as possible. Goal can only be scored after a cross from wingers positioned in wide grids (black/blue 7 and 11). Wingers must stay inside their grids throughout. Offside rule applies.

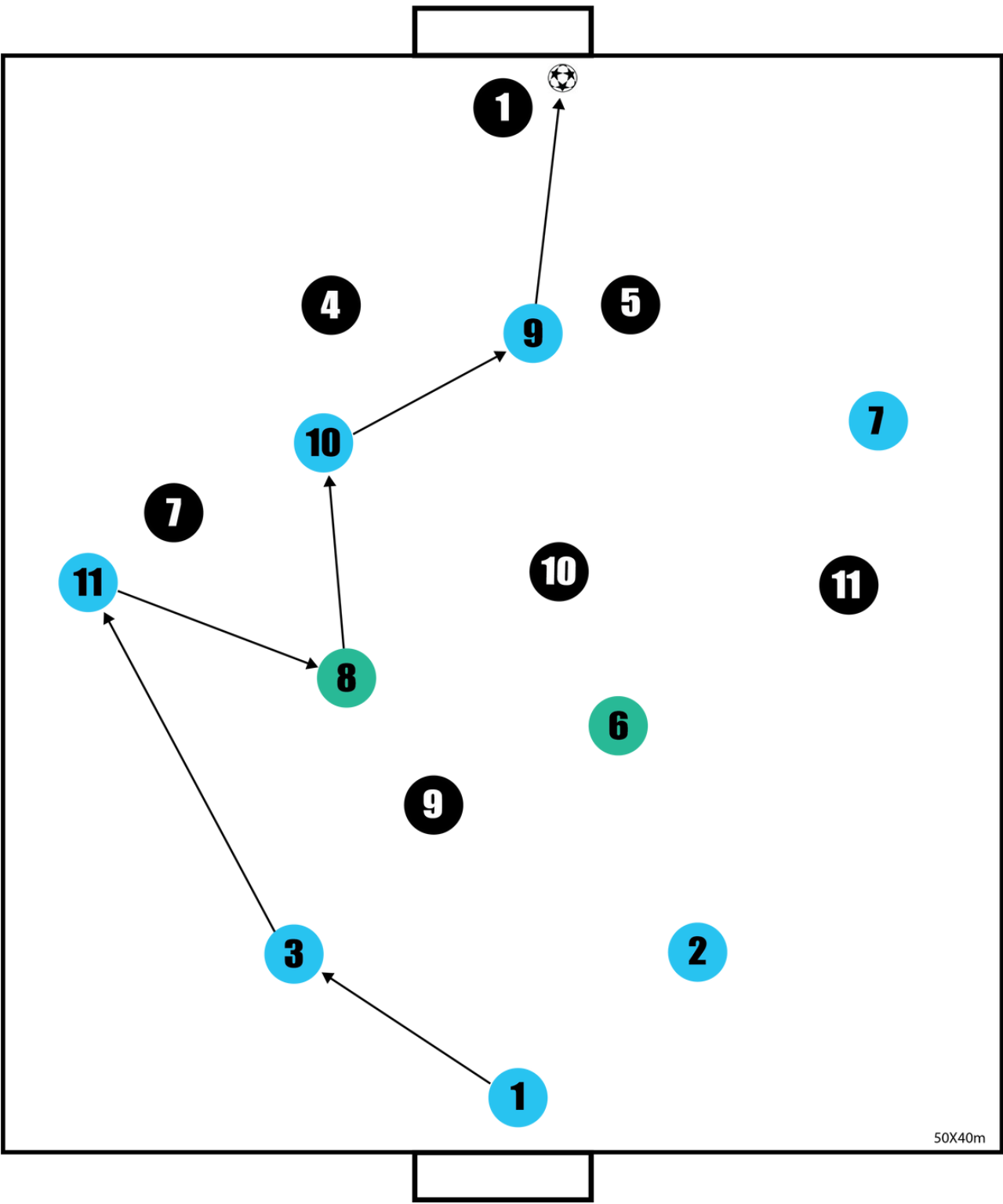
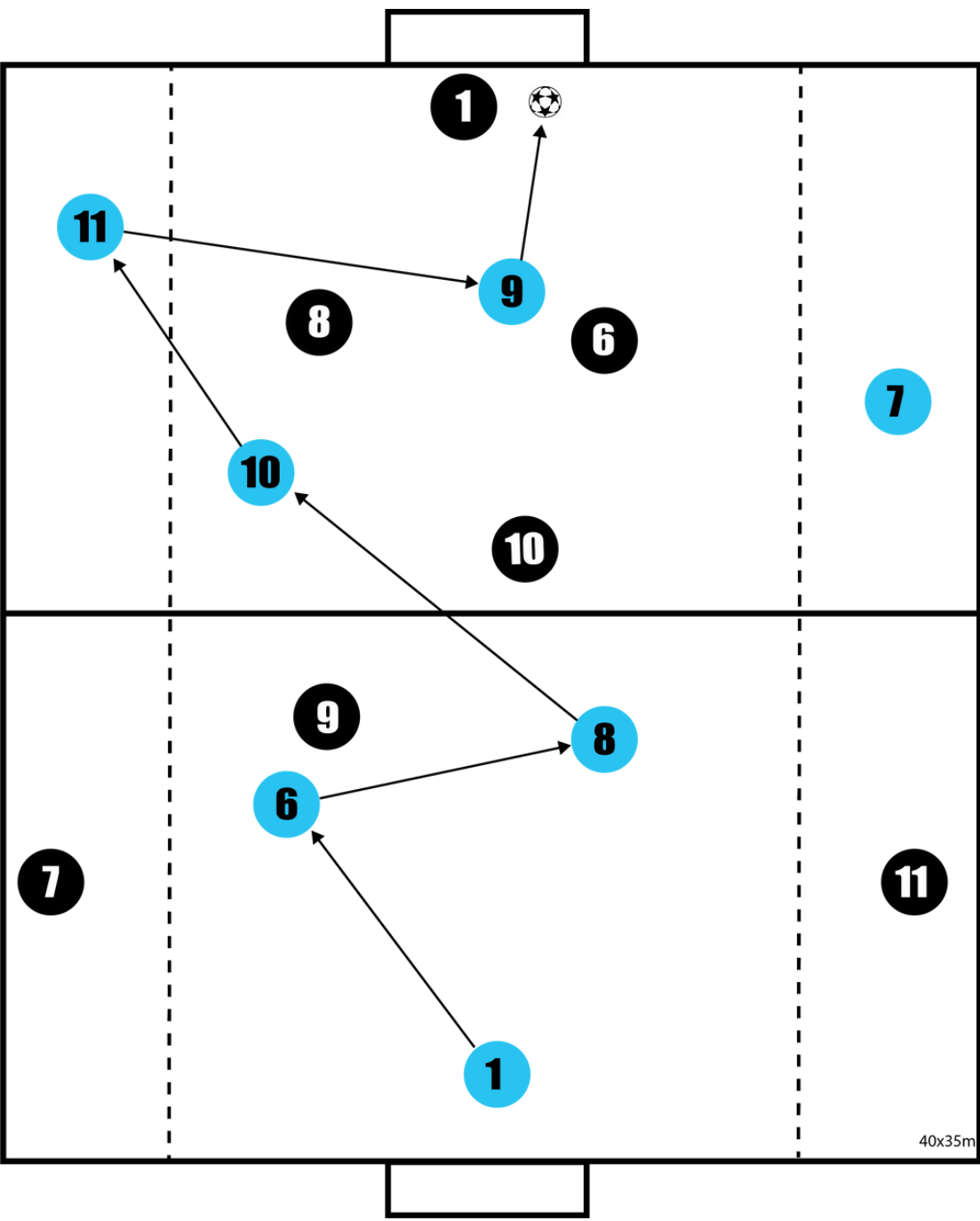
7 v 7 + 2 SMALL SIDED GAME:

Objective: improving finishing inside the box.

Rules: two teams play in high tempo with an aim of scoring as many goals as possible. Game has a natural flow to it. Neutral players (green 6 and 8) play with the team in possession of the ball and have 2 touches max. Teams to engage in immediate counter-pressing effort after losing possession. Offside rule applies.

COACHING POINTS:

- Game Intensity: Maintain a high tempo to replicate match conditions, with quick transitions and constant pressure.
- Movement: Encourage constant movement to lose markers and find space. Players should make runs to the near post, far post, and drop back for cutbacks.
- Combination Play: Encourage the use of one-twos and other combination plays to navigate through tight spaces and disrupt the defensive structure.
- Encourage dribbling: Dribble to draw multiple defenders, creating numerical superiority for teammates in other areas.
- Vertical Play: Encourage vertical passes that advance the ball quickly through the lines.
- Runs In-Behind: Players need to time their runs to exploit gaps in the defensive line.
- Composure in Front of Goal: Train players to stay composed and make the right decisions in front of goal, whether it's a shot, a pass, or a cutback.
- Transitions: Emphasize the need for immediate reaction upon losing or winning the ball.



Adjust size of the play area according to players abilities and objectives of the session.





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